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JOSEPH NICHOLAS

The Paternoster IMPOSTER



THE
PATERNOSTER
IMPOSTER

JOSEPH NICHOLAS

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

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PATERNOSTER

noun

pa·ter·nos·ter

1: often capitalized: LORD'S PRAYER

2: a word formula repeated as a prayer or magical charm.

- *Merriam-Webster.com Dictionary*, Merriam-Webster,
<https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/paternoster>

PROLOGUE

In February 1798, France declared war on the Vatican. Giovanni Angelo Braschi had reigned for twenty-three years as Pope Pius VI. At the age of eighty, he was neither frail nor sickly. To all who knew him, he did in fact seem younger and stronger than a man of so many years.

Braschi held his spyglass with a steady hand and watched from his window as the French general, Louis-Alexandre Berthier, and his army marched through Saint Peter's Square.

"We prevailed in our lawsuit for peace, and yet they halt not," Braschi remarked.

"Yes, Your Holiness," the Cardinal Secretary of State replied.

Braschi continued to observe, seemingly detached, as the invading army entered the Vatican and arrested his cardinals. He paced to the corner of the room near the fireplace, where a birdcage stood housing his pet doves. He reached into the cage and carefully removed two of the peaceful creatures. Holding them gently in his cupped hands, he walked back to the window and released them.

Braschi closed the window and reflected as he watched the birds disappear from sight. He heard the approaching footsteps of General Berthier and his soldiers. The doors of the Pope's apartment burst open, and Berthier and his officers entered.

The general was an imposing figure—a tall man with thick brown hair and a serious gaze—and he spoke with a stern voice. "Monsieur Pope, la lettre de Napoléon." He handed Braschi the envelope.

Braschi donned his spectacles, broke the seal, and read Napoleon's communiqué: two sentences, a direct quote from the prophetic scripture of Revelation.

***"He who leads into captivity, shall go into captivity;
He who kills with the sword, must be killed with the
sword. Revelation 13:10"***

Braschi looked up at Berthier with surprise and a mixture of anger and betrayal. His prominent forehead wrinkled, his dark eyes burning, “What is this?”

“Monsieur Giovanni Angelo Braschi,” Berthier declared. “By the order of Bonaparte, you are henceforth a prisoner of war of the Republic of France.”

The iron chains chimed as Braschi’s hands were bound.

“You need not do this. I can be an ally.”

Braschi feared his fate as he saw the soldiers plunder his apartment and loot his personal belongings with complete disregard.

General Berthier pulled a soldier’s New Testament from his vest pocket and began to read aloud from the Book of Revelation as Braschi was dragged out against his will.

**“I will show unto thee the judgment of the great
whore with whom the kings of the earth have
committed fornication, and the inhabitants of the earth
have been made drunk with the wine of her
fornication. Revelation Chapter 17:1.”**

Braschi fell to his knees and bent forward, suctioning his palms to the smooth marble floors to prevent his capture. Imprisonment was the most terrifying fate he could imagine. He tested the strength of his chains and tried to break them as if he thought it were even possible, his face red with effort.

The French soldiers laughed at him. “He is soiling himself,” one of them mocked.

Berthier continued his sermonizing to the dethroned pope as if he were reading him a judgment written by the hand of God.

**“And the woman which thou sawest is that great city,
which reigneth over the kings of the earth. Revelation
17:18.”**

Braschi was pulled to his feet. A soldier by his side locked an iron collar around his neck. “You will not escape,” he snarled and heaved on the chain.

Braschi shouted out as he was forced to suffer these indignities. “Think you then that while we sued for peace, that we would not also take precautions?”

Berthier ignored Braschi and continued to read aloud.

**“How much she hath glorified herself, and lived
deliciously, so much torment and sorrow give her: for
she saith in her heart, I sit a queen, and am no
widow, and shall see no sorrow. Revelation 18:7”**

The guard in front heaved on Braschi’s chains as if he were pulling on an unwilling mule. The soldiers laughed and mocked Braschi. They cheered as he was ejected from his palace and pushed into his berline de grille.

Braschi turned and gazed upon his conquered city. Snow fell and smoke poured out of the Vatican windows as he and his Cardinals were carried away in the middle of the night. Braschi watched the fires burn and chanted mystical words once inscribed upon a palace wall by a phantom hand in the presence of King Nebuchadnezzar. The very words of which, half a millennium before Christ, were recorded in the Book of Daniel and foretold the fall of the kingdom of Babylon.

**“Mene, mene tekel upharsun. Mene: Your kingdom
has been assessed. Tekel: It has been weighed in the
balance and found wanting. Upharsun: Your
kingdom is to be divided. And given to your
enemies.”**

Giovanni Angelo Braschi died in prison 18 months later. Curiously, his funeral was delayed for 3 years since his corpse had vanished. The mystery of Braschi’s disappearance has never been solved. That is, until now.

CHAPTER 1

The counsel for the defense addressed her. “Dr. Ashton.” Natasha raised her eyebrows and leaned forward, willing to answer whatever question Sidney Delaware desired to ask. He was a tall, skinny man who liked to stroke his smoothly shaven chin as he paced in front of the jurors. Mr. Delaware had a long face and a mouth and teeth that were too wide for his narrow head. “Please explain to the court the term ‘paleography.’”

Natasha looked at the grotesquely deformed man who sat in the defendant’s chair. She was certain that he was the killer of the young woman, Katrina Dunlap. She knew that her testimony would be a key element in the prosecutor’s effort to secure a conviction.

“Paleography is the study, analysis, interpretation, and authentication of ancient handwriting—specifically Greek and Latin,” she answered.

Natasha turned her attention back to the jury and briefly wondered if she appeared as they expected a paleographer to look. She was an attractive woman with mid-length golden hair and intelligent brown eyes.

Wearing an ivory suit, she thought she resembled the stereotypical linguistics academic. “Smart babe,” her girlfriend, Lucy, had teased. Natasha found herself wishing she had her reading glasses to flip open and push up the bridge of her nose—if only to look more like a doctor and less like a babe.

Delaware continued, “And isn’t it true, Dr. Ashton, that your seemingly impressive academic credentials from Georgetown and Oxford are actually in the specialization of paleography?”

“It’s true that my doctorate is in paleography. However, paleography is a sub-specialization of graphology in general,” she explained. “I am an expert in the analysis of handwriting.”

“You are an author, aren’t you? Your most recent book is a bestseller, isn’t it?”

“Objection. Relevance!” the prosecutor protested.

“Your honor, I will show relevance,” Delaware answered.

“I’ll allow it for now,” the judge ruled.

“Dr. Ashton,” Delaware continued. “Isn’t it true that this latest book is about insights that you arrive at by means of not only your study of ancient writings, but also by means of your self-proclaimed psychic abilities?”

Natasha didn’t know how to answer. Mr. Delaware had grossly mischaracterized her book.

“That’s not exactly how I would put it,” Natasha answered. “It’s about using one’s intuition and life experience to discern personal meaning from ancient writings.”

“Yes. But isn’t it true that you consider yourself to be psychic?” Delaware probed.

“I’m not a fortune teller, but I feel I have a heightened intuition and sensitivity to the spiritual.”

“Heightened sensitivity to the spirit realm,” Delaware repeated. “So do you feel that spirits communicate to you?”

“Objection. Relevance!” The prosecutor stood up.

“I’m allowing it.” The judge looked over to Natasha to answer. Natasha bent back to the microphone.

“Yes. Whether we realize it or not, we are all communicated to by spirits.”

“And what about the spirit of the deceased in our case? Do you believe she assisted you in discerning—as you put it—the truth?”

“I strictly analyzed the handwriting, Mr. Delaware,” she answered.

“But why? If my client were guilty, wouldn’t the victim be screaming at you of his guilt? Did you perceive any communication from the victim as to my client’s guilt?”

Natasha looked at the defendant, Gilbert Carver. He avoided her glance and lowered his bald, misshapen head.

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“No. The communication I received as to Mr. Carver’s guilt came from Mr. Carver, in my opinion. I concluded that the handwriting was his,” Natasha answered.

“So, what are you, Dr. Ashton, a handwriting expert or a psychic investigator?” Mr. Delaware vigorously shook his head with a look of condemning disapproval. “No further questions, Your Honor,” he hollered to the courtroom on his way back to sit next to Gilbert Carver.

CHAPTER 2

William Jaimeson awoke from another one of his nightmares. In his dream, his eyes had shifted from their brilliant cobalt blue to a vivid red—red with rage. He believed in dreams; after all, they had carried him this far, hadn't they? But lately, the bad dreams were coming more often. Probably just stress. Things had been pretty hectic. William noticed his thoughts drifting. I need to go back to sleep and rewrite this dream. I must make it better.

You always make it better. A voice inside him said. *That's why you're the most popular governor in Washington State history. That's why you're the next president of the United States.*

It was his mother's voice. She was gone now, but she never stopped encouraging her boy Will.

He filled a quarter of a bar glass with bourbon. *That's right, baby. You can have a nightcap. Forget that bad dream. Instead, dream about your beautiful wife or your good old Mommy.* He finished his drink and went back to his dream, trying to undo it and make it all better.

Nevertheless, he didn't make things better. In the dream, he watched a hijacked airplane. He saw a terrorist pulling plastic explosive material out of specially machined American quarters. The quarters were hollow, each containing just a few grams of explosive.

That's how they'll sneak it on the plane. He thought. *It'll look like a handful of pocket change.*

The terrorist went to the lavatory, extracted the explosive putty from the coins, and assembled the bomb. When he came out, he was joined by four others.

"I am Ahmed Ahmad," the terrorist announced as he began his takeover of the plane. He spoke with a cultured British accent. "Today, Allah will drink the blood of the Great Dragon. Allah has given us the

great honor of being His cupbearer. At the end of this day, we will fly this plane into the United Nations Building—but that doesn't mean you have to perish. If you cooperate with us, you may live.

“Under each of your seats is a parachute. Give us the plane freely, and we will fly to a low altitude so you can skydive to safety. If you do not give up the plane, it will be exploded—and we will all die together.”

He held the bomb up for everyone to see. It was a walnut-sized ball of gray putty with wires sticking out. In his other hand, the terrorist held a modified RC car remote. He pressed the plastic explosive against the window.

“Give us the plane and skydive to safety, or you will die a horrible death. Your bodies will be burned alive—or perhaps your flesh will be sucked through small holes in the plane. Think about your families. Think about the ones you love.”

“Don't do it!” a beautiful woman screamed from the rear of the plane. She had wavy, light hair and intelligent brown eyes. “You're all going to die anyway. The chutes won't open. He's going to turn you all into falling little bombs. He will use your bodies flying through the sky and splattering all over the city to magnify the horror! Don't you understand?” she shouted. “You're part of the horror! You are the bombs! Your deaths are part of the diabolical scheme!”

The passengers decided to save themselves.

“You have chosen wisely!” Ahmad shouted. The plane flew low, and Ahmad opened the emergency exit door. He shouted, “Hurry! Save yourselves. Tell the world our cause is just.”

The passengers lined up and, one by one, jumped out of the plane. Will saw the horrified expressions on their faces as they pulled their parachute ripcords, only to discover they didn't work. He heard them scream as they plummeted to their deaths.

The 321 passengers sprayed across the skies over the city like the tail of a falling comet. Will could hear their screams. He saw them landing on cars and buildings. He saw them falling on unsuspecting pedestrians. He saw their eyeballs shoot out of their sockets. He saw their spines eject

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through the tops of their heads like skewers through pieces of marinated pork.

Will screamed, “Ahhhh! You monstrous psychopaths!” He saw the General Assembly of the United Nations. Without warning, the plane burst through the walls in an explosion. The General Assembly was vaporized. Will screamed, “Ahhhhh! Those poor people.” He shed tears into his pillow and swore vengeance. Rage burned beneath his eyelids. The next morning, Will began to think of a way to finally end his terrible dreams.

CHAPTER 3

Thousands of miles away, in the other Washington, Washington DC, Natasha Ashton also tossed and turned. She couldn't help replaying her testimony. She despised the memory, but she was a slave to it. It kept looping in her mind, just like the dream that had awakened her once again in the middle of the night. She stared at the ceiling and renewed her vow never to give handwriting testimony in a court of law again. Her disastrous testimony had led to the eventual acquittal of the notorious killer, Gilbert Carver. He was out there somewhere, hunting for his next victim.

Natasha decided to shift her thoughts and focus on something positive. She glanced over at her husband, Tom, as he slept peacefully beside her. Lying on his back, his straight nose and square chin pointed toward the ceiling. The silhouette of his face reminded her of a moonlit mountain range. His full head of soft afro hair tempted her caress.

She imagined he was dreaming about the new life they were about to begin in the Pacific Northwest. After twenty long years as a diplomat in the Foreign Service, Tom was ready to retire at the young age of forty-two.

Natasha rose quietly and walked to the kitchen. She filled a glass with cold water and drank it, then returned to bed and slipped beneath the covers. *Soon we'll start our new life*, she thought, just before sleep overtook her. *Soon we'll journey to that enchanted island.*

CHAPTER 4

It was raining most of the day that Tom and Natasha first visited Jerrell's Cove and Harstine Island. Natasha reclined in the passenger seat, napping while Tom drove.

She was fatigued from the travel, first from Maryland to Seattle. After Seattle, a one-hour ferry ride to Bremerton. From Bremerton, Harstine Island was just a thirty-minute drive south. They were on their way to meet with their real estate agent, Vernon Cook, and to inspect their dream home for the first time.

As they crossed the bridge to the island, Natasha breathed deeply and dreamed of the days ahead. Vernon's description echoed in her mind, with the rich, toned voice of a man whose success depended on building relationships over the telephone.

"Jerrell's Cove is a gated community. It has all the amenities of a resort. Most of the homes have stunning views of the water and the surrounding mountains. And to top it all off, it's got its own private marina with assigned moorage for each property."

"After we settle in, I'll find us a boat and we'll sail to endless destinations," Tom said. He watched the road. Silent but for the hum of the engine and the squeegee of the wiper blades back and forth along the windshield, Natasha imagined all the places to sail.

Tom continued, "We could sail to Seattle, Bainbridge Island, or the San Juans. Port Angeles and Hoodspoint are gateways into the Olympic Mountains. We could moor at their marinas and go on backpack adventures."

Natasha smiled, thinking of Tom out on the hunt for their boat. He would find it in the classifieds, on a bulletin board, or parked near a busy intersection with a big "for sale" sign on it.

"You'll find it honey," she told him. She smiled big, stretched, and let out a howling yawn.

“No one can bargain like you.”

“Yeah, all those years in foreign marketplaces have honed my negotiating skills pretty good, haven’t they?”

“Oh, yeah. I’m sure you’ll find us the perfect boat.”

With the success of Natasha’s writing career and Tom’s own success as a career diplomat, they had plenty of money to buy a new boat, but that wasn’t Tom’s style. He preferred buying a thing—such as a boat — from an individual rather than from a corporation or a professional salesperson. Perhaps it was the personal negotiations and the opportunity to test his reading of body language. Perhaps it was the opportunity to make a new acquaintance or a new friend. Possibly, it was the satisfying sense of coming to the rescue of someone who needed to sell to raise cash for some reason or other.

Vernon was waiting for them from inside his dark green Jeep Cherokee at the Jerrell’s Cove entrance gate. The gate seemed out of place in its setting—a black iron monstrosity connected to black iron fencing that extended out in both directions until it was engulfed by the forest of cedars, Douglas firs, and tall sword ferns. An intercom and keypad device stood about four feet high, like a fast-food drive-through menu. Natasha looked up and noticed video cameras mounted high above the gateway.

After they entered, they followed Vernon’s Jeep along a narrow winding road. Natasha gazed out the window to see what wildlife might be out there.

“Now I know what Vernon meant when he said, ‘enchanted forest feel,” she said.

Jerrell’s Cove was abundant with deer and friendly families of raccoons. Majestic old-growth cedars lined the edge of the roadway. It was as if the road was made to meander around and through the trees.

Narrow asphalt bike and walking trails crisscrossed through the entire forested community. As they drove, they noticed trailhead entrance signs every so often.

They turned right and passed the clubhouse on the left.

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“That must be where they have the swimming pool,” Natasha pointed out.

A few moments later, they passed a little village church on the right. As they parked in front of the home, Natasha and Tom smiled at each other.

The house was quintessential Pacific Northwest lodge style with exposed timber, a river-rock fireplace, and awe-inspiring views from enormous cedar-framed windows. It felt warm and down-to-earth. The pleasant scent of cedar smoke lightly permeated the atmosphere.

“Vernon, it’s even better than we imagined,” Natasha exclaimed.

Tom and Natasha looked out the large bay windows at the water and mountain views, which had magically emerged from the rain clouds and mist that had hidden the beauty for most of the day. They turned to each other and embraced.

CHAPTER 5

Tom and Natasha settled into their cozy semi-retired rural lifestyle, but Natasha still had a book to promote. The seminar in Olympia, Washington, was her last for the year. It was a small venue, one of the meeting rooms in a larger hotel, but it was only a thirty-minute drive from their new home.

Natasha was a stunning presenter. Public speaking did not come easily to her, but careful practice for her presentations helped immensely.

At larger venues, the seminar was almost always a double feature. The distinguished psychic medium, Grant Nuby, would give the introduction for Natasha. After Natasha finished her presentation, there would be a short intermission, followed by her introduction of Grant.

By 5:00, most of the audience had arrived and been seated. Inspirational, up-tempo music softly filled the room, cueing the audience that the show was about to begin.

Tonight, Tom Ashton filled in for Grant. Although Tom was a handsome man with soulful brown eyes and a medium build, his most notable characteristic was his wide, genuine smile. It beamed out of his full-faced beard like sunshine through clouds. He walked energetically up the side stairs to center stage and grinned broadly at the audience.

“Welcome, ladies and gentlemen!” he called out.

The music intensified.

“She has traveled the world as a United States diplomat and has delighted audiences across the globe with her positive and hopeful messages. She is both a seasoned scholar and a spiritual visionary.”

Natasha felt a wave of anxiety and adrenaline wash over her. She loved the sensation, but it also made her want to run away. Her heart was pounding. She breathed in deeply and remembered to smile.

The music rose to its climax as Tom continued, “Ladies and gentlemen, you are about to experience a life-changing event. It will

answer some of the greatest questions of our time. It will take you on a journey of mind and spirit and unlock the mysteries of inspiration! Welcome to the dynamic presentation, 'Inspired Revelations.' Please put your hands together to welcome the one and only Natasha Ashton!"

A healthy cheer of applause thundered as Natasha jaunted to the front of the stage.

"Thank you. Wow. Thank you very much," Natasha responded to the applause.

Behind Natasha, the giant screen glowed, and the title "Inspired Revelations" faded onto the screen. It appeared as if written in calligraphy on ancient paper.

She began solemnly, "The actual title for what we know as the Book of Revelation is the Greek word



APOKALUPSIS, the Apocalypse, the Revealing. And within its pages is a passage that is actually quite revealing in regard to the process of inspiration."

In the back of the room, a tardy audience member entered quietly. She was a woman with long, dark hair, now graying, pulled up into a tight bun at the back of her head. Natasha made brief eye contact with her, noting her cloudy hazel eyes. The woman made her way to a rear corner seat and dropped her backpack on the floor next to her feet.

Natasha clicked the control in her fist and transitioned the slide to Revelation 22:14 and continued her presentation.

"Revelation chapter twenty-two, verse fourteen. In the New King James version of the Bible, it reads:

"Blessed are those who do His commandments, that they may have the right to the tree of life"

"However, in the New International Version of the Bible it reads this way:" Natasha continued.

**“Blessed are those who wash their robes, that they
may have the right to the tree of life”**

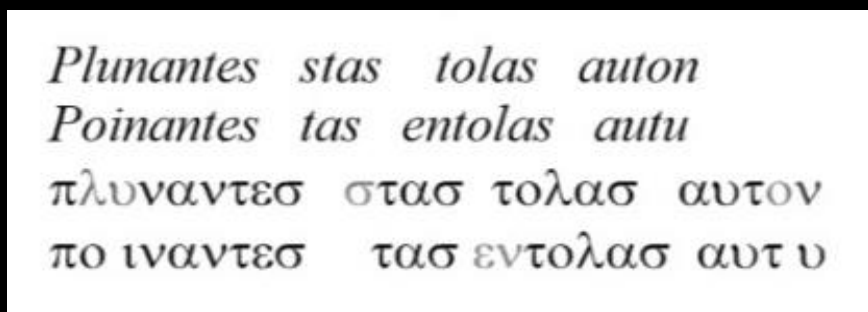
“How can the same verse be translated so differently in two different, yet widely accepted, versions of the Bible”? Natasha asked her audience.

Natasha looked around at the faces in the audience and searched their expressions as they pondered her question. She noticed the woman in the back wasn’t paying any attention; instead, she was fumbling around with both her hands in her backpack. It looked almost like the woman was trying to open a pickle jar.

Natasha continued, “The answer is simply that scholars cannot agree on which version is correct. The controversy goes back to the ancient Greek manuscripts themselves. Here, the King James version and the New International version rely on differing variant manuscripts.”

Natasha noticed a man who sat a few empty chairs down from the cloudy-eyed woman; he looked distracted by her fumbling about in the backpack. He was watching her with a look of concern and annoyance. She clicked the next slide.

“Let me show you the corresponding versions of the subject sentence side by side as they appear in the Greek.” Natasha read aloud. “*Plunantes stas tolas auton*’ and please compare to ‘*poinantes tas entolas autu*.”



“As you can see, the two versions optically appear very similar when compared. The variance between the two manuscripts is the result of an extraordinary and yet understandable scribal error. This one, of course, magnified by its profound effect on the meaning of the text.”

The woman in the back stood up and put on her backpack. “Amazing!” she shouted sarcastically. “You think you’re so smart, don’t you,”

Natasha stopped. She clenched her teeth tightly while trying to maintain calm and searched for security. Tom stood up. He was in back, but on the opposite side of the room from this strange woman.

Natasha tried to ignore the woman and hoped someone, either Tom or security, would escort her away. Natasha continued, “So how can one discern personal meaning from inspired sources if one is not certain of its accuracy?” Light instrumental music faded in. It sounded like puzzle-solving music. “The answer? Test all things.”

The strange woman began approaching up the center aisle.

Natasha continued, “It’s all right for a product of inspiration—such as a scripture—to be sprinkled with mistakes here and there. Perhaps variants serve a purpose—to remind us that even though we believe them to be inspired, they are still human.”

The woman interrupted suddenly, “Did you read the part in Revelation where it says the smoke of their torment will ascend forever and ever?” As her face turned red, she continued advancing. “Who do you think it’s talking about, Mrs. Smarty Pants?”

Natasha put her hand out, motioned for the woman to sit back down, and attempted to continue her presentation. “It’s our job to discern. Simply test it against these three criteria: Does it harmonize with science? Does it harmonize with personal experience? Does it harmonize with other known truths?”

The woman walked closer, brandishing a sprayer—the kind gardeners use for pesticides and fertilizers. “It’s talking about bitches like you!” she shouted, smacking her lips and chewing her gum. “You’re gonna burn!” She pointed the wand at Natasha.

Suddenly, Natasha was petrified, realizing she was being doused with gasoline. Tom ran up the center aisle, but it was too late. Almost in slow motion, Natasha watched the woman pull out a giant lighter with her left hand and click the trigger as its tip entered the stream of fuel. A spray of

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flames shot toward Natasha and engulfed the podium. She screamed and dived off the stage to her right, narrowly avoiding being ignited.

A young, bearded Orthodox priest sitting in the second row reacted swiftly. He saw the hose leading from the wand to the fuel tank in her backpack. He jumped from his chair, grasped the tubing, and yanked it down with all his strength, knowing that if he failed to disconnect the hose, the woman could turn her flame shooter on him next.

He ripped the tubing from the backpack, and an instant later, Tom rushed up from behind and wrestled the woman to the ground. The building's sprinkler system engaged, showering the audience. Other audience members grabbed fire extinguishers from the walls and covered the stage in white foam, putting out the flames.

The Orthodox priest, Father Elijah, looked over at Natasha to make sure she was okay, then turned to where Tom was wrestling with the woman on the floor. Holding the rubber tubing, Elijah tied a slipknot and bound the woman's arms behind her back with great effort. The woman, displaying incredible strength for her size and weight, fought wildly.

Most of the audience was either about to—or had already—abandoned their seats for the exits. Natasha returned to the stage and addressed them, "Stay calm, everyone. It's all over. I'm very sorry for the inconvenience, but obviously we won't be able to continue."

Security guards ran in and pulled the woman to her feet. Knowing she had a change of clothes in her car for emergencies and assuming the hotel would provide a room to clean up after such an incident, Natasha continued, "If anyone is interested, I'll be available for book signing and discussions at the hotel fireside lounge in one hour." The gasoline was beginning to sting her bare skin on the backs of her hands and neck. A quick shower was becoming urgent. The hotel manager had indeed come to the room to take charge, and when she asked, he said there would, of course, be a room key for her at the front desk when she returned from her car.

CHAPTER 6

After showering as quickly as she could, Natasha joined Tom and Father Elijah in the lounge; they had long ago shaken hands and introduced themselves to each other, but without her, their conversation had been limited to the subject of the arson attack. The fire alarm had long since been turned off, and the staff were cleaning up after the sprinklers and fire extinguishers in the meeting room. Wet and shaken, none of the other attendees had lingered. Tom and Natasha embraced. “Are you okay?” he asked.

“Other than being a little shook up, I’m fine. Thanks to you two, I really am,” she added before turning to Father Elijah with a smile. “Father, how can I ever thank you?”

Father Elijah blushed slightly. He was a mildly chubby man in his mid-thirties. His wavy brown hair was pulled back into a ponytail, and his beard was wild and untidy. His skin was smooth and pale—except for his pink cheeks—and he wore small, round, gold-framed glasses.

On his chair, he had left his hardback edition of *Inspired Revelations*. He picked it up, extended it to her, and smiled.

“Dr. Ashton, it is a pleasure to meet you. I am Father Elijah from Jerrell’s Cove. It hardly seems appropriate, but...”

“Oh, no. The pleasure is all mine,” Natasha assured him. She pulled out her pen and scribbled an autograph. Natasha recognized him as the priest of the small church near her home. “It is not often that a member of the clergy attends one of my seminars.”

She handed him the book, and they began walking out of the conference room with Tom.

“I must say it is very interesting and thought-provoking,” Father Elijah said. “Of course, I do not agree with everything, but you might be surprised by how much I actually do.”

As they passed through the exit and turned toward the lobby, Natasha smiled at him. “Thank you, Father Elijah. What did you especially like?”

“Well, a person of your education probably already knows that the Orthodox Church also holds a historical, metaphorical interpretation of the scriptures.”

Natasha nodded. Of course she knew that. The majority of Christendom, in fact, held the historical, metaphorical interpretation of scripture.

Elijah continued as they walked, “But what I really appreciate is the idea you bring up about valuing the scriptures for what they are. Their imperfections may be by God’s design, especially to prevent us from over-relying on them, as some do. The imperfections drive us to seek wisdom and understanding through prayer and to respect the traditions and authority of the Church.”

Natasha nodded and smiled widely. He was not just being agreeable—he genuinely appreciated her ideas.

“Yes, exactly. Thank you, Father. That was not what I expected you to say.”

They all stopped just a few feet in front of the reception desk.

“What did you expect?” Father Elijah asked.

“Well, I thought you were going to ask me to stay away from your flock.”

He shook his head and smiled. “No flocking way,” he joked.

The joke hit their funny bones just right after such a stressful event and a serious conversation, causing them all to break into short, vigorous laughter.

When it subsided, Elijah continued, “No, no. On the contrary, I would be honored if you and Tom would join us this Sunday for Divine Liturgy.”

“Well, thank you. Since we have so much in common, we might just take you up on that offer. I will discuss it with Tom and—who knows—you might just see us there.”

Tom, standing at Natasha’s side, gave her a squeeze.

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“There is one other thing,” the priest said, curling his newly autographed book under his arm like a football.

“What is that?” Natasha asked.

“I have come across some material that I think may astonish you.”

Natasha raised her eyebrows. “What kind of material?” she teased.

“Come to church, and I will show you,” Elijah answered.

“Well, you’ve definitely got my attention.”

“Good. Divine Liturgy begins at ten.”

Elijah shook hands with them, waved, and walked out.

CHAPTER 7

Natasha and Tom awoke to a clear, sunny winter day. The sky was blue, and the mountains seemed even closer than usual. The air smelled fresh, and it had snowed overnight.

They woke earlier than they normally would on a Sunday because they intended to go to church—despite the fact that Natasha and Tom hadn’t been in years. Father Elijah’s friendliness had made them feel comfortable, and they enjoyed the traditions of Christmastime—especially singing Christmas hymns.

Natasha supposed it brought back the magical memories of her childhood before her father had passed away. He had loved Christmas.

It was the people at her childhood church who had been the only ones to help her and her mother during the nightmare of her father’s death. It was probably that childhood loss that had something to do with the ease with which she made friends with Father Elijah, and before him, Father Francis Charles.

After several changes of mind, Natasha decided on her red outfit. “’Tis the season to wear red, fa-la-la-la-la,” she hummed. A short walk later, they arrived at the small church to the sound of the choir singing hymns.

The atmosphere was special and reverent. Under dimmed lights, people quietly lit candles, placed them in sand, and prayed silently. At the front of the church, a gold-painted dividing wall with an arched doorway stood between them and the altar.

A large icon of Jesus Christ was painted in a distinct Eastern Orthodox style to the right of the doorway. He had caramel skin, a ski-sloped nose, and a narrow, gaunt face with long, narrow eyes and small lips. His right index and middle fingers pointed upward as if he were saying the Boy Scout oath.

The spicy, clean sandalwood incense and the soft chimes calmed her.

Natasha noticed a box of candles with a handwritten placement card in the lobby. “Let’s burn some candles,” she whispered.

Tom shrugged in agreement.

He stuck a five-dollar bill in the collection box, and Natasha grabbed two candles, handing one to Tom.

“Do I get to make a wish?” he whispered, jokingly.

Natasha jabbed him with her elbow. They entered the sanctuary and sat in the last pew in the right corner.

Father Deacon Jim Worley entered and walked down the aisle to the podium. He was a tall, round man with thick glasses and a comb-over. Despite his somewhat unkempt appearance, Natasha sensed the church members respected him.

“Everybody, may I have your attention?” Jim paused and looked about the congregation. “Father Elijah has not arrived yet. I just got back from his home, and he’s not there either, but his car is. I’m afraid something’s wrong. Father Elijah has gone missing. I just called the sheriff; he and his deputy are headed over right now.”

A woman sitting in front of Natasha buried her head and began to sob. Natasha felt a lump in her throat.

I’m sure he’s okay, Natasha tried to reassure herself, but her instincts said otherwise. Nobody knew why he would have no-showed at church this morning; a lot of things could have happened.

Tom squeezed her hand. “Are you okay?” he asked.

“No, I’ve got a bad feeling about this,” she whispered.

Sheriff Darwood arrived with his deputy, Ben Green. The sheriff looked fiftyish; Natasha had a feeling he might be a retired Marine officer. He appeared confident, strong, and in good physical condition for his age.

At the front of the church, Jim yielded the podium to the sheriff.

“Listen up, everyone,” Darwood announced. “Jim Worley has filled me in on the details. Based on my experience, I believe we need to begin a search for Father Elijah in the woods immediately. I have a hunch he may have either gotten off the trail or possibly been caught in an animal trap.

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“All of his belongings are still at his residence, and his car is still there. We’ve called all the taxi services in the area; no one took a taxi out of here last night. Does anyone have any idea what might have happened?”

Again, silence.

“All right, then. He may very well be freezing out in the woods.”

Sheriff Darwood led the congregation back to the community center where the priest had last been seen. “Everyone, stay far behind us and let the dog do its work.”

He took a piece of clothing, bunched it up, and put it to the dog’s nose. Bear was a fluffy, bulky mixture of black Lab and perhaps a little Husky. “Okay, Bear. We’re counting on you. Let’s go find our man. Let’s go!”

Bear immediately took off down the street past the church and toward the Ashtons’ place. They passed the home and continued around the circle before stopping at the marina trailhead. He sniffed around momentarily and ran toward the marina.

The canine barked confidently as he charged down the snow-packed trail, finally stopping near the spot where, two weeks earlier, Tom and Natasha had photographed a deer. Later, they had discovered the small outbuilding hidden in the trees and bushes—just barely out of view from the main trail.

“Father Elijah, are you here? Father Elijah, can you hear us?” Darwood shouted.

Bear ran up to the outbuilding and jumped on his hind legs. He scratched at the door and barked, trying to push it open.

“Everybody, stand back. Father Elijah, are you in there?” Darwood shouted.

Silence was the only answer.

“You all get back home right now!” he ordered. “What’s behind this door is police business.”

Nobody moved. Nobody was about to go home. The sheriff shook his head at the crowd for defying his order and turned back to the door. The young deputy drew his pistol, taking position behind and off to the side, ready to cover as Darwood opened the door.

CHAPTER 8

Father Elijah's frozen body slumped in the far corner of the pump house. His neck was cinched with a belt, which was fastened on the other end to a water pipe a few feet above his head. A clear plastic bag—the kind one might find in the produce section of any grocery store—snugly covered his face. Frozen blood coated his hands. Above his head, a bloody finger-painted message screamed out in Latin from the wooden planks:

IN QIRUM IMUS NOCTE ET CONSUMIMER IGNI

“Dear God in heaven!” Sheriff Darwood exhaled and whipped around. “I want everybody out of here right now. Go back to the community center. He’s dead. I’m going to have to secure the site, and then I’ll have questions for you all. Deputy Green, tape off this area. Does anybody here know Latin?”

Natasha reluctantly stepped forward.

“I can help.”

Testifying in the Gilbert Carver trial had set a killer free, and the weight of it had followed her for years. Now, for the first time, she felt the faint possibility of redemption. She could never allow herself to testify again, but that did not mean she could not try to be useful.

“Okay then, you two stay here,” Sheriff Darwood commanded. “Everybody else, go back to the community center if you think you might have any valuable information. Otherwise, go home.”

Once everyone else was gone, Sheriff Darwood turned to Tom and Natasha. “The details of Father Elijah’s death are a matter of police business. What are your names?”

“I’m Natasha Ashton,” she said as she offered her hand.

The Sheriff's eyes sparked in recognition when she introduced herself. He shook her hand and turned to Tom.

"I'm Tom Ashton."

Darwood spoke solemnly. "It looks as if he hung himself. He wrote a note in his own blood. I need to know what it means."

Natasha wanted to collapse into tears, but she forced herself to hold it together.

Darwood opened the door. Natasha gasped. Tom held her as she sobbed into his shoulder for a moment before composing herself.

"Are you gonna be okay, honey?" Tom asked.

"Yes. I just can't believe it," Natasha answered, wiping her eyes with her sleeve.

"See his writing just above his head?" Darwood asked.

Natasha nodded.

"I can translate what he wrote, but it doesn't make much sense. 'IN GIRUM IMUS NOCTE ET CONSUMIMUR IGNI,' 'We wander in the night and are consumed in the fire.'"

Darwood repeated the sentence "IN GIRUM IMUS NOCTE ET CONSUMIMUR IGNI" When he turned back to Natasha, his eyes held a different, less friendly look. "Thank you for the information. Don't worry. We'll do a thorough investigation, but I think what we have here is a pretty clear case of suicide. The writing's on the wall. Believe it or not, a lot of people die like this."

"Why would he want to be found like this?" Natasha asked.

"Who knows? He might have been really sick," Darwood said.

"Sheriff, I'm a paleographer. I'm an expert in authenticating and analyzing handwriting—in particular, handwriting in ancient Greek and Latin. If you provide me with handwriting samples, I will be able to tell you with certainty whether or not Father Elijah wrote that note."

"No offense, Mrs. Ashton. I appreciate your offer, but your reputation precedes you. Just leave the police business to me. You two go back home now. As far as handwriting analysis goes, the Washington State Patrol has a lab for that if we need it."

CHAPTER 9

When they arrived home, Natasha drew a steamy hot bath while Tom kindled a fire and made a fresh pot of coffee. She leaned her head back and sank deep into the suds until only her face and breasts remained above the water. Massaging her scalp, she exhaled slowly, opened her eyes, stared up at the ceiling, and tried to relax.

Natasha could hear Elvis Presley singing “Oh Come All Ye Faithful” from the living room; the singing choirs of angels blended with the sound of Tom cheering as the Seahawks scored a touchdown. The hollering mixed with the music and filtered through the bathwater, creating a strange yet soothing audio experience. She could tell he had already freed his mind from the day’s horror. She wished she could do the same, but she could not.

Natasha sat upright, wrung out a washcloth, and wiped her face several times.

It just did not add up. There was no way he committed suicide. Last night at the party, he seemed perfectly happy. I will bet Father Francis Charles could shed some light.

Natasha had mixed feelings about contacting Francis Charles. Part of her still loved and missed him, but on another level, there was hurt and heartache. And there was also the destructive secret they shared and had spent years trying to forget.

Her mind drifted. A flicker of excitement fluttered through her as she remembered those years. She was barely out of university, and the job at the embassy in Italy had been a dream come true. By day, she pushed government papers, but after work, she immersed herself in everything Rome’s nightlife had to offer. Father Francis Charles was the embassy chaplain, and through the sacred privacy of confession, he had intimate knowledge of her personal affairs.

Father Francis was the most eminent scholar Natasha had ever known. She had met many intelligent and gifted people in university and during her time in the Foreign Service, but none like him. Fluent in ten languages and a walking, talking encyclopedia, he could hold a conversation for hours.

She believed he began to fall in love with her the night he encouraged her to speak frankly about her romantic life during confession. She thought back to that night and remembered.

Francis appeared at her apartment late, saying he felt alone and needed a friend. They talked until the early hours. When she offered him the couch, he countered with the idea that they share the bed as platonic friends. As a priest, he said, he often felt lonely and starved for simple human contact; just once, he wanted to fall asleep within the comfort of an affectionate snuggle.

Natasha sympathized with him and saw no harm in offering warmth to the handsome young priest.

Later that night, when she felt his arousal, she realized she felt the same longing. She turned toward him, and they kissed. Then they made love—good love. Love that felt like water in the desert, understood only by those who had been lost and lonely for far too long.

When he returned the next night, she ended it. Despite his smile, she could see the disappointment beneath it.

When she discovered she was pregnant, she did not know what to do. She had never told Francis that she had conceived and borne his son. In her fourth month of pregnancy, she took a furlough to the Italian coastal town of Rimini. Six weeks later, she gave birth to her only child. She checked into the hospital under an alias and entrusted her newborn son to the orphanage sisters.

The memory pressed on her chest like a stone. She understood, painfully, what a broken heart felt like. There was the grief of losing her child—and another grief as well. The small-town medical center had been charming but poorly equipped. The substandard care left her barren. The boy she gave away was the only child she would ever have.

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When she returned to Vatican City, she avoided Francis Charles entirely and found comfort in the arms of Thomas Ashton. Tom and Natasha fell in love while Francis watched from the sidelines. He watched her give her heart to another man. When Tom and Natasha chose to marry in the Embassy chapel, Francis performed the ceremony. He smiled throughout it. He also envied Tom Ashton throughout it. He pronounced them husband and wife—and then watched them kiss after inviting Tom to kiss the bride.

Natasha had always felt a strange mix of thankfulness, pity, admiration, and guilt when it came to Francis Charles—but above all, she felt guilt. Deep down, she knew she had robbed him of his only son. She had robbed them both.

She thought again of the words he had spoken to her in the confessional the night before they first made love. “You must control your mind—it is the key to controlling your life. Is there anything else?”

“No, Father. Other than that, I have been a good girl.”

“Then your confession is penance enough. You are forgiven. Go in peace, child.”

His words echoed in her mind all these years later. They offered the forgiveness she longed for but could never bring herself to ask for.

She wiped her face with the washcloth again. A sense of peace washed over her. She stepped out of the tub, pulled on her robe, wrapped a towel around her head, and fell back onto her bed to air-dry.

“Go in peace, child.” His voice lingered as she drifted into sleep.

CHAPTER 10

Darwood stood in front of the outbuilding, facing the trailhead. His eyes followed a squirrel darting up a tree trunk. When his gaze wandered higher, he noticed a winter hawk circling in the sky far above.

He grasped his radio from its holster and held it to his lips. “Deputy Green, this is Darwood, come in. Over.” The radio hissed and crackled.

“Green here. Over,” the deputy responded.

“Deputy Green, before you start asking questions, I need you to bring the crime kit down here pronto. Over.”

“Affirmative. Be right down. Over.”

“Roger. Over and out.” Darwood spun the radio in his hand, settling it into its belt clip like an old west gunslinger.

A few minutes later, Deputy Green arrived with the crime kit. He walked up to where the sheriff waited near the outbuilding. “You want me to stick around with you here and interview the folks later?” Green asked.

“Negative. I have this covered. Go back and interview them. See if anyone has anything useful to share. I’m worried about what Father Elijah did that was so bad he couldn’t live with himself. One other thing—get on the horn with Red at the mortuary. We’ll be running out of daylight soon, and the body needs to be secured.”

“Understood. Call me if you need me!” the deputy shouted as he headed off.

Darwood reached into the crime kit duffle bag, pulled out latex gloves, and snapped them on. He cracked his knuckles, grabbed the Polaroid, and began taking photos of the snowpack around the shack.

Doggone it. Too many footprints in the snow now. Shouldn’t have let anybody approach the shack at all. There were at least four sets of footprints leading up to and around the building. If the priest’s tracks were present—or if

the tracks of a mysterious stranger were there—it was now impossible to prove.

His photos of the snow would be useless. He thought back to when he'd approached the shack with the dog. *Had any footprints been visible? No. I don't think so, but I cannot remember for certain. It was snowing last night. Most likely, any footprints had been covered by the fresh snowfall.*

He opened the shack, switched on the light, and began taking pictures. He took close-up shots of the key parts of the scene: the priest's head wrapped in plastic, the father's neck, his left hand, his right hand. He left his multi-tool knife on the workbench.

Darwood stepped backward to take a wide shot. A creepy feeling washed over him, and he froze. He sensed someone lurking in the corner behind him, hidden behind the door.

His chest tightened, his stomach dropped, and he couldn't breathe. *Damn.* The murderer was behind him. He reached for his gun, but it was too late.

Before the sheriff could react, the figure in the shadows whipped a plastic bag over his head and yanked him backward. The killer flung the sheriff sideways over his own hip and facedown into the snow outside. He jumped on top of the sheriff's back and pinned Darwood's arms beneath his knees, pulling the plastic tight.

Darwood struggled, but it was useless. He tried to buck the killer off, but he couldn't. The sheriff's lungs burned. His chest felt as if it were exploding.

He tried to roll sideways, then snapped his legs upward in hopes of kicking the killer off or hooking him with his feet. Moments passed as Darwood fought desperately and eventually convulsed as a final death rattle oozed out.

The killer sat on his back and arms for a few more seconds to make sure the sheriff was dead. *Perfect kill. They'll assume he just had a heart attack and collapsed in the snow.* A diabolical idea surfaced. He had heard just enough of the sheriff's earlier radio call to Green to mimic how they spoke on the radio.

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He practiced the sheriff's voice with a strained, labored inflection. "Green, this is Darwood. Having heart attack. Get an ambulance. Over." The killer was satisfied, and an evil grin crawled across his face. He was good at doing voices. Medications he had taken for most of his life had made his natural voice high-pitched and effeminate. Disguising it had become second nature. He pulled the radio off the sheriff's belt, held it to his lips, and gave his best imitation of what the sheriff might sound like during a massive heart attack.

A voice much like the sheriff's came out. "Green, this is Darwood. Over."

"Green. Go ahead," the deputy answered.

The killer's lips curled into a sinister grin as he breathed life into his impersonation of a heart-attack-stricken Darwood. "Green, this is Darwood. Having a heart attack. Send an ambulance."

The killer placed the radio back in the sheriff's hands and pulled the plastic bag off his head. He backtracked quickly through the other footprints. Once he reached the trail, he continued toward the marina. It was mostly deserted this time of year. He would wait until dark and then escape by boat.

CHAPTER 11

Deputy Green and Jim Worley jumped into the sheriff's car and sped toward the trailhead. Green grabbed the dashboard-mounted radio handset and called out.

"Dispatch, this is Green. Over. Get an ambulance to the marina trailhead at Jerrell's Cove right now. Sheriff Darwood has had a heart attack. I'm on my way."

"Darwood, are you there? Darwood, are you there?"

No answer.

"Damn!" He slammed the radio down and looked at Jim. Jim only shook his head. The sheriff's car sped past Natasha's home, sirens screaming and lights flashing.

The commotion woke Natasha from her nap and startled Tom from his game. They looked out the window just as the sheriff's car flew past.

"I wonder what that's all about," Tom said. "Why the rush?"

"Let's go see," Natasha suggested.

They were lacing up their boots when the ambulance roared by ten minutes later.

"Something's going on," Natasha exclaimed.

They ran down the street to the trailhead. The paramedics were already making their way up to the shack. Natasha ran ahead of Tom; she was six years younger and far more athletic.

Natasha arrived just as the paramedics rolled the sheriff onto a transport board. They strapped him in.

"One, two, three."

They lifted him onto the ambulance gurney.

"Out of the way. Out of the way!"

They rushed Darwood down the trail and back to the ambulance.

"Oh my goodness. What happened, Deputy?" Natasha asked.

“Darwood had a heart attack and collapsed. He wasn’t breathing when Jim and I arrived. I performed CPR until the medics got here,” Deputy Green said, voice thickening. “He was like a father to me.”

Jim Worley placed a hand on the deputy’s shoulder. He did not say anything—just gave him a steady, reassuring pat.

“They gave him adrenaline, and they’ll keep trying to resuscitate him on the way to Mason County. Since the snow kept him cold, he may not even have brain damage if they bring him back.”

Tom arrived in time to hear this last part. The ambulance’s sirens wailed as it sped off.

“Is there anything we can do to help?” Tom asked.

“Well, Red from the mortuary is on his way to collect the priest’s body. I need to stay here and finish the scene documentation for the file.”

“Jim,” the deputy said, turning to him. “It appears the man committed suicide.”

Jim clenched his jaw, looked down at the ground, and shook his head.

“I’m sure that when I look inside, I’ll see what you’re seeing. But it’s still hard for me to believe.”

“I think so too,” Natasha said quietly.

“I’m going to finish taking pictures of the scene. Then I’d like you to look and tell me if anything stands out. As far as suicides go, this one is strange.”

When Jim saw the condition of the priest, tears burst from his eyes. He silently shook his head and dropped to his knees beside the body.

He clenched his teeth and shook his head again.

“Can I?” Jim asked, gesturing to Deputy Green that he wanted to untie the man’s neck and remove the plastic. Green nodded.

Jim loosened the belt from the priest’s neck and gathered the man’s head to his chest, weeping deeply. His throat tightened with pain. His eyes squinted—his facial muscles quivering—as he held Father Elijah’s head and sobbed.

The sight was overwhelming, and Natasha began to cry as well. Tom and Deputy Green tried to hold in their emotions, but they too could not keep back their tears.

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Nobody spoke for several minutes. Tom held Natasha while the deputy rested a hand on Jim's shoulder.

"How about if I give you a hand up, Deacon?"

Jim gently laid the priest's head back against the corner of the wall.

Deputy Green extended his hand and helped Jim rise. Jim wiped his eyes on his shirtsleeves and pulled the deputy into a hug.

"You two go on home now. Jim, if you'll stay with me, I'll gather what I need and we'll head over to the Father's parsonage."

"Mm-hm," Jim agreed.

CHAPTER 12

The phone rang at Tom and Natasha's house on Monday afternoon.

"Hi, Natasha, it's Jim Worley. How are you and Tom doing?"

"I did not sleep much last night. Tom was up, too."

"Me neither," Jim continued. "One thing I'm certain of—Father Elijah was murdered."

Tom was in the garage arranging his tool area. He hammered a nail as if to punctuate Jim Worley's statement, and a chill ran down Natasha's spine.

"Who do you think might have done it? And why?"

Jim took a deep breath and sighed.

"Wish I knew. All I know for sure is that Father Elijah did not commit suicide—and that leaves only one other possibility."

"Did you tell Deputy Green?"

"Well, the deputy's pretty headstrong. He thinks it's a suicide. Of course, there's no evidence to the contrary. Ruling the death as a suicide is a lot less work than opening a murder investigation. When he talks about looking for clues, he's really just looking for reasons why Father Elijah might have taken his own life."

"How do you know?" Natasha asked.

"I was with him at the scene and again at Father Elijah's home. Unlike the deputy, I was looking for clues pointing to who would have wanted him dead. Two very different mindsets. I looked over his home and personal belongings carefully. Now I'm trying to put the pieces together. I did see some things that gave me a few ideas."

"Did you retrieve any handwriting samples?" Natasha asked.

"Not a single scrap. He was completely digital."

"What was it that you found?"

"I'd rather not say for now, if that's all right."

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Natasha invited him to dinner, and Jim agreed.

CHAPTER 13

As they sat down for roast beef dinner, Natasha directed her attention to Jim and began, “I was thinking last night that maybe you could shed some light on the note Father Elijah left behind—IN GIRUM IMUS NOCTE ET CONSUMIMUR IGNI, we wander in the night consumed by fire.”

“Have you considered the possibility that it was not Father Elijah who left the note?” Jim asked.

Tom and Natasha looked at each other, their eyebrows raised.

“The thought did cross our minds,” Tom answered. “But it looked like he wrote it.”

Jim continued, “Well, it looked like he wrote it because we assumed he was the only one present at the time of his death, since the sheriff hastily ruled it a suicide. But if you consider the possibility that he was murdered, then the killer could have written it.”

“And that person may have been the one who left the note,” Natasha agreed.

“But it was written in the Father’s blood—with his own fingertip,” Tom said, raising some doubt as he poured another glass of red wine.

“We assumed that too,” Natasha added, turning back to Jim. “Just because his hand had blood on it doesn’t necessarily mean he was the one who wrote the note.”

They all paused in thought.

“Jim, when we spoke earlier, you mentioned that you might have seen something at the Father’s home that gave you some ideas.”

“Truth be told, it’s partly what I did not see that gives me some ideas,” Jim answered. “As I said earlier, his home was completely devoid of any scrap of handwriting. We turned on his computer and discovered that all of his documents had been erased from his hard drive. And the Internet browsing history had been erased too. There was no trace of his pet project either.”

“What project was that?” Natasha asked.

“The Father was writing a series of sermons. He was going to call the series Countdown to the End Times. Or Countdown to the Apocalypse. Something along those lines. It had to do with interpreting the prophecies in Revelation—specifically, the seven seals.”

“Are you saying you think he might have been killed over that manuscript?” Natasha asked.

“The question is: why was his computer wiped? Where was all his research? Where was his sermon calendar? Where were his manuscripts?”

“But why would someone want to kill him over a book about the end times? There are hundreds of such books already,” Tom said.

The idea Jim put forward was interesting, but Natasha wondered if perhaps he was letting his imagination stretch too far.

“Do you have any idea what the message is about?” Tom asked. “Why would the killer have written that?”

“That’s a good question,” Jim responded, wagging his empty fork at Tom as though it were an extension of his pointer finger.

Natasha answered, “The Zodiac Killer used to leave puzzling messages for the police to solve. Maybe this phrase is a clue to the killer’s identity.”

They thought silently for a moment. Jim looked as though a thought had struck him, but then he hesitated.

“What?” Natasha asked.

“Well, I thought of something else that could be relevant. I should probably tell you now rather than have you find out later.”

“What?” Natasha pressed.

“Oh. About twenty years ago, there were a lot of mysterious cattle mutilations—and a lot of talk about devil worshippers in the woods of Mason County.”

“Devil worshippers. Hmm. The wandering in the night and the fires sound like something cult-related or demonic. It’s worth checking out.”

“Yes—and it might explain motive as well,” Jim agreed.

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"Maybe I'll pay a visit to the Mason Journal tomorrow," Natasha suggested.

She cleared the plates, turned on the teapot, and sat back down.

"So, Jim. Tell us about your boat," Tom said.

"Oh, she's nothing fancy. But she's comfortable. Named her Foresta because when you sail around here, it's peaceful to look at the edges of the forest as it meanders along the pristine beaches."

"Sounds nice," Tom said.

"Anytime you want, we can take her out."

The teapot began to whistle, and Natasha got up. "I think you'll like this tea, Jim. It's called holiday spice."

"Sounds good. Thank you, Natasha."

Natasha smiled. She loved introducing people to her favorite unique teas.

Tom got up, pulled the cookie jar off the counter, and set it on the table. It was filled with Natasha's homemade chocolate chip and walnut cookies.

Natasha walked carefully back with three steaming mugs and sat down again. "I think we need to have a talk with Deputy Green."

"Won't work," Jim countered. "I know the man. He lives in a world of black and white. And all we have are unproven conspiracy theories."

"If all we have are conspiracies, then we better find something soon. We only have two days before the funeral. And I think he deserves better than for the whole town to think he committed suicide."

"And we deserve better than to live in fear of an unrestrained murderer in our midst," Tom added.

"Um humph," Jim agreed. "We'll need to gather the facts and present the case to Green no later than Wednesday night. So we need a plan."

They pondered for a moment until Natasha broke the silence. "Tom, I know you did not want to split up, but you know I can defend myself. And as I see it, we have three places to cover: the newspaper, the library, and Jerrell's Cove. How about you take the newspaper; I'll take the library; and Jim can cover the church and the crime scene? Jim, could you call Deputy Green tonight and see if there have been any new

developments? And one way or another, get him to open the crime scene to you as early as possible tomorrow.”

“Sounds like a good plan,” Jim said.

“Who said I was worried about you?” Tom joked. “You’re the one who studied karate, not me.”

“That’s right. So you better watch out, old man,” Natasha teased, making a playful karate chop.

“I best be going then,” Jim said as he stood. “Tomorrow morning comes awfully early for me.”

He made his way to the door and put on his jacket.

“Thanks for that delicious dinner. And it was a real pleasure getting to know you better.”

“Thank you for being our guest.”

Natasha reached into a side drawer, pulled out one of her business cards, and handed it to Jim. It was a plain white card with her name and number.

“This is my cell phone. Call me as soon as you can tomorrow with any updates. And I’ll bring Tom in on a three-way call.”

“What kind of business?” Jim asked.

“Inspirational—motivational, you might say,” she answered.

“It was nice getting to know you better too. And I’ll definitely take you up on that offer for a day on your boat,” Tom said.

“Anytime you want to take her out, just give me a holler.”

“Good night,” Natasha said as she gave Jim a hug.

Then Jim and Tom shook hands.

“Good night. See you tomorrow.” Jim turned around to leave, and Tom closed the door behind him.

CHAPTER 14

The next morning, Tom made cappuccinos. They sipped them on the back deck while taking in the panoramic views of the Puget Sound and Mount Rainier beyond.

“So,” Tom said, “you really want to get mixed up in this?”

“We already are. Besides, whether I like to admit it or not, Sidney Delaware was right. I am kind of a psychic investigator.”

“This is serious.”

“I am serious. I may not be psychic like Grant Nuby, but you know I have a gift—even if it is just a glorified woman’s intuition.”

“What’s your intuition telling you now?”

Suddenly an ugly, dreadful feeling manifested in her core. It was heavy and oppressive. She recognized what it meant—someone had died or was in danger of dying. Maybe someone she loved.

Natasha bent over, bracing herself against the sensation.

“Honey, are you okay?” Tom placed a hand on her back.

Natasha didn’t answer right away, but after a few moments she straightened. “Something bad has happened or is going to happen. I can feel it.”

“What do you think it might be?”

“I don’t know.”

Tom kissed her on the lips and then on her forehead.

“Thanks, babe.”

“Of course. Don’t forget to eat the breakfast I made for you.”

Tom went to the living room and turned on the news. Natasha walked back to the bedroom and slipped into her favorite blue jeans with the red sparkle beads on the right thigh. She looked in the mirror and smiled at herself. She didn’t feel like smiling, but she hoped it might help. She pulled her hair into a ponytail and put on a tight white turtleneck sweater.

“Hey, honey?” Tom shouted from the living room. “You’d better come in here. I think I know what’s upset you.”

“What?” Natasha demanded as she entered.

One look at the TV and she understood why she felt sick. The feeling deepened, pressing heavily on her heart. She sank onto the couch and watched in horror as the news helicopter showed footage of ferry victims floundering in the water.

“A Seattle ferry just capsized,” Tom said. “As many as eleven hundred people may have been aboard.”

“What caused it to capsize?”

“I don’t know yet—I just turned it on.”

The news anchor appeared behind his desk, a window behind him showing Seattle with the Olympic Mountains in the distance.

“KOJO’s reporter, Mitchell Johansson, is at the ferry terminal. Let’s go to him now.”

“Thanks, Dan. Yes, as you can see, behind me is where the ferry went down. Helicopters are pulling out as many survivors as possible. Here’s what we know. At 7:15 this morning, an explosion occurred somewhere in the center of the Bainbridge-to-Seattle ferry. As many as 1,100 people may have been aboard. So far, fewer than one hundred are known to have survived.

“The Department of Transportation has suspended all ferry routes, effectively isolating roughly one hundred thousand island residents who depend on ferry transportation.

“We are told that A.I.M., the American Islamic Militia, has taken credit for the attack and has warned that more attacks will follow. We have to take a break. When we return, we’ll have an interview with Washington’s director of Homeland Security, Darrel Burns.”

Natasha cried, and Tom held her. She was strong, but deeply sensitive.

“All we can do is be thankful it didn’t happen the last time we took the ferry. Let’s stay home today. I’m sure we can do our research online, and if we need to, we can drive to Shelton together.”

Natasha nodded and wiped her eyes with her sleeves. She went to the kitchen and popped an English muffin into the toaster.

“Water’s probably still hot enough for your tea,” Tom called.

Natasha had at least twenty different types of tea. She pulled out a calming blend and poured the hot water into her favorite white mug. The mug was wide and shallow—half bowl, half cup—also perfect for slurping soup.

The English muffin popped up. She placed it on her plate and spooned the cheesy scrambled eggs Tom had made over it.

“Tom?” she said loudly. “Can you turn the TV down? The news is too upsetting.”

“Okay,” he hollered back. “I’ll let you know if they say anything really important.”

Clear your mind. Focus on your goals.

She closed her eyes, breathed deeply, then exhaled.

She opened her eyes and looked into the teacup. A little mound of pulverized tea leaves sat in a shallow moat of remaining tea. She swirled the cup gently, draining the liquid so the leaves clung to the mug’s surface. She gazed at them, trying to clear her mind and look for shapes.

At first, she saw nothing. Then she spotted what looked a bit like the face of a cartoon cat. Natasha smiled—a warm, genuine smile.

She stood, stretched, and looked out the window at the view. She loaded her cup and plate into the dishwasher and headed into her office.

Natasha sat at her desk, pulled out a yellow tablet, and a felt-tipped pen. What’s the plan for the day? She remembered she wanted to call Cardinal Charles in Vatican City. If anyone can help me with the “wander in the night, consumed by fire” note, it’s him.

She wrote:

1. Call Cardinal Charles.
2. Research occult connections in Mason County—start with cattle mutilations.
3. Call Jim and check his end.
4. Reassess afterward.

Natasha dialed Cardinal Charles. The phone rang with clicks and crackles before the line disconnected. “Ugh!” She dialed again. This time it went through.

“Hello, this is Cardinal Charles.”

“Hello there, Cardinal. Do you know who this is?”

A short silence followed. The line crackled and clicked.

Francis smiled. “I’d know that voice anytime, anywhere. Natasha! So nice to hear from you! Congratulations on your writing success. I always believed you’d be a great leader.”

“Thank you—and congratulations on your promotion, too. You’re really famous now.”

“I’m honored to serve Christ in this position. It’s the most challenging and interesting work I have ever done. Truly incredible. I heard about the A.I.M. attack on that ferry. Horrible. You never know where they’ll strike next.”

“Actually, Tom and I moved to the Pacific Northwest earlier this month. We just got here—and then this happens. It’s ironic because one of our reasons for leaving D.C. was thinking it was the number one target.”

“Yes. These extremist radicals will take advantage of any opportunity. Thank God you weren’t aboard that ferry. Do you live close to Seattle?”

“We live on a small island community southwest of Seattle. It takes an hour and a half to drive there, forty minutes by boat.”

“Really? I’m very good friends with someone else who has a house in that area. Which island?”

“Harstine Island.”

“What an amazing coincidence. He and his wife own a home in Jerrell’s Cove.”

“Wow!” Natasha slapped her desk lightly. “That is a coincidence. That’s where we live too!” She smiled in disbelief. “Who are they?”

“Well, I hate to namedrop, but you probably know them. President-elect Jaimeson owns a summer home there. Every time I talk to him, he tells me I have to visit. I nearly went last summer.”

“Wow. I haven’t met him yet, but I heard he had a place in Jerrell’s Cove.”

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

“He’s retired foreign service too. That’s how I know him. I met him shortly after I officiated for you and Tom. We served in Istanbul together.”

“Small world, huh?”

“Yes, it certainly is. If America had more consular officers like Will, the A.I.M.’s membership numbers would be much lower. He was tough but fair. Who knows? Maybe he saved lives. Radical Islam is the most imminent threat to our civilization. I’m using my influence at the Vatican to toughen policies and help Western governments defend against this threat.”

Natasha sensed he was restraining himself from launching into a full tirade. He caught himself, inhaled deeply, and calmed his tone.

“And it’s funny you should call, because you’ve been in my mind and prayers lately. Are you okay?”

“It’s funny how that works. I’ve been thinking of you too—and yes, I need your help with something.”

“I’m at your service.”

“Thanks, Francis. Since moving here, I became acquainted with our village Orthodox priest, Father Elijah.”

Natasha’s voice tightened.

She took a breath. “Well, he was discovered dead on Sunday.”

“Oh. I’m so sorry.”

“Me too. The sheriff thinks it was suicide, but he himself died of a heart attack later that afternoon while taking the crime scene photos. It’s very strange.”

“Yes. Go on.”

“There was a note written on the wall in his blood: *In girum imus nocte et consumimur igni*. I translated it—‘We wander in the night and are consumed by fire.’”

Natasha waited.

“It can also mean ‘At night we move in circles, and are consumed in flames.’ Very interesting,” Francis added.

“The thing is,” Natasha continued, “I don’t think it was suicide. If it wasn’t—who left the note?”

“Handwriting is your expertise. Have you told any local authorities?”

“Just the sheriff, hours before he died.”

“Anyone else?”

“The head deacon, Jim Worley. We both think something is wrong. He tried convincing Deputy Green, but the deputy is young, headstrong, and committed to the sheriff’s rushed suicide ruling. Another issue—Father Elijah left no handwriting samples. None readily available.”

“He must have left his signature somewhere—loan documents, credit card slips.”

“Possibly, but only if the deputy pushes for it. And a signature is not enough. A real analysis needs multiple samples.”

“Still, a signature might show similarities or differences.”

“That’s true—but a lot doesn’t add up. I find it hard to believe he killed himself. I was at a Christmas party with him the night before. He was joyful. Inviting people to church. And when the deputy and deacon went to his home, the deacon noticed all his documents and browsing history were erased.”

“This is very mysterious. You think he was murdered—and the message is from the killer?”

“Yes. And while the deputy does nothing, the trail grows cold and a killer wanders the night, stalking his next victim.”

“Didn’t the deputy think the erased documents were suspicious?”

“The deacon said he just brushed it aside.”

Francis absorbed the information. “The deputy might be right. Much of what you’ve told me could still be consistent with suicide.”

“How old was he?”

“Mid-thirties.”

“And unmarried?”

“Yes. How did you know?”

“You’re not the only one with intuition,” Francis teased. “The Orthodox Church allows priests to marry, yet he was still single in his mid-thirties. Did he have a strange personality? Shy?”

“No. Outgoing, well-rounded. He liked my books.”

“Hmm.”

“What are you thinking?”

“Just a scenario that might fit the facts, though I’m not sure you want to hear it.”

“No—go ahead.”

“Suicides often act joyous and outgoing beforehand. They’ve made peace with death. A weight lifts. They call old friends, have meaningful conversations, give things away, and hide their intentions because they don’t want interference.

“As for the missing computer data, it may turn up. I’ll think about the note. One way or another, we’ll figure out what it means. You’ll need a writing sample.”

“Thank you, Francis. Is it okay to call you Francis? I never know what to call you anymore,” Natasha laughed.

“No problem. You’re not exactly Roman Catholic now, so Francis is fine. I wish everyone would use my first name. I’m glad you called. Contact me anytime—and definitely if you have updates.”

“Thank you, Francis.”

“You’re welcome. Peace be with you, Natasha.”

“Mm, bye-bye.”

Maybe Father Elijah really did commit suicide. Maybe I’m reading too much into things, Natasha thought.

She suddenly grabbed her phone and ran to the kitchen. Tom was loading dishes.

“Wait!” Natasha yelled.

Tom stared as if she’d lost her mind.

“There was a kitty-cat face shape in my tea leaves and I meant to take a picture.”

Tom raised his eyebrows and grinned, amused. He stepped aside with his hands raised like a burglar caught in the act.

Natasha shoved his chest lightly.

“Do not make fun of me!” she said with a mischievous grin. She knew how ridiculous she could seem at times. She opened the dishwasher, pulled out the teacup, and looked inside. The kitty-cat face was still intact.

JOSEPH NICHOLAS

She flipped on the overhead light, aimed, and snapped a photo. Now her kitty-cat face was preserved for all time.

CHAPTER 15

Natasha sat in her study and looked out the window. An evergreen tree nearby carried a heavy layer of snow. The snow rounded the edges and made the tree look chubby. “Chubby tree.” Her thoughts turned to Father Elijah. She could hardly believe he was really dead. Whereas before she felt certain he had not taken his own life, after speaking with Cardinal Charles, it now seemed like a real possibility.

Natasha tried to remember anything he had said that would help her make up her mind. She recalled the day they first met at her book signing. He had been so charismatic, so excited to show her his “astounding” material.

As far-fetched as Jim’s connections had been, they pulled her attention anyway. They seemed to urge her to look deeper. She sensed truth in the idea that he was murdered—as horrible as that seemed—in every one of its possible scenarios.

All right. Last night we made a plan. There is no reason not to dig into the research I committed to.

She launched the internet browser and searched for results on cattle mutilations, satanic activities, and mysterious deaths in Mason County, Washington. Of course, fourteen million results showed up. She sifted through all the clickbait.

Finally, she hit pay dirt. It was an article from the November 30, 1986 issue of *The West Sounders Journal*—“Man in Custody for Murder,” and underneath, “Lucas Phillip Renard arrested for the ritualistic killing of Belfair teen Jeanette Downy.”

A mental image flashed in Natasha’s mind. She saw a thin, rugged man in his late twenties wearing faded blue jeans and a flannel shirt. He had long, greasy blond hair. He was hiding in the woods, waiting. He

crouched behind a huckleberry bush, his blue eyes focused and his lips drawn into an expression of sinister joy.

Natasha felt as though she were inside Jeanette's mind—experiencing what she experienced. She heard a twig break on the forest floor and felt that creepy sensation, as if she were being watched. She turned and saw the man. He was crouched, trying to hide from her, but now he knew she had seen him. He looked at her and did not move. He just watched her and smiled his evil smile. He flashed the blade of a buck knife. It glinted in the sunlight.

Jeanette pretended not to see him, but her heart filled with terror. She turned and ran as fast as she could, but he was already springing onto the path to chase her.

Natasha had an idea of what Lucas Phillip Renard had done even before she continued reading.

She shook her head and continued. The article said that Lucas Phillip Renard had disfigured and raped her. He had carved the number 666 into her chest. Natasha slipped back into her vision again. She could see what the sheriff had not shared with the newspaper. She saw Jeanette running from him, frantic, screaming, "Jesus, help me! Jesus, help me!"

He pounced on her like a wild cougar. He pinned her to the ground, removed a nylon cord from his pocket, and tied her arms tightly to her sides. He rolled her over, put his rough, dirty hand over her mouth, and held her head down.

Jeanette looked up at him, frightened and crying.

He cut out her vocal cords with his buck knife.

Jeanette's eyeballs rolled and darted in terrified panic—but to her horror, when the man lifted his hand from her mouth, the only sound she could make was a gurgling noise.

Natasha jerked back to reality and recoiled from her vision. *Unbelievable. How horrible.*

She typed in "Lucas Phillip Renard," and twenty-nine articles appeared to be specifically related to the killer. She clicked the third one. The headline read, "Satanic Killer Explains."

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

Her eyes locked on his photo. He was exactly as she had imagined. Under his photo was a quote in bold italic lettering:

“When my victims cry out to Jesus for help, I think it’s amusing. Lucifer charged me to kill in order to test me and to prove to me that he is the one who saves, and not the man Jesus.”

Natasha felt a chill go down her spine, and the bloody finger-painted message haunted her.

IN GIRUM IMUS NOCTE ET CONSUMIMUR IGNI

CHAPTER 16

When Natasha looked out the window again, the snow seemed less pure. She picked up the phone and dialed Jim's house. No answer. Natasha reasoned to herself, "*He's probably with Deputy Green.*" But then again, it was almost noon, and he still had not called. *That was strange. For sure, he should have called by now.*

Natasha walked to the kitchen and pulled Deputy Green's card out of her junk drawer. Tom was still watching the aftermath of the ferry attack. "How's it going, honey?" she called out.

"Well, you have not missed out on much in here. What have you been up to?"

"I came across some pretty creepy history from Mason County, just like Jim mentioned. You remember, we were expecting to hear from him by now. I just called his house, and no one answered. I think I'm going to go ahead and call Deputy Green."

Natasha sat down on the couch next to Tom and watched the coverage of the ferry tragedy as she dialed. No one answered. She held the line and let it ring a little longer. Still no answer. She pushed the flash button and dialed Jim again. No answer. Another flash, and she dialed Deputy Green's number. This time, she heard the line click.

"Sheriff Green here."

"Sheriff, thank goodness you answered. I was starting to worry."

"About what?"

"Have you heard from Jim since last night?"

"Well, I know he tried to call me late last night. I saw his number on my caller ID and tried calling him back this morning. No one answered, so I figured he'd call me when he got the chance. It's been a busy morning for me. Douglas Blair from the governor's office called and appointed me acting sheriff. I updated him on my investigation into Father Elijah's death."

“What did you tell him?”

“Just that it appears to be a suicide.”

“Did you tell him about the possibility he might have been killed?”

“You and Jim are on the same page—but you’re both wrong. I know all about this stuff, and just because you two didn’t see it coming doesn’t mean he didn’t do it. Besides, who would want to kill Father Elijah anyway?”

Natasha could not think of what to say.

“Now, Natasha, I know you’re a writer, which means you get paid for having an overactive imagination—and Jim’s an old man full of conspiracy theories and fortune-cookie sayings. Listen to me. I’m going to say this as nicely as I can. This is my investigation. Sheriff Darwood, God rest his soul, also thought it was most likely a suicide. I’m doing my own investigation, and I have to agree with the late Sheriff Darwood for now. And this is important. Governor Jaimeson has just been elected President. Any reckless rumors about supposed murders on the island could draw a spotlight—a spotlight we do not want.”

Natasha remembered the feeling in her gut from this morning and worried that maybe it was not just about the ferry. Maybe something had happened to Jim.

“Deputy—I mean, Sheriff. Jim was supposed to contact you and persuade you to let him look at the scene where Father Elijah was found. We made a plan. He was supposed to call and check in.”

“Do not worry. He’s okay.”

“I am worried. I have a really bad feeling.”

Tom motioned for the phone. She handed it to him.

“Sheriff Green. This is Tom. We had Jim over for dinner last night. I have to say I’m a bit alarmed—come to think of it—that he has not checked in. Can you meet us at his house?”

Natasha figured Sheriff Green was probably leaning back in his chair with his waffle boots propped on the desk, staring at his faux-timber office walls.

“Yeah, Tom. I have to admit. It doesn’t sound right. It’s probably nothing. But I’ll meet you at Jim’s place in, say, fifteen minutes.”

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

“We’ll be right there.”

“See you there,” Sheriff Green said as he slammed the handset down.

Natasha and Tom hopped into the Subaru and drove to Jim’s place. They walked up to his front porch and heard the Buick running. They could smell the fumes. They rang the bell. No answer.

“Why don’t you wait in the car until Green gets here, honey.”

Green arrived and parked hastily, close to the garage. He got out and shut his door hard.

“Sheriff,” Tom said. “We just got here. No one answers the door, but Jim’s Buick is running.”

Green nodded. He stood on his tiptoes and looked through the garage window.

“No! What the heck is going on around here? Now Jim’s committed suicide, too!”

Natasha turned to Tom and began to sob. She felt like she was going insane. Green snatched his radio from its belt clip.

“Dispatch, this is Sheriff Green. Over.”

“This is dispatch. Go ahead.”

“Code 1028. Send an ambulance to 211 Robin Road, Jerrell’s Cove, right away. Over.”

“Roger. Ambulance on its way. Over.”

Green grabbed the handle of the garage door and tried to open it, but it was locked.

“Jim! Jim! Are you still alive? Jim? Jim, I’m sorry I didn’t call you back!”

He kicked the door, clenched his fists, and looked up at the sky.

“Tom, I’m going around the back to break in. You and Natasha stay here—or go home if you want.”

“We’ll stay for now.”

“Suit yourself. I don’t know how much more of this she can take.”

“I don’t know how much more of this any of us can take,” Natasha snapped back. She wiped her eyes as Sheriff Green disappeared behind the house.

Suddenly they heard a gunshot.

“Whoa!” Tom exclaimed. “Get back to the car!”

Natasha started to, but the front door burst open. Sheriff Green stood there with a shotgun hole through his chest. Behind him, the killer Lucas Phillip Renard stood triumphantly.

“Ah, Satan sees Natasha,” he hissed.

Natasha stumbled backward, closed her eyes tightly, shook her head from the momentary hallucination, and looked again. Green had no shotgun wound. There was no Lucas Phillip Renard.

“Sorry if I scared you,” Green said. “Shooting the sliding glass door was the fastest way to break in.”

Natasha shook her head again, checked once more to make sure Lucas Phillip Renard wasn’t there, and then her knees buckled. She fainted.

Luckily for Natasha, Tom caught her. He and Green pulled her inside and laid her on Jim’s rusty-colored velvet sofa.

Tom knelt next to her and touched her forehead.

“She’ll be okay. Go to Jim! Maybe he can still be saved,” he told Green.

Green went into the garage. He turned off the engine and opened the garage door. It was clear Jim had been dead for several hours. He looked at the dashboard and decided it was best to keep Tom and Natasha away. In girum imus nocte et consumimur igni was scrawled in blood across the pale grey dash. His mind reminded him that suicides sometimes occurred in groups. *This odd Latin phrase, though, it would only fuel conspiracy theories.*

He went back to the living room to check on Tom and Natasha. She was conscious now. Tom was sitting beside her, holding her up.

“Tom and Natasha,” Green said solemnly. “Jim’s been dead for several hours. I need you two to go home. The rest of this is police business.”

“Come on, Tom. Let’s go. I just want to go home. Call us later and give us an update, will you?”

“I will. Tom, take her home now—and no more of these wild murder accusations. Maybe you need to take her on a vacation and get out of here for a few days. The funerals might be too much to handle.”

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

“That might not be a bad idea.” Tom thought of taking Natasha to Mexico.

CHAPTER 17

As Tom drove the last block and turned into their driveway, neither he nor Natasha noticed the strangers in the anonymous green sedan parked a few houses down.

Natasha was strong again—or the piercing look in her eyes was a mix of determination and seriousness. She was deep in thought and silent. She slammed the car door and ran straight to the bedroom. Tom went to the computer to shop for last-minute, all-inclusive vacations in Mexico, trying to clear his mind.

A few minutes later, he heard her down in the basement, beating the stuffing out of the boxing bag. He could hear her yell as she exhaled and performed a powerful roundhouse kick. The chain holding it to the ceiling rang. Puh-puh-puh-puh in rapid succession as she pummeled the bag with her fists. Puh, puh, clang, clang. Her strikes became rhythmic, and he knew it was therapeutic for her, something she needed right then.

Tom listened to her fight her emotions out. The noises she made sounded wild and primal. He had to fight an urge to search for a website that featured sexy jungle-warrior women. Instead, he kept himself focused on booking a vacation.

Three weeks in the Mexican Riviera would be perfect. He became engrossed in reading online hotel testimonials and comparing rates. His mind drifted from the death and despair of the recent days as he imagined crystal-clear tropical waters and never-ending fountains of Corona.

An hour later, Natasha was showering and Tom had already pulled out their passports and was packing. They still used the highly coveted black diplomatic passports. Their flight would leave SeaTac at 12:45 a.m., from Seattle to Miami, with a connecting flight to Cancun.

I don't wanna be around for the rest of the week, of nothing but funerals and terror news!

“This was a great idea you had, Tom! Christmas and New Year’s in Playa del Carmen. What a great idea. You’re just full of surprises!”

Suddenly, Natasha remembered the gift from Father Elijah that had arrived shortly after the hotel incident. It was the only gift under the tree. She went out to the living room and looked at it. It was wrapped in red foil paper and a green ribbon. She sat down on the floor in front of the tree Eastern-style. She picked up the gift and shook it to feel its weight and guess what might be inside. She wasn’t supposed to open it until Christmas. I think I should open it. He would want me to, I think.

She looked down at the package and tore off the wrapping. Inside the box was a handsomely embellished computer thumb drive. Its exterior casing was polished cherry wood with gold trimming. He had enclosed a note written in calligraphy. It read:

Dear Natasha,

Merry Christmas! From one writer to another, I know how great these little gadgets are. I hope you enjoy yours as much as I enjoy mine. Don’t forget Jesus is the reason for the season!

With Love in Christ,

Father Elijah Alexander

Natasha momentarily reflected that Easter owed its roots to the Roman fertility goddess, Ishtar. She bitterly remembered how, after several years of unanswered prayers, while dyeing eggs for Easter Sunday, she had dunked an egg and made a wish for a baby—as if the egg were a shooting star or a coin tossed into a fountain. It felt completely at odds with how she viewed God and Christ. She had been mildly troubled for years that Easter eggs and bunny rabbits had nothing to do with Christ, but were actually pagan symbols of fertility. And she had given in to it anyway, almost against her better judgment.

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

Though she knew most of its trappings were also of pagan origin, she still loved Christmastime. Although his death had foreclosed their budding friendship, the gift from Father Elijah still felt very special—perhaps even more so. Included with the thumb drive was a well-coordinated leather travel chain made to be worn around the neck.

I'll keep it close to my heart. She snapped the chain onto the drive and placed it around her neck.

Natasha stood up and walked back to the bedroom. “Look what Father Elijah gave me for Christmas.”

“Oh. That’s cool. Let me see that.” Tom reached out.

Natasha disconnected it and handed it to him. It reminded him of a souvenir pocketknife.

“He should have given this to me.”

“Too bad for you,” Natasha said. “I’m gonna transfer my stuff to it right now.”

“Natasha, I’m already done packing, and you haven’t even begun. So hurry up. We have to be at the airport by eleven, which means we have to leave here by nine-thirty.”

Natasha looked at her wrist to check the time, forgetting she had taken her watch off in the workout room.

“What time is it?”

“It’s already three.”

“Okay. I’ll hurry.”

Natasha ran across the hall to the office, sat down at the computer, and connected her old and new thumb-drives. She began transferring her files when the phone rang.

She answered. There was only static and faint crackling on the line. “Hello?” she said. Still nothing. She hung up.

She thought about something she had once read called electronic voice phenomenon. She wondered if she recorded the static and played it back slowly, whether there would be a message from Elijah or Jim. More likely, it was an automated telemarketing machine probing to see if anyone was home.

She looked back at her computer and resumed dragging files into her new gadget. As she moved the mouse arrow to the next file, the arrow momentarily darted off in its own direction. It was ever so slight. Natasha froze and watched it. It moved again, barely. She glanced down at her cable modem. The activity lights were blinking even though she was sure she had clicked to disconnect the Internet. Somebody had hacked into her computer.

“Oh, I caught you, whoever you are,” she said under her breath. She pulled her drive out and launched her anti-spyware program. The program would perform a TRACEROUTE back to the hackers and identify roughly where in the world they were operating from. “Gotcha.” She pounded the enter key and watched the trace.

The program traced the intrusion back to Maryland. That was as specific as it got. “*Hmm.*” Natasha pondered.

The doorbell rang. Natasha walked into the entry as Tom answered the door.

The two men standing there were wearing suits. “Thomas Ashton?” the one with short brown hair asked.

“Yes.”

Natasha put her arm around Tom’s waist and stood beside him.

“Mr. Ashton. I’m Agent Beck, and this is Agent Matthews. We’re with the United States Secret Service.”

They held up their ID wallets.

“How can I help you?” Tom asked.

“Sir, this is a Federal warrant commanding us to arrest you on the charges of espionage and high treason.”

“What?” Tom exclaimed. “This is a mistake. I’ve never done anything of the sort. I just retired from the Foreign Service.”

Agent Beck cut in, “If you’re innocent as you say, then there’s nothing to worry about. But for right now, you’ll have to come with us.”

“This is preposterous!” Natasha cried. “This is crazy!”

“Don’t worry. This will all be okay,” Tom reassured.

“Get dressed!” Beck ordered.

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

Tom grabbed his coat off the hook and put on his shoes.

“Up against the wall. Put your hands on the wall above your head.”

Agent Beck pulled out his cuffs and slapped them on Tom’s wrists. Natasha gasped.

“That’s not necessary,” Tom said. “I’ll come peacefully.”

“It is necessary. And I know you’ll come peacefully.”

Beck frisked him for weapons.

“Tom Ashton, you are being arrested on the charges of high treason and acts of espionage. You have the right to remain silent.”

Agent Matthews pulled on Tom’s cuffs, guiding him toward the unmarked sedan.

“You have the right to an attorney.”

Tom kissed Natasha.

“Don’t worry, honey. This will all get straightened out. Call Jerry right away.”

“This is crazy!” Natasha said, her voice cracking. “You guys are making a mistake.”

“If you cannot afford an attorney, the court will appoint one for you free of charge.”

Natasha kissed Tom. “Don’t worry, honey. I’ll take care of this. I love you.”

“I love you, too. Don’t worry. I’ll be okay. Just call Jerry right away.”

Agent Matthews opened the back door and protected Tom’s head as he guided him inside. Agent Beck followed. As they drove off, Tom turned his head to keep his eyes on Natasha. She stood at the door a moment longer, trying to comprehend what had just happened. She looked down at the arrest warrant in her hands. This is scary shit, she thought.

She closed the door and went back to the office to call their attorney. It was four already. With any luck, he would still be in his office.

Jeremy Benton’s voicemail greeted her.

“Hi, Jerry. Listen! This is Natasha Ashton. I really need you to call me right away.”

JOSEPH NICHOLAS

Natasha felt queasy and weak again. *Oh no. What am I going to do?* She staggered back to the bedroom, flopped on the bed, pulled the covers up around her head, and passed out.

CHAPTER 18

Natasha dreamt that she was scuba diving with Tom in the Mediterranean. Father Elijah was guiding them. They were looking at the exotic, colorful wildlife, but Natasha suddenly realized that Father Elijah was leading them to a secret place underwater. A Plexiglas-encased artifact seemed to be pulling him through the tropical waters. Natasha noticed that he was studying a glowing treasure map on the reverse side of the artifact.

Tom was struggling with his buoyancy control. Natasha was afraid for him. If he ascended out of control toward the surface, his lungs would explode. She reached up, grabbed Tom's leg, and tried to pull him back down. When she started to float up too, panic surged through her. She exhaled all the air in her lungs and pressed the purge button on her BCD vest, but the more they floated, the more buoyant they became. She remembered her SCUBA certification—Always Be Breathing. Suddenly, she felt a grasp on her calf. It was Father Elijah. He pulled them back down to safety. He held up two fingers, pointed to his eyes, and then pointed into the distance.

Natasha looked and recognized the hazy outline of an ancient cityscape of medieval towers and domed mega-structures. As they swam closer, she could make out the shapes and colors. What was this place? Atlantis? She could now read the letters on one of the buildings as they drew closer. “C o v r t H o v s e” was spelled in ancient tradition, as on the front of old courthouses with a “V” instead of a “U.” Father Elijah pointed to his eyes again and then to the map on the artifact. It was acting like a homing device. A circular track shape was glowing yellow and blinking. A glowing red indicator—similar to cell phone reception bars—pulsated with an underwater alarm.

Natasha looked up. They were being circled by a school of vicious barracuda. The barracuda bared their razor-sharp teeth and tightened

their circle, their silvery scales reflecting violet from the pulsating light. The alarm on the map continued to pulse. Suddenly, Natasha was awakened by the realization that her cell phone was ringing. Her mind felt broken and her eyes felt glued shut. She answered the phone.

“Hello?” Natasha said anxiously. She still felt disoriented from being torn out of her dream.

“Is this Natasha Ashton?”

“Yes.”

“This is the Vatican switchboard operator. Please hold the line for His Eminence Cardinal Secretary of State Francis Charles.”

“Guess who?” Francis asked.

“I don’t know. Could it be ‘His Eminence the Secretary of State Francis Charles?’”

“Ah. You got me.”

“Yeah. You’ve got quite the introduction service.”

“I can assure you, it’s not that at all. All of my outbound international calls go through the switchboard.”

“It’s okay, Francis. I’m very proud of you. It’s nice to get a call from such an important person.”

“Natasha, what do you think could cause me to call you at five a.m. my time?” Francis looked out his window, only the first hint of sunrise illuminating St. Peter’s Square.

“I don’t know. Were you able to come up with anything?”

“Well, I didn’t have a lot of time yesterday. I had to make diplomatic calls to President-Elect Jaimeson and the President. I didn’t have any time for the type of in-depth research I know you’d expect of me.”

“That’s okay. Of course. You must have been very busy.”

“But not too busy to think critically about your situation, Natasha. At first, I thought the message—‘we circle in the night, or we wander in the darkness, and are consumed by fire’—might be referring to the movement of the planets or perhaps rogue satellites falling back into the atmosphere, but none of that makes sense in the context. Then I thought again about your theory that the priest may have been murdered, and the note left by the killer.”

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

“Yes,” Natasha said. “Maybe it’s a clue to the killer’s identity.”

Francis ignored the comment and continued. “So, I kept thinking. And do you know what else circles in the darkness and is then consumed by fire?”

“What?”

“The ordinary—or should I say extraordinary—firefly. At night, it will circle around a campfire. It will fly closer and closer—attracted to the light—until, finally, it flies too close to the fire and is consumed by the flames.”

Natasha was fully awake now. Francis paused, waiting for her reaction.

“That is true,” Natasha said. “It fits the behavior of a firefly rather well.”

“Natasha,” Francis said seriously. “I do not think this is a clue to the killer’s identity. I think it is a deadly warning.”

“A warning to whom?”

“A warning to you—and to anyone else who shares your circumstances. For example, able to translate Latin and acquainted with the deceased.”

“I see. Kind of like don’t get too close to the fire or you might get burned.”

“Or curiosity killed the cat.”

“Oh, my go...” Natasha shifted her wording midstream. “Goodness!”

Jim fit the criteria too. Natasha rubbed her eyes. “Francis, today has been an absolute nightmare. When I researched the history of the area on a lead that Father Elijah’s death might be occult-related, I uncovered a creepy history of local devil worshippers. Then we discovered Deacon Jim Worley dead of an apparent suicide. When we got home, I noticed my computer was being hacked from Maryland and, a moment later, the Secret Service showed up at the doorstep with an arrest warrant for Tom, ludicrously accusing him of espionage.”

“This is indeed a bad situation. Another church member is dead? Are you telling me that you are there all alone?”

“Yes—and Deacon Worley had theorized last night that the Father might have been assassinated over secret knowledge he may have uncovered, hidden in the prophecies of the Book of Revelation.”

“The Apocalypse,” Francis emphasized. He stood at his window, clasped his hands behind his back, and looked intently into the distance. His eyes squinted in concentration. “Natasha, if these deaths are the result of foul play, then you could be on a very short list of who might be the next victim. There are not many scholars like you on that island, I would think. I fear you are in mortal danger.”

“That might be, but I am not worried about myself. I am worried about Tom.”

“Natasha, Tom is safe for right now. You are alone, but Tom’s situation adds to your vulnerability. Not only does it leave you alone, but I will bet that an order to freeze your bank accounts is already in the works.”

Natasha’s eyes widened. She was not worried about the money—it was the seriousness of the situation sinking deeper. The line clicked. “Hello. Are you there?” Francis asked.

“Yes. I was just thinking about what you said.”

“Natasha, withdraw as much cash as you can from your ATM and catch the first flight to Rome. You will be safe here as my guest at the Vatican. We can work together to help Tom. But it is imperative you leave right away.”

Natasha pictured Tom alone in a jail cell. “But I would feel like I was abandoning him.”

“No. Not at all. Trust me. He is worried about you. He will be overjoyed at the news. We will get this all squared away from here.”

“Okay,” Natasha said. “I will call you as soon as I know my flight plan.”

“Excellent. See you here.”

“Okay, bye.” She hung up the phone.

CHAPTER 19

Natasha looked at her wrist again for her watch. “Ah.” She recalled fighting the bag earlier, and Handel’s Hallelujah Chorus played in her mind as she jaunted down the stairway to the basement.

Natasha flipped the light switch when she reached the bottom, but the lights did not come on. The room was dark. She could see her watch on the other side of the basement; it glimmered in the moonlight shining in from the windows high on the wall. She was about to continue into the darkness when she sensed an evil presence. She quickly shut the door to the basement and locked it. As she did, she shot a lightning-fast glance at the windows. Just as she feared. The latch on the window closest to the corner was unlocked—unnerving, since she was sure it had been locked earlier in the day. *Forget the watch.*

Natasha ran up the stairs, nearly petrified and shaking. She had not felt so close to such an intense aura of evil since sitting across a courtroom from the twisted visage of Gilbert Carver. In less than sixty seconds, she dressed, grabbed her purse, and loaded it with her keys, passport, cell phone, pepper spray, and thumb drive.

She was about to exit to the garage on the way to the car, but she stopped again. She remembered Jim. Killed in his garage. What if the killer was hiding in the shadows there, or hunched in the back of her car? She tried to clear her mind of fear and use her senses. The car felt wrong. The garage felt wrong. An image of her snowmobile floated to the top of her mind. It felt right. Then an image of Jim’s boat, with his keys hidden under the captain’s chair, surfaced. She felt the influence of a helping spirit. She sensed it was Jim, urging her toward the water.

“But why, Jim? Give me a reason to believe this is not a crazy idea,” she asked him telepathically.

The answer came as a new thought drifted in: *Not safe. Killer expects you will attempt to flee by car.* Whether it was her own thought or Jim's was impossible to tell. For all Natasha knew, her mind was making up the answers to her own questions.

Natasha grabbed the remote and turned the TV on, the volume a little higher than usual. She snuck out quietly through the sliding glass door on the back deck. Her heart was pounding as she jumped on the snowmobile. *What if it would not start?* She slid in the key and pushed the start switch.

The snowmobile started right up. Natasha squeezed the throttle and raced out from the back of the property and into the trailheads that led to the marina. She flew through the dark forest trails, the headlights and the scattered moonlight shining through the branches barely giving her enough time to react to the bends and low-hanging brush.

Natasha could not look behind her, but she could sense the evil chasing her. She raced downhill through that last dangerous curve. *"Almost there. When you get there, be careful. If you twist your ankle, you'll be dead meat."* She parked the snowmobile as close as she could to the marina entrance. She looked around. It was completely deserted. She listened, but heard nothing.

Natasha made each step deliberately and carefully, but also quickly, on her way to Jim's boat, Foresta. She climbed in and untied it. She found the keys under his seat, engaged the ignition, pushed the throttle lever forward, and cruised out of Jerrell's Cove. Downtown Seattle was the only place she could think to head. It would be all lit up, easy to find. She would figure out later who needed to hear what about why she had absconded with a dead man's boat. What would have seemed like an irresponsible trespass earlier now felt like a minor detail in the scheme of things. Somehow, she sensed Jim would have agreed.

When I get there, I can take a taxi the rest of the way to SeaTac Airport. She was out on open water now. The waves were choppy. She looked up and saw the moon rising over the Cascade Mountains. It was beautiful. Natasha sighed. She no longer sensed the evil pursuing her. She steered the boat and watched as the Seattle skyline grew larger and brighter.

CHAPTER 20

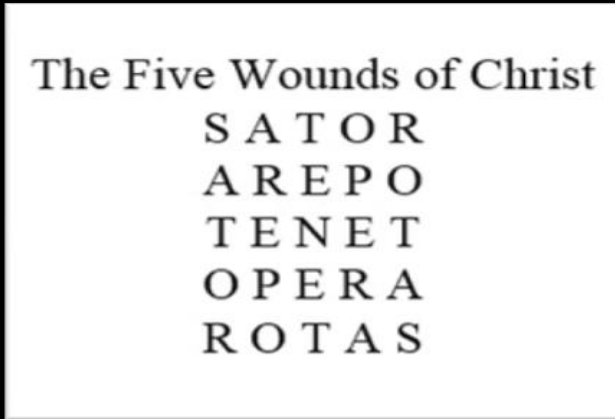
Francis closed the Bible on his desk and stood up. He clasped his hands behind his back and paced back and forth in front of the window. The sun was setting in Vatican City. Large, fluffy snowflakes floated like feathers down to the cobblestone streets. The sky was pink, and the edges of the clouds appeared to be glazed in gold. He stood and watched the sunset for a moment longer. He looked out into the distance and thought about Natasha—how strange it was that she had gotten herself mixed up in all this business on Governor Jaimeson’s Island. And now she was on her way to be his guest. She hoped that he, the “High and Mighty” Francis Charles, would be able to help her husband escape from charges of espionage and high treason.

Francis performed an “about-face” and considered the suitability of his home to accommodate Natasha. The apartment could more accurately be described as a palace. The ceilings were twenty feet tall, and the outside wall was floor-to-ceiling windows that looked out to St. Peter’s Square. In the middle of the wall of windows, enormous double French doors opened from the formal living room onto his private terrace.

Adjacent to the formal living room was Francis’ private library and home office. It also had a view and an access door to the terrace. His library was rich with his private collection of books, and his desk was oversized and made from a beautiful cherry wood. The wall opposite the windows displayed a large triptych—a portrait of the moment when the followers of Christ carried His tortured body down from the cross. Incongruously, the figures were shown dressed in the embellished fashions of the Renaissance. Mary, the mother of Christ, and Mary Magdalene stood by as the men carried His body. The men were perhaps Joseph of Arimathea and James, the brother of Jesus. The artist had

employed a Sepia color palette and had painted the scene with almost photorealism, giving it a haunting depth.

A fourth work of art punctuated the set of three paintings. It matched the style and color of the others. “The Five Wounds of Christ” was written in sepia print across the top of this fourth work. Below this title, printed in giant reddish-brown letters, were the legendary names of each of the five wounds, stark and solemn on the canvas.



Francis walked across his office to the wet bar and poured himself a glass of Merlot. His face was red from years of occasional drinking. His cheeks and nose were marked with blood vessels, webbing out like veins on the underside of a leaf, though it was not quite rosacea.

Francis downed his glass and poured another. He walked over to the grand piano in the main entrance room, sat down, and began to play dramatic, melancholy chords. He played hard; eventually, his playing settled into a soothing rhythm. He played four of the same chord, rose to the next, then returned to the first chord, repeating the pattern four times.

He sang the words to the music he felt he had written a thousand years ago. He could hardly remember the song in its original language, and the English words he improvised felt stilted, unworthy of his poetic gifts.

“In Rome, it’s a cold and lonely night
And the moonlight isn’t shining very bright

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

Friends aren't really friends, they just pretend
And love's not really love, it's a dead end.
And I'm a lonely man.
The pain I'm going through, no one understands.
And I'm a lonely man
If she can't love me, I think no one can."

The chords continued. His right hand flew over the higher notes. Francis felt the wine warming his cheeks now. His music thundered through the palace, echoing off marble floors and high ceilings.

Francis rose from the piano and walked back to his office. His desk held a large flat-screen monitor and a wireless telephone headset. He put on the headset and dialed zero for the switchboard operator.

"This is Secretary of State Charles. Please connect me with the United States Attorney General."

He stood at his window again, hands clasped behind his back. The Christmas lights of the Vatican shone magnificently. Three minutes passed before the operator returned.

"Your Eminence, the U.S. Attorney General is on the line. Please hold."

"Mr. Attorney General, thank you for taking my call."

"Not at all. It is a pleasure. What can I do for you?"

"I know the wheels of justice are turning, but I felt the need to call personally to let you know I support your work to bring Tom Ashton to justice. I have the Vatican security surveillance photos your office requested—Tom Ashton meeting with Russian agent Alexei Kirov. Before I make them available, I want your personal assurance that Natasha Ashton will be left out of this matter."

"You have my word, Your Eminence. Thank you for your cooperation so far."

"Do you know why Tom Ashton wasn't arrested back then?" the Attorney General asked.

"Tom Ashton was not prosecuted because no one wanted to tip off the Russians—and our alliance was secret from the public. Diplomatic relations between the Vatican and the U.S. government were still young.

JOSEPH NICHOLAS

I hope you understand how important it is to us that he is prosecuted vigorously.”

“I could not agree more, Your Eminence. This is a very important case for the Justice Department as well. He will be prosecuted to the full extent of the law.”

“Thank you, Mr. Attorney General. Please keep me informed of any progress you can report.”

“Certainly, Your Eminence.”

“May the Lord bless you. Go in peace, my son.”

“Thank you, Your Eminence.”

Francis pressed the “end call” button on his headset.

A small white jeweler’s box rested on the corner of his desk. He picked it up and flipped it open. Inside lay a gold watch he planned to give Natasha when she arrived. He had it inscribed with a Latin proverb, more fitting than she could imagine.

“ROMA TIBI SUBITO MOTIBUS IBIT AMOR”

“By me, you arrive in Rome, the love of your travels.” Francis held the watch, reading the inscription aloud. He smiled and returned the watch to its case.

CHAPTER 21

Governor Jaimeson's situation room was a beehive of frenetic activity. Ceiling-mounted projectors showcased three separate news channels. The ferry disaster was one of the deadliest single terrorist attacks in US history. At least 915 people were confirmed dead.

An enormous round conference table stood in the center of the room. It was crafted from a rich, reddish polished wood. In the center, the Jaimeson family crest was artfully inlaid. The table was approximately bar height. Barstools lined its perimeter, though they were rarely used. Jaimeson knew Thomas Jefferson had favored a standing desk. People standing around a high table remained more energetic than if they sat. They could reach across, walk around, and come and go more easily.

Around the table was a "who's who" of the Washington State executive branch: William and Meredith Jaimeson, Douglas Blair, Lieutenant Governor Richard Winslow, General Alfonzo Perez of the State National Guard, and Admiral Justin Baker of the State Coast Guard.

Janice walked up to the Governor's right side and spoke softly in his ear. "Governor Jaimeson, sir. Darrel Burns from Homeland Security has just arrived by helicopter. He'll be escorted to the situation room momentarily."

"Good," Will said.

Janice returned to her station outside the room, and Will turned to Meredith. "I'll be interested in hearing what he has to say."

"Governor," Douglas Blair said, "Darrel Burns just finished a live interview on KOJO in which he essentially blamed our administration for not appointing enough State Patrol officers on the ferry system. I'm not sure I trust him in your situation room, sir."

“Noted, Douglas. Everyone,” Will said, looking around at his team, “today is a test for us. Douglas has raised an important point. There’s no escaping it. Accusations will fly, fingers will be pointed, and our political rivals will use this disaster for their own purposes. We must not fall into that trap. We must rise above it. Today, more than 900 people were murdered by a diabolical madman. Our mission is to stay focused! We must work together. Leadership is not about how well one can work with friends, but how well one can work with adversaries!

“We will not play the blame game. Let us not forget—let us never forget—that this disaster is the work of a terrorist. From what I know so far, there may be more attacks in the works, whether here in Washington State, Washington DC, or elsewhere. We must come together and cooperate. We must learn everything we can from one another.”

Automatic glass doors slid open, and Darrel Burns entered.

“Governor, First Lady, Gentlemen. Let me start by apologizing. My words came out wrong on the KOJO interview. As you can imagine, it has been a horrible and difficult day. I did the best I could during the interview.”

“Apology accepted, Mr. Burns. We were just discussing your comments. We know you meant to communicate that the persons responsible are members of A.I.M. We must all work together and learn from one another. Finger pointing and blame games are not appropriate—the public sees through such rhetoric for what it is: political games. The citizens of Washington know my administration has worked tirelessly on counter-terrorist measures. They also know the State House of Representatives voted down my proposal for increased spending on State Patrol. And they know there was no heightened alert status from the Federal Government.”

“Yes, Governor,” Burns said. “With a humble spirit, I agree—and I am here to help. Here is what we know so far. The NSA has intercepted chatter. They are expecting a secondary event, but we do not know where or when. We also have intel that suggests the explosion on the ferry was consistent with one caused by a truck full of fertilizer chemicals. Satellite surveillance shows the explosion was massive.”

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

The glass doors opened again. Press Secretary Pete Thomas approached the Governor and spoke softly in his ear.

“Sir, I’ve finished fine-tuning your speech. It has everything you requested. Your press conference is scheduled in thirty minutes.”

“Thank you, Pete. That’s excellent. Gentlemen, continue to work together. I must prepare my remarks for the press conference, which begins in less than thirty minutes. When I return, I want specific proposals on three things:

1. How can we best help the families of the victims?
2. What do we need to do to get the ferry system running again?
3. A list of likely next targets and what we can do immediately to thwart attacks on them.”

Governor Jaimeson walked toward the exit. The glass doors slid open; he passed through and turned right toward his private study. Pete Thomas followed him.

Jaimeson’s cell rang. He flipped it open and put it to his ear.

“Governor Jaimeson?”

“Yes, this is he.”

“This is the switchboard operator at the Vatican Embassy. Please hold for Secretary of State Francis Charles.”

Francis Charles stood in front of the giant window in his Vatican apartment. He watched the snowflakes in Saint Peter’s Square as he held the line. The view reminded him of the souvenir snow globes commonly sold in tourist shops.

“Your Eminence, please hold. Governor Jaimeson is standing by for your call.”

“Will, this is Francis. I know you must be busy, but I felt compelled to call you.”

“Thank you, Cardinal. I need all the help I can get right now, but I must let you know I am pressed for time at the moment.”

“All right. I’ll be brief. Two quick things I want to communicate. First, my prayers are with you—and the Vatican supports you. I feel compelled to advise you to speak and act strongly against the Islamic radicals. This is no time for political correctness. It is a time for decisive, honest

leadership. I know you epitomize that—but I felt I should share this in case your press team has advised otherwise.

“Second, an amazing coincidence. I have two very old and dear friends who also live on Jerrell’s Cove. We served together in Rome twenty years ago: Natasha and Tom Ashton. Natasha called me this morning and told me what happened to the village Orthodox priest. She believes he may have been murdered.

“I mention this because members of the press may bring it up during any potential press conference. Since we spoke the day of his death, I know you were on your boat alone and near where he was found. You need to be prepared for any such questions.”

“As always, Cardinal Francis, you are a wise and trusted advisor. I am just now headed to my study to read the final draft of my prepared remarks. Your call could not have been timelier. Regarding the second matter, I appreciate your input as well. Though I feel it likely won’t come up, I will follow your advice and consider in advance how to respond. Please keep me in your prayers.”

“I always do. Keep me in yours as well. May the Lord bless you, Will. Go in peace.”

“Thank you, Cardinal. You are always in our prayers too. I’ll call you as soon as I can. Goodbye.”

“Goodbye, Will. Go in peace.”

Will opened the door to his study. He slapped the speech down on his desk as he sat. Pete sat across from him, silently awaiting his reaction.

“Terrific work, Pete. Just one thing: I need stronger language regarding the Islamic radicals and their responsibility. Please leave me to make those changes and bring the speech back to me in ten minutes. Janice, I’ll need to be undisturbed for the next ten minutes.”

“Yes, sir.”

“Thank you.”

Pete got up immediately. “Thank you, sir. I’ll be right back with the revised stronger language.”

Pete left, closing the door carefully. Will closed his eyes and cleared his mind.

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

“That’s right, honey,” he heard his mother’s voice in his head. “The people need you to be strong. They need you to give them hope.”

CHAPTER 22

Natasha deplaned in Rome and immediately noticed a limousine driver holding a sign with her name on it.

"I'm Natasha Ashton," she said as she walked up to him.

"Pleasure to meet you, madam. No baggage?"

"No," Natasha laughed. "Not a single bag. Just me and my purse."

She laughed again and followed the driver. Her face was puffy from sleeping on the plane. The driver opened the door, and Francis Charles took her hand to help her inside. Despite his ruddy cheeks and nose, her first impression was that he had hardly aged. Golden, square-rimmed glasses framed his penetrating dark brown eyes; a faint widow's peak and a full head of coarse black hair crowned his prominent forehead.

"Francis!"

Natasha gave him a joyous hug, and he kissed her on the cheek.

"Good to see you, Natasha. I've missed you more than you know. So good to see you. Where is your luggage?"

"Francis, you were right. As soon as I got off the phone with you, I sensed an evil presence in my home. I noticed one of the basement windows had been opened, and I followed my instincts, grabbed my purse, and got the heck out of there. I was too afraid to even cross the basement floor to get my watch."

"Thank God, Natasha. You don't know how worried I was for you. I sensed it too. I felt you were in danger, but now you're safe." Francis reached out and caressed the side of her head. "And look at you. You must be so tired from travel, but you're as beautiful as ever."

"Thank you, Francis. You look great too. And I'm so proud of you."

"Natasha, if it's okay, my assistant is awaiting my call. She will procure you some fresh clothes." Francis dialed and handed the phone to Natasha. "Just tell her your measurements."

Natasha took the phone from him and relished speaking Italian again. As she gave the girl her measurements, she smiled and watched the Italian countryside fly by at a hundred kilometers per hour.

Natasha felt excited to be back in Rome. The sights and smells triggered her memories and made her forget the trauma and fatigue of recent days. All the excitement of her younger years rushed back into her blood. It was invigorating. Rome was so beautiful—a city full of trees, parks, ancient architecture, and old-world charm.

“Grazie,” she told the girl, locked the phone, and handed it back to Francis.

“Francis. Were you able to find out anything about Tom? Is there anything you can do to help?”

“As a matter of fact, while you were on your way, I placed a call to the American Attorney General and spoke to him personally.”

“What? You are kidding me? What?”

Natasha smiled at her old friend in admiration.

“What did you tell him? What did he say?”

“Put it this way,” Francis said. “I very diplomatically expressed to the Attorney General my belief that Tom is completely innocent of the charges. And I personally asked him to look into the matter for me.”

“What did he say?”

“He was polite. He said that he would look into it for me. He’s a good Roman Catholic, and I think this craziness will get cleared up very quickly. I’d be surprised if we didn’t hear some good news by tonight. I take it you have a good attorney as well?”

“Jeremy Benton. Of course I’m sure he’s never had a case like this. Nevertheless, he is very competent. I spoke with him during my layover, and he said Tom’s arraignment won’t be until Monday morning. Can you believe that?”

“That does seem like an awfully long time. Don’t worry, my dear! Everything will be fine.”

He caressed her cheek again.

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

“You’ll see. Believe me. The best thing you can do for Tom’s sake is to relax and rest. He’ll be so happy and relieved to know that you are safe here at the Vatican. I’ll try to arrange a call with him today. You’ll see.”

Natasha nodded her head and smiled. She felt the slightest bit of discomfort with this second caress from Francis. *He sure is touchy-feely*, she thought. Mostly, she was thankful that he had actually spoken to the Attorney General on Tom’s behalf. She felt guilty to even think that something could be wrong with this wonderful man, giving her a comforting caress. He really does care. He really cares about people, she reassured herself.

She leaned over to Francis and kissed his cheek.

“Thank you, Francis.”

Natasha looked out the window again and saw they were getting closer. The scenery was turning a little more industrial. Her eyes felt heavy, and she yawned.

“Wait until you sink into your bed,” Francis said. “It’s fit for a queen. You may never want to leave it.”

“I slept on the plane, but I’m still a little sleepy.”

The limo approached Vatican City and stopped at the VIP entrance gate. Natasha was awestruck. A Vatican Swiss Guard checked the undercarriage, and a second Swiss Guard walked a bomb-sniffing dog around the vehicle. They gave the driver a nod, and the gates opened. A few moments later, they were home.

“Natasha, Nicholas will show you to your quarters. I’m very sorry, but I must continue on to a breakfast meeting. Please make yourself at home, and I’ll check in on you later.”

“Thanks. I plan on showering and then sleeping half the day. I’ll see you later.”

Nicholas opened the door and took her hand to help her out. He was young, perhaps just out of college, and though he didn’t look entirely like Francis Charles, she could see that time with him had imbued him with some of the latter’s mannerisms.

“Bye! See you later!”

JOSEPH NICHOLAS

She smiled and turned toward the palace apartment. The limo driver pushed the accelerator and whisked Francis off to his meeting with the Holy Father.

CHAPTER 23

Natasha awoke to the sound of gentle piano music drifting down the halls into her suite. She was sunk deep into the soft bed. Slowly, she got up and dressed in the simple, clean clothes hung neatly in her closet. Her new undergarments and pajamas had been laid out on the bed for her, while the clothes she had been wearing were taken to the laundry. The young woman who worked for Francis had done a fine job, procuring two light-gray pairs of thick wool trousers and a snow-white wool sweater.

She smiled as she followed the source of the music back to the main entrance hall. Sunshine streamed diagonally through the huge windows in front of the terrace, stretching across the marble floor like a spotlight aimed at Francis. He was singing softly.

“I’ve seen a mother’s prayers be answered
When life’s struggles got too rough.
I’ve seen an old man healed of cancer
I’ve seen a lonely man find love!”

He intensified his playing on the last part and smiled up at Natasha as he led into the chorus.

“And ... I’ve seen the light of God shine through
I’ve seen His promise of new life come true
I’ve experienced His joy and hope
And I know that you can too
I’ve seen the light of God shine through.”
Francis slowed, singing softly again for the second verse.
“I’ve seen a child kneel beside her bed
I’ve seen her Mommy change her ways
I’ve seen a homeless person being fed
You see what happens when we pray.”

Once again, he intensified his playing and returned to the chorus, finishing with soft, charismatic flourish as his fingers danced through the higher notes before settling on the final rich chord.

Natasha stood at the curve of the piano, hands on her hips, watching in admiration.

“Bravo! Bravo! Bravissimo! Bravissimo!”

Francis stood and took a bow to his audience of one. “You must be starving!”

Natasha nodded and smiled.

“Well, then come with me. I hope we have what you’re hungry for. I had Maria fix up a few things.”

Natasha marveled at the kitchen. It was the size of a three-car garage, with a breakfast nook near the windows. Off the side of the nook, double doors led onto the terrace.

“If it weren’t so cold, we could have coffee and breakfast out there,” Francis said, gesturing toward the terrace.

Natasha looked at the island bar, laid out with two catering-style hotplates—one with scrambled eggs, the other with a potato skillet dish. Nearby, a bowl of sliced fruit offered apples, grapes, peaches, mango, kiwi, and cantaloupe. Another plate held a pyramid of croissants.

Natasha popped a croissant into the toaster oven, dished up some eggs and potatoes, but mostly filled her plate with fruit salad. She grabbed the croissant and sat at the table. Francis followed, serving himself heavily on eggs and potatoes, lightly on fruit salad.

“Natasha, you won’t believe it. The Holy Father and I have been prayerfully drafting an announcement of one of the greatest church reforms in modern history. Have you ever noticed that while the Roman Catholic Church suffered from a plague of pedophilia among priests, one never hears of such problems in the Orthodox Church? Why do you think that is?”

Natasha thought a moment, sipping her coffee and glancing sideways out the window.

“Do you think it’s because Orthodox priests can marry and have families?” she asked.

“Precisely.”

“Among other things, the new reforms I’m working on will lay aside doctrine that denies God’s servants the opportunity to have families of their own.” Francis’s eyes welled with tears.

“Oh my goodness, Francis! That’s the most sweeping reform in a millennium.”

“Without this change, I do not believe the Roman Catholic Church can survive. The number of young men interested in the priesthood has plummeted. You have no idea the hurt and sacrifice that doctrine causes,” Francis continued. “You have no idea the sacrifices I have had to make to get where I am today. And even in all of this—even with all I have achieved—how empty it feels to have no one to share it with. I feel hollow!” He pounded his chest with his fist, eyes still wet.

Natasha went to him, kneeling and embracing him. She felt ashamed that she had been irritated earlier, ashamed that she feared he might misinterpret her affection. Teary-eyed, she lifted her head and met his gaze.

“Of course you’re lonely, Francis. I’m so sorry I haven’t done a better job staying in touch. But I’m here with you right now.”

“Thank you, Natasha. Please forgive me for getting emotional. This reform is too close to my heart.” He gently lifted her shoulders to urge her up.

Natasha returned to her chair. “I know a little of what you mean. Since I cannot have children—and all the money in the world cannot dull the pain of being barren—Tom is all I have. And we love our life. But sometimes, when I see a beautiful, innocent baby smile at her mother, it really hurts. It’s a dull ache in my heart and stomach. The pain of a broken heart.”

“Yes. At least you have each other.”

Francis forced a smile, then remembered the gift for Natasha and smiled more genuinely. “I almost forgot. I have a surprise for you. Wait right here. I’ll be back.”

He hurried to his office and returned with a gift box. “I hope you don’t mind.”

JOSEPH NICHOLAS

“Francis! You didn’t have to.”

“Tom’s all you’ve got, but you’re all I’ve got. I couldn’t resist. Please open it.”

Natasha smiled her “you-shouldn’t-have” smile and tore off the paper. “It’s beautiful!” she exclaimed, pulling out the watch and checking the time.

“I have one more for you, but you’ll have to wait until Christmas Eve.”

Natasha read the inscription aloud. “ROMA TIBI SUBITO MOTIBUS IBIT AMOR. By me, you arrive in Rome, the love of your travels. Wonderful, Francis! And thank you so much for this—and for your hospitality. You’re a great friend.”

“I’m glad you like it.” He looked satisfied. They both returned to their food. “That was good,” Francis said, patting his thin belly. “Find out as much as you can about Tom today. This evening, we’ll make some calls.”

“You have a deal.”

“All right then. See you tonight. Don’t lift a finger. Nicholas will drive you anywhere or fetch anything you need. Don’t hesitate to call.”

“Thanks. I won’t. See you tonight.”

“Have fun, Natasha. It’s Christmas, and you are in Rome!”

CHAPTER 24

Tom leaned back against the cold prison wall. He was sitting on his bunk and looking up at the television. The news channel was still reporting nonstop about the ferry attack. Sound bites from President-elect Jaimeson's well-received "Freedom from Terror" speech were playing again.

"Dear Citizens. In the wake of one of the single most deadly terror attacks in U.S. history, we find ourselves at a crossroads. Shall we continue the battles for peace and stability in foreign lands? Or shall we fight for the peace and stability of our own land? For too long we have focused on one and not the other. It is time we remember the inheritance from our forefathers. They sacrificed to give the citizens of our nation the promise of Life, Liberty, and the Pursuit of Happiness. These are the ideals worth fighting for. These are the ideals worth dying for. And in the defense of the lives of our innocent citizens, yes, these are the ideals worth killing for."

Governor Jaimeson's speech reminded Tom of his new home in Washington State. He wondered how Natasha was doing. Jeremy Benton had told him she had traveled to the Vatican at the invitation of Francis Charles. Tom's mind drifted back to the afternoon he had been arrested. *It doesn't look good. The fact that I was planning to fly to Mexico that night—a prosecutor could twist that into evidence that I was planning to flee the country, he thought.*

Tom flipped the channel. Governor Jaimeson was in the middle of answering a question when Tom started listening.

"We must cast aside political correctness and adopt a realistic approach. It is clear who our enemies are. They are men of Middle Eastern descent who have adopted the perverted worldview of radical

fundamentalist Islam. These men are not in a foreign country—they are here among us. They are in our cities and towns.”

“Yes, Governor Jaimeson,” the interviewer probed. “But what are you proposing as a solution?”

“Here’s one example,” the Governor answered. “Visa applicants from certain troublesome regions could be required to pay a fee that will cover the cost of an enhanced Department of Homeland Security background check.”

The interviewer looked into the camera.

“And we’ll be right back with President-elect and Governor William Jaimeson after the break.”

Tom turned the TV off. He folded his hands over his stomach and stared at the ceiling, thinking about his predicament.

I’ll bet this is about Alexei Kirov. They had met three days before Alexei vanished in 2003. Alexei had seemed paranoid. He was sweating profusely, and his eyes darted nervously around the room.

“They’re after me,” Alexei had said.

“Who?” Tom had asked.

Alexei shook his head in irritation. I don’t have time to explain—and even if I did, you’d think I was crazy. Thanks for your help, Tom. I have to go. He stood up from the table, holding the file in his left hand close to his body.

Alexei had seemingly eluded his pursuers. Tom had learned that the Russians had continued searching for him for weeks.

The file Tom had given Alexei contained ten copies of an “apartment for rent” flyer. Alexei needed to leave suddenly and had asked Tom for help in making the flyers so his landlord could lease the flat quickly.

Tom stood and offered his hand. “How will I reach you?”

“I have friends in Istanbul. Seek wisdom there.”

“Good-bye, then.”

“Das vedanya.” Alexei said goodbye in Russian.

Tom cracked his knuckles as he remembered that final handshake with Kirov. His eyes searched the ceiling. *Seek wisdom there? What did Kirov mean by those parting words anyway?*

CHAPTER 25

Natasha went back to her suite. She walked over to the window and drew the drapes aside to look down into the busy streets. Christmas shoppers and tourists bustled hither and thither. Some rode in horse-drawn carriages. That would be nice. She made a mental note to ask Nicholas about arranging such a ride.

Natasha picked her cell phone off the desk and dialed her voicemail. It was still the middle of the night in the States, but she hoped that, by some miracle, Tom might have been able to call her. She had one new message.

“Natasha, I’ve been concerned about you, darling.” She recognised the rich tone of voice and crisp British accent. “I happened to be in the Seattle area yesterday and stopped over to give you a surprise visit; however, you and Tom were not to be found. I know something is wrong. Give me a ring, my dear. Day or night, it doesn’t matter. Right away—it is important.”

Grant Nuby had to be the most amazing psychic medium she had ever known. Natasha’s gift was more of a talent that came and went. It was spontaneous and unreliable. Except in matters of personal guidance, it was almost useless.

Grant Nuby, however, was skilled. His abilities were more like carefully focused powers. They were at his will. He could control them. He could harness his power and direct it.

And if he’s concerned... She did not want to even think. She knew Grant had been scientifically verified to be 85 percent accurate under carefully controlled experiments. If he’s concerned too, that was not a good sign.

Natasha’s eyes widened in an expression of self-congratulatory epiphany. Eureka! Grant might be able to help Tom.

Last year, Grant had earned international notoriety when he used his powers to will a kidnapper to release a boy in North Carolina. The kidnapper had not only released the boy, but also surrendered to the police. He claimed that he had suffered from insomnia, and a voice inside his brain had kept telling him to “release the boy, turn yourself in, and then you will sleep.”

Maybe Grant could will the Justice Department to abandon their ridiculous charges against Tom. It was worth a try. She dialed Grant’s number, and he answered right away.

“Natasha, darling. I’m so glad you rang. I didn’t think you would take me seriously when I told you to ring day or night. But I’m elated that you did.”

“Thanks, Grant. I really appreciate your concern. You were right. My whole world’s been turned upside down since Sunday.” Natasha continued to tell Grant the entire story.

“Natasha. I’ve seen the dream with Lucas Phillip Renard. He says something to you. ‘Ah, Satan sees Natasha.’ Does this mean anything to you?”

“That’s incredible, Grant! He said those very words to me in a snapshot vision—or hallucination—I had after I was startled at Jim’s house. I fainted afterward. What do you think it means?”

“I hate to say it, darling, but I believe an evil spirit is after you. I think it is the same spirit that possessed Lucas Phillip Renard. You probably couldn’t be in a better or safer place than the Vatican. Under the circumstances, I am considerably relieved that you are there.”

“But why would it be after me?”

“Because, my dear, you’re a threat to its agenda somehow. At least that is what I’m sensing.”

“I’ve been racking my mind to figure out what’s been going on. How is it all connected? Why him? And why me?”

“Natasha darling, you’ll need to meditate. The answers will come. Pay attention to clues in your dreams.”

“If I can figure out what some of this is about, then maybe I can get the upper hand. I’ll be in a position of strength.”

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“You know the proverb—knowing is half the battle.”

“Yes. The other half is following your instincts.”

“Natasha, my dear. Please listen carefully. I have some important tips for you to stay hidden from this evil spirit. It’s very important for you to remember them.”

Grant paused to make sure Natasha was giving her undivided attention. He had correctly perceived that Natasha’s mind was still thinking about all the matters she had told him about. He wanted to make sure that she was truly listening.

“Remember that negative thoughts and emotions are like a scent trail to these spirits. It’s a path they can follow to find you. If you’re putting out signals of fear, anxiety, or sadness, they can tune into you. It is much like a metal detector finding a coin in the dirt. Once they lock onto your signal, they can track you. So stay positive.”

“What else?”

“One thing is for certain. Pray to Jesus. Pray earnestly. Pray unceasingly. Listen mentally for the guidance.”

“Thank you, Grant. I will.”

“Excellent, darling. And I will pray for intercession on your and Tom’s behalf. All right, then. Call me with updates.”

“I will.”

“Good-bye, darling. Take care.”

Natasha sat down Eastern meditation style. She closed her eyes, exhaled, and cleared her mind. She breathed deeply and concentrated on keeping her mind blank. She wanted to start a conversation with Jesus, but she felt awkward doing so. She opened her mouth to speak a prayer, but then closed her lips and breathed deeply again. It was like initiating a conversation with a long-time estranged acquaintance. She could not do it. It was as if her throat was locked shut and her stomach was full of butterflies.

“Dear Jesus.” She could not think of what to say. A teardrop escaped her right eye and traveled down her cheek. She thought of Tom.

“Please help us. Please. Please, Jesus. Help us.” When she opened her eyes, she felt like a weight had been lifted. It was not an eloquent prayer,

but she had reached out for the help of Jesus. That was the first step anyway.

She stood up, picked up the desk phone's receiver, and dialed Nicholas' extension.

"Hello?"

"Nicholas. Hi, this is Natasha."

"Hello, madam. I'm at your service."

"Would you care to escort me on a horse-drawn carriage ride?"

"For certain. What time would you like?"

"Can we go right now?"

"Your wish is my command," he declared in good humor. "I'll meet you in the main entrance hall. The carriage will be waiting for us down at the street."

Natasha smiled and bunny-hopped with joy. She felt excited and looked forward to the excursion with great anticipation as she readied herself.

CHAPTER 26

In the main entrance hall of Francis' apartment, a narrow Christmas tree rose to the height of the ceiling. A large rectangular gift box lay under it for Natasha. It was about the size of two briefcases put side by side.

Francis sat at his piano, playing another one of his compositions. He sang a soft, twinkly, kind of dreamy Christmas song in a slow, gentle voice.

"A snowy winter's night
A man walks alone on the street
He looks around at the Christmas lights
And remembers the people he's loved in his life
He remembers festive gatherings
And the sound
Of people laughing and talking.
And love filled the air all around."

Francis intensified the tempo as he played into the chorus.

"'Twas the season of hope
'Twas the season of joy and gifts
And peace could always be found.
It was the time of Christmas cheer."

Natasha emerged from her hallways with a bright smile as Francis repeated the chorus. He hastened to finish with his usual flourish.

"That was wonderful," Natasha exclaimed.

"I haven't finished it yet. Maybe today's excursion will give me the inspiration I need."

"I thought you were working?"

Francis pulled his hands down from the piano keys and stood up. "I was, but then I got to thinking. How often do I have such a special guest

as you? Nicholas informed me of your request, and I just had to come home early.”

“Are you sure?” Natasha teased. “You won’t get bored while I’m trying on clothes?”

“Don’t worry. I’ll give you your space.”

Francis Charles bent over and plucked Natasha’s gift from under the tree. He held it up to her.

“Surprise.”

“I feel bad. I don’t have anything for you.”

“No worries,” he answered in an Australian accent. “I can wait until Christmas day.”

Natasha sat down on the piano bench and placed the box on her lap. She pulled the ribbon loose and opened it. It was a luxurious silver-and-white fur coat. Natasha had never owned one before. They were taboo in the States, but very much still in style throughout Europe.

Natasha gasped. “Oh my goodness!”

She felt awkward accepting this extravagant, guilt-laden gift, but she was overwhelmed by the gesture. She knew Francis was lonely and had a need to give nice things to someone.

She radiated pure delight to show Francis how moved she was by his special gift.

Francis returned a slightly self-conscious smile.

“It’s cold out on the street, and I really wanted to make sure you enjoy yourself. Here, let me help you.”

Francis pulled the fur up her arms and wrapped it around her shoulders. He was wearing a gray pinstriped suit. He pulled his matching gray cashmere overcoat from the coat closet and put it on.

He held out his arm to Natasha, bent at the elbow.

“Shall we?”

“We shall.”

Snow fell lightly as they sat back in the carriage and rode through the narrow cobblestone streets. Francis held his arm around her back in a sideways embrace.

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Natasha began to feel more awkward. He was squeezing her waist in the carriage. *Is he putting the moves on me?* She tried to push the thought away. That's absurd. He hasn't tried to kiss me. He's just being a gentleman.

It was dusk when the carriage stopped at St. Andrews Village Square, their last stop before heading back.

"Francis, why don't you go along to some of the shops you like apart from me? I still need to find something a little special for you."

"All right then. Why don't we meet at the corner in, say, sixty minutes?"

"That should be enough time."

Once Francis had disappeared out of view, Natasha briskly walked to the Internet café she had noticed.

She sat down and logged into her e-mail account. She opened an e-mail from Jeremy Benton.

Dear Natasha,
Tom says there's a man who may be connected to the conspiracy against him. He says the man may be able to shed some light on the matter. There's just one problem. Tom says he's a fugitive. Interpol has been on the lookout for him since 2003. Tom says the only way to find him is to go to Istanbul and "search for wisdom" from a man known as "the priest." He suggests hiring a private investigator to find this man, and interview him for information that may help.
Other than that, nothing new. Tom sends his love. He's doing fine. He seems to be in good spirits. Mainly concerned about you. I'll e-mail you an update on Monday afternoon.

Best regards,
Jeremy Benton

Natasha remembered the Eastern Archaeological Society in Istanbul. Her eyes widened. Father Elijah had a file on Hagia Sophia on

the memory stick. It was the Church of Holy Wisdom, and those Greek proverbs she had seen at Hagia Sophia and in the Basilica Cistern beneath. They were all in Istanbul, but something was nagging at her. There was something else.

Grant had told her to pay attention to the clues in her dreams. She had dreamed of an ancient cityscape in the Mediterranean, hadn't she? The cityscape she remembered had vast domed buildings and Medieval-style towers. That was Istanbul, too. Natasha ran her hand up her forehead, combed her fingers through her hair, and down the back of her head to the side of her neck.

I'm in the wrong city.

She pulled up and printed more information on this line of thought: Hagia Sophia, the Eastern Archaeological Society, and the Library of Istanbul. The library was one of the oldest and greatest on earth.

Natasha looked at her watch. *Time to go meet Francis*. She walked out of the storefront and stood at the corner. No sign of Francis or the carriage. She turned and looked up the street. It was dazzling with all the little white lights, but still no Francis. She stuck her hands into her fur coat and enjoyed its warmth.

Suddenly, someone from behind shot their arms through the loops between Natasha's armpits and where her wrists entered the pockets of her fur. The hands interlaced fingers at the point of her abdomen and pulled her close. For a moment, she was shocked, but then realized it was Francis, surprising her with a hug from behind. He held her tight, rested his jaw on her shoulder, and whispered, "Merry Christmas!"

Natasha put her hand on her chest. "Francis, you startled me," she said.

"Oh. I beg your pardon. I am sorry. I just couldn't resist. I haven't held a woman in a fur coat since I—" He didn't finish.

Natasha thought to remind him that she was a married woman, but then bit her lip. Everything he had done was so innocent. If I say anything right now, he can just claim he's lonely and in need of a little human contact and affection. I would be stuck looking hypersensitive—and then everything would be uncomfortable. She shook it off. Don't burn a

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bridge, Natasha. He may very well be able to help Tom get out of this mess. So, play along with his little games, as long as it gets you Tom.

“Here’s the carriage now,” Francis announced, offering Natasha his hand to escort her up into the seats.

As the carriage slowly pulled them through the ancient streets, Natasha was silent. Francis did not have his arm around her. Perhaps he had begun to sense her discomfort.

“After dinner, we’ll make those calls for Tom,” he said. “I would have called sooner today, of course, but the time difference must be accounted for. Can’t really get a hold of anyone until 7:00 a.m. Eastern.”

Natasha stared out with an indifferent look. This last bit made her feel particularly uncomfortable.

CHAPTER 27

Later that same night, tensions continued to build as Natasha reminded Francis about his promise to help her husband. Eventually, Francis could not stand any further mention of Tom. He clenched his teeth and lowered his eyelids.

“What?” Natasha asked. “What was that expression?”

Francis stood up and walked to the far side of the kitchen island. He turned around and placed his hands on the countertop. He locked his elbows, leaned on them as if they were two kickstands holding up a bike, and lowered his head.

“There was a reason I played that song for you about the light of God shining through. Even in the darkest times, God’s love finds a way to illuminate our lives and show us the way. I mention this to offer solace in the wake of bad news regarding Tom’s situation.”

“What? What did you find out?”

“I’m very sorry, Natasha. I did not want to discuss this while we were eating. But now that we are...”

“What?”

“Natasha, this is hard for me. I can’t just blurt out information. Please understand that in my role as a government official, I am privy to classified information. I received some of it regarding Tom—and all I can tell you is that I believe Tom is in quite a bit of real trouble. I believe the U.S. Justice Department is very serious about their case against him.”

Natasha sat speechless.

“Natasha, I’m reasonably certain—based on the classified information shared with me—that Tom is not innocent in the matters against him.”

Natasha burst into tears.

“I know he’s innocent! He’s my husband!” Natasha screeched. “Whatever information you saw is wrong. Tom is one thousand percent

innocent. You, of all people, should know that. You married us, for God's sake."

I have the power to annul your marriage. Natasha sensed the thought flash through his eyes. He composed himself.

"Natasha!" he pleaded. "Don't you understand? Tom's guilty. It will take all my influence to keep him from being hanged. Life in prison is the best we can hope for."

Natasha froze. Francis put his hands on her shoulders and looked down at her.

"Tom is gone, Natasha. He'll never be with you again. I know it's hard for you to accept, but he would want you to continue your life. Why not continue it with me—here. I love you. I always have." Francis reached out to wipe a tear from her cheek.

Natasha deflected his gesture.

"I am a married woman—and shame on you for attempting to take advantage of my vulnerable situation."

Natasha slapped him across the cheek. She ran to her suite and locked the door behind her as she packed her things to travel to Turkey.

CHAPTER 28

Natasha walked along a crowded marketplace in Istanbul. The merchants called out to her. She passed a young man selling marble souvenirs—ashtrays, square-block paperweights, and small animal sculptures.

“American lady. Look, look over here. I have what you are looking for. Name your price.”

Natasha smiled, shook her head, and continued walking. The young man followed, calling out persistently.

“How much you want to give? You name the price.”

Natasha stopped and looked at him. He was thin, obviously impoverished, but he had an incredible smile. He held up a small marble keepsake box that Natasha had glanced at earlier. She took it from his hands and examined it more closely. It was mainly white, with shades of blue marbled through it.

“Five dollars,” Natasha said.

“Please, my lady. It is worth more. Fifteen dollars and it is yours.”

Natasha handed it back, but he would not let her.

“Ten dollars.”

Natasha was satisfied. She thought she might have gotten it for five, but she could tell he wasn’t getting rich.

“How’d you know I was American?”

“Your smile. It was your beautiful smile, my lady.”

Natasha blushed slightly and smiled.

“You’ve got a heck of a smile yourself. What’s your name?”

“My name? My name is Ishamel.”

“Ishmael?”

“No, no. Ish-amel. Ish-amel.”

“You speak good English.”

“Yes, I learn from American, too.”

“Thanks.”

She paid him the ten dollars and continued on her way.

“Make my day,” Ishamel said. “Thank you. Come to me if you need anything else. I can give you guide. I can show you city.”

“Thank you, but I must go now,” Natasha replied, waving as she walked.

She wanted to give him more money, but that would not be wise. Her years in the Foreign Service had taught her caution. Flashing cash in a busy marketplace could invite trouble, despite good intentions. Thieves and conmen could easily be drawn to such displays.

The marketplace was full of all sorts of smells and noises. People called to her, and some of the men whistled. She was glad to emerge from the alley. She enjoyed the music of a group of Peruvian musicians playing wooden flutes and guitars—they seemed out of place in Istanbul, but there they were. She crossed the busy street and entered the grounds of Hagia Sophia. With acres of gardens surrounding the temple and its accompanying structures, it took her some time to finally reach the massive building.

Natasha looked down at the historical note posted just before the entrance. It was titled, “Hagia Sophia, Church of Holy Wisdom.” Among other details, it stated the temple was built under the direction of the Roman Emperor Justinian in AD 537.

Hagia Sophia was one of the grandest Christian temples of all time. Its scale was unrivaled for more than a thousand years. It was, in fact, one of the largest domed structures ever built.

Natasha walked to the prayer area, put a donation in the collection box, and took a candle. Reverently, she made her way forward. She lit her candle from another’s flame, placed it in the sand, and stood before it. She cleared her mind and bowed her head in meditation.

She sensed a man behind her. She could smell his aftershave—a spicy, clean scent. Opening her eyes, she turned to confirm her suspicion. The man was slender and European, with dark hair parted to the side. He wore a custom-tailored, French-cuffed white shirt and black Armani trousers. It was Grant Nuby.

“Grant! What a surprise!” she whispered. “What are you doing here?”

“Natasha, darling.” He kissed her cheek.

“I’ve always wanted to visit Turkey—and I thought you could use some company. Viola! Simple as a plane ticket.”

“How’d you know where to find me?”

“I didn’t for sure. But I had strong influences that made me believe you’d be here.”

“Wow. You’re good.”

She glimpsed an old priest entering the confessional booth across the room behind Grant.

“Grant, I’m sorry. Wait here. I’ll be right back.”

He noticed her attention shift.

“Have you been naughty?”

“All right. I’ll be right back.”

Natasha walked to the dark corner of the confessional booths. She entered the booth and closed the door. She sat quietly for a moment, unsure of what to say, then just spoke.

“My name is Natasha Ashton. I am the wife of Thomas Ashton. I’m looking for a particular man here. He’s known as ‘The Priest.’ Can you help me?”

“You’ll have to tell me your whole story.”

She told the same one she had shared with Francis Charles and Grant Nuby.

“I don’t believe I can help you, my dear.”

“No. Please. I know you know something. From the questions you asked, you must know something.”

“As I was about to say, I believe the man you seek is actually the priest librarian. He is known as a holder of secret knowledge.”

“Okay, then. Please tell me. How do I find him?”

“Go to the Library of Istanbul. Request a copy of the 1599 Geneva Commentary Bible. Then take it to the first-floor reading area. Sit at the rear corner table and read the second half of the Apocalypse. Once you have done this, the priest librarian will find you.”

“When? When should I do this?”

“Today. 4:00 p.m.”

“Thank you.”

“Go in peace, child.”

Natasha exited the booth and looked for Grant. He was leaning forward on a bench, head down. He looked up, saw her, and smiled.

Grant stood and walked toward her.

“Looks like we have a lead,” she said.

“Like what?”

“I don’t know for sure. We have to go to the library at 4:00 to find out.”

“Good. So we have time to take the tour.”

“The tour?”

“Yes. Look over there.”

Grant pointed to a small group gathering near the entrance. Natasha and Grant joined, strolling as the tour guide revealed the secrets of Hagia Sophia. Originally constructed by Justinian I in AD 537, its interior was so elaborately decorated that Justinian declared, “Solomon, I have surpassed you.”

The walls were inlaid with white, green, and purple marble, richly covered with gold mosaics. The entrance was covered by a separate dome, and the eastern section was used for Orthodox services. An enormous central dome—thirty-one meters in diameter and fifty-six meters high—connected the two sides. The support beams ribbed the interior of the dome like the inside of an umbrella. The tour guide took them outside and stopped in front of the famous Fountain of Sophia. Natasha recognized the inscription from Elijah’s flash drive file. “NIPSON ANOME MATA ME MONAN OPSIN”

νιψον ανομη ματα μη μοναν οψιν

The tour guide translated it “Wash your lawlessness, not only your face.”

Natasha stared at it. I’m missing something. She couldn’t shake the idea.

The tour group approached an outbuilding, which served as the entrance to the Basilica Cistern—an enormous underground structure built solely to hold and protect the water for Constantinople.

As they approached the entrance, Natasha recognized another inscription from Elijah's flash drive. The inscription over the entrance read: "NOMAN O KIONOS EXE SON OIKONOMON"

ΝΟΜΟΝ Ο ΚΙΟΝΟΣ ΕΞΕ ΣΟΝ ΟΙΚΟΝΟΜΟΝ

"Whoever you are, let the law be your guide." Natasha took a picture of the inscription with her cell phone. They followed the group down narrow stairs. Haunting music echoed, and colored lights theatrically illuminated the amazing chamber. They reached an area near the water level. A walking bridge crisscrossed the cistern above a gigantic lake. Hundreds of huge marble columns emerged from the water and towered to the ceiling. There was enough space between the columns that small boats could sail through them.

Natasha thought about the reference in the inscription to "law." *Justinian was known to be the father of modern law, but what did law have to do with this place? What did allowing the law to be one's guide have to do with anything down here?* She pulled out her phone and typed herself a reminder to think about this later.

CHAPTER 29

At 5:00 PM, Natasha and Grant sat at a reading table inside the library. Natasha looked around at the incredible maze of enormous bookshelves. Light poured in from high windows, and a slight mildew odor hung in the air. Ancient manuscripts, loose-leaf writings, and modern volumes all shared the massive shelf space.

Just as the old priest had prescribed, Natasha and Grant read the last half of the Book of Revelation. Natasha was eager to make connections now with the prophetic scriptures because they lined up with Jim Worley's speculation that Father Elijah had discovered secret knowledge within their pages. It was those very secrets that she suspected had prompted his killing.

A man wearing the robe of an Orthodox priest approached the table and sat down. He was an older gentleman, perhaps sixty years of age. He wore rounded spectacles and a short white beard. He carried a tattered black briefcase and placed it on the large table.

"Dr. Ashton," the priest librarian addressed her. "Nice to meet you." His accent was a soothing mix of British English with a Russian foundation. "I am Alexie Kirov. I knew your husband Tom many years ago."

He substituted a handshake with the Anjali Mudra gesture, a partial bow, his hands at his chest in a prayer position. "You are here because you seek truth. Yes? I will show you the truth about one of the most amazing mysteries in human history. The first part of the mystery may be too shocking for you—but not to many others, because it has been known for well over one thousand years. Before I say more, I must make something very clear."

The priest librarian paused and cleared his throat. He looked up as he searched for the right words.

“Pretend I am a Muslim. What does it mean about me if the Antichrist turns out to be Muslim? Does it mean that I am evil? What about the Antichrist himself? Must he be an evil man? Or could he be misguided, yet with good intentions? Perhaps he leads the world astray, thinking that he is doing good?”

Natasha and Grant were silent. She was curious where this man was leading them.

“You see,” he continued, “demonizing and name-calling comes from a fundamental misinterpretation of the Apocalypse, the prophecy of the Book of Revelation, as you know it.”

Natasha turned to Grant and clarified. “He is talking about the Book of Revelation. In the original Greek, the title of Revelation is Apocalypse, based on the Greek word *apocalypsis*, which means ‘the revealing.’”

The priest continued, “I will prove my point. I say a word, commonly associated with the Apocalypse, the Book of Revelation, as you say it, and you tell me what you think. Agreed?”

“Okay, we’ll play along,” Natasha said.

“Good. The first word: Antichrist.”

“Evil world dictator,” Natasha stated.

“Satanic ruler,” Grant added.

“Why?” the priest librarian asked.

“Anti means against,” Natasha said. “The title itself is self-explanatory. Christ stands for all things good and pure, and the Antichrist is the opposite.”

“Wrong,” the priest librarian declared bluntly.

Natasha was startled to be declared wrong in this matter. Then it dawned on her. Of course. The Greek word *anti* was one of those words that carried dual definitions. Now she thought she knew where the priest was headed.

“Right,” she agreed and turned to Grant to explain. “Most people don’t know it, but the exact translation of the Biblical Greek *anti* is the English word instead.”

“Exactly,” the priest continued. “The title of Antichrist literally means ‘instead of Christ,’ not ‘against Christ.’”

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Grant raised a skeptical eyebrow.

The priest was prepared and pulled a dictionary of New Testament Greek from his briefcase, handing it to Natasha.

She recognized it immediately. “Thayer’s and Smith’s Dictionary of the New Testament,” she announced, flipping through until she came to the word *anti* and read the entry aloud:

“*anti* – (an-tee)

1. for, instead of, in place of (something)
2. on behalf of something
3. substitution”

Grant shook his head in bewilderment.

“I know. I know,” the priest said slowly, empathizing. “It is an amazingly simple truth, and so few people have ever noticed it.”

Natasha nodded in agreement.

Grant sat quietly with his hand on his mouth, staring off in deep thought.

The priest continued, “So you see, Antichrist is not necessarily evil at all. For example, the Pope’s official title actually means the exact same thing. His official title is Latin: *Vicarius Christi*. It exactly translates as ‘Vicar of Christ.’ But what does the word *vicar*, with its Latin root *vicarious*, mean?”

Natasha knew the answer but, for curiosity’s sake, gestured to him to explain.

“I will show you what the dictionary actually says.” He pulled a Random House English dictionary from his briefcase, flipped to the word *vicar*, and read aloud:

“*Vic-ar* – (vik-er) – noun

1. A person who acts in place of another. A substitute.
2. A person who is authorized to perform the functions of another; deputy: God’s vicar on earth.”

“Or for even more clarification, look at the next word down,” he continued, reading:

“*Vi-car-i-ous* (vahy-kair-ee-uhs) – adjective

1. Performed, exercised, received, or suffered in place of another: vicarious punishment.
2. Taking the place of another; acting or serving as a substitute.”

The priest sighed. “We all know that throughout history there have been both godly and ungodly popes. But they have all had essentially the same official title: Vicarius Christi. Simply, it means ‘instead of Christ,’ or, once again in Greek, Antichrist. Understand? I will show you more. In the context of the Apocalypse, what does the word beast mean?”

“The devil,” Grant said.

“You probably are going to say it’s wrong,” Natasha added, “but I’ll say evil empire.”

“You are partially right,” the priest librarian encouraged. “A beast in Bible prophecy is a symbol of a nation, an empire, or a political power. However, a beast is not, in and of itself, evil. We do the same thing today. Eagle represents whom?”

“America,” Grant answered.

“Bear represents whom?”

“Russia,” Natasha replied.

“Lion represents whom?”

“Great Britain,” they answered together.

“And so it is simple. Beasts in Biblical prophecy are symbols representing world powers. They are not necessarily evil or good. Each beast is different, and the characteristics attributed to it help us figure out which world power is being represented.”

“Understand?” the priest asked. “What about the word woman?”

Grant and Natasha looked at each other.

“I will help you. Do you remember reading about the woman who sits on the beast? Do you remember the part where the ‘voice from heaven’ said, ‘Come out of her, my people’? So obviously, the woman is not a real woman. God’s people are not inside a real woman. No. Where are God’s people?”

“Church,” Natasha said thoughtfully. “Christ often is said to have referred to his church as a bride. She was the bride, and he was the bridegroom.”

“Yes,” the priest continued. “It is very well established that a woman in prophecy represents a church. A pure woman represents a pure church. An impure woman represents an impure church.”

“So, when the ‘voice from heaven’ says, ‘Come out of her, my people’—what is meant by this? You see? You understand? The ‘Great Schism’ was actually foretold in the Apocalypse.”

“What’s the ‘Great Schism?’” Grant asked.

Natasha answered, “The largest divorce in history: 1054 AD, when the Christian Church split into two—the Roman Catholic Church in the West and the Greek Orthodox Church in the East.”

The priest librarian continued the explanation. “Many differences festered for several hundred years until finally, Great Schism. Apostle Paul also foretold such a fate, referring to the church as a woman, he wrote this.” The priest opened the Bible and read aloud: Second Corinthians, chapter eleven, verses two and three, and also verses thirteen to fifteen.

For I am jealous over you with godly jealousy: for I have espoused you to one husband that I may present you as a chaste virgin to Christ. But I fear, lest by any means, as the serpent beguiled Eve through his subtlety, so your minds should be corrupted from the simplicity that is in Christ....

For such are false apostles, deceitful workers, transforming themselves into the apostles of Christ. And no marvel; for Satan himself is transformed into an angel of light.

Therefore it is no great thing if his ministers also be transformed as the ministers of righteousness; whose end shall be according to their works.

The priest librarian looked up and said, “And this knowledge is not new by any means. The Orthodox Church has always known this interpretation, and later the Protestant reformers did as well. I will continue so as not to leave any doubt. There are several more clues to

the identity of this woman and the beast she sits on, which make it clear that the woman here, known as the Whore of Babylon, is actually the Christian Church gone astray.”

The old priest opened his briefcase and pulled out a stack of papers and booklets. It was a messy pile with layers of various thicknesses and different shades of paper. He pulled a cheat sheet from it and began to go through the bullet points. “Clue number one:

And the woman was arrayed in purple and scarlet color.”

He pulled out a color photo of the Papal Coronation ceremony of Pope Paul VI. The photo showed hundreds of cardinals and bishops gathered at the coronation. They were all clothed in scarlet and purple. “The Roman Church is a woman clothed in purple and scarlet.” He pulled out several other photos showing the cardinals and bishops in their purple and scarlet attire. “This tradition of the purple and scarlet dress code goes all the way back, at least to the Donation of Constantine.”

Natasha interjected, “But the Donation of Constantine was determined to be a forgery.”

“A forgery based on an original,” the priest answered.

“I’ve heard that too. But no one has ever seen the evidence for that.”

“Evidence is all around us,” the priest replied. “There was obviously a transfer of power. And the fact that the Donation of Constantine was a forgery doesn’t change the fact that the Papacy used it for over eight hundred years to legitimize her power in secular political matters and as a deed to prove ownership rights of her vast real estate empire.”

Natasha bit her lip. The priest’s argument made sense to her. The priest librarian smiled and continued, “In Donation of Constantine it was written that ‘Princes’ of the church should be adorned in purple and scarlet. And next.” He pointed down at the text.

“And in her was found the blood of prophets, and of saints.”

“This is an easy one. As a result of veneration of the saints, the church actually does keep pieces of the remains of saints: pieces of bone, strands of hair, and blood itself.”

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Natasha's mind raced. She surprised both men with her observation. "The Apocalypse says, 'She was drunk with the blood of the saints' and he 'marveled at her.' Most people would probably incorrectly draw from this language a vision of an evil woman drinking blood like a vampire, but actually, the opposite is true. The keyword here being drunk, not drank."

"I don't understand," Grant said.

The priest nodded. He was excited as he anticipated what Natasha would say.

"What do we say when someone has been driving drunk?" Natasha asked rhetorically. "We say they have been driving under the influence. Yes? The word 'drunk' here is code for 'influenced.'"

"John marveled as he saw the future persecution of the church," Natasha explained. "And he marveled as he saw that the blood of the saints influenced the church. Do you understand? She was a victim."

"Yes," the priest affirmed. "Blood of saints persuaded her into compromising with Roman paganism. She did this in desperation to escape ruthless persecution. You understand me?" he asked, insecure about his own language skills. "All right." The priest sat back in his chair. He took his glasses off and rubbed his eyes "So to summarize: "First part of the mystery is this: The mystery of Whore of Babylon. I believe that the Whore of Babylon is a symbol of the medieval Christian Church - gone astray, but not in a name-calling sense. It is in sense of real life. A woman forced into prostitution in order to survive poverty and violence. In a sense, she is a victim. I believe the Beast that she rode is a symbol for the medieval Vatican. I believe the official Latin title Vicarious Christi can be translated literally as Antichrist in Greek.

"Are you ready to hear second part?"

"Yes," Natasha said.

"Good. Because this is part that is really inconceivable," he said as if he was a Russian scientist who had made a mind-blowing discovery. He put his hands around his head and burst them out into the air. "And I believe with your unique expertise, Dr. Ashton, you will quite enjoy it."

“Second part of the mystery is the Mystery of 666 and of mark of the beast. In order to understand the beast, its mark, and its number, we must first identify the beast. Do you understand?” he asked again self-consciously. “All right. The beast in question makes his appearance in the thirteenth chapter of the Apocalypse, I mean the Book of Revelation. Please turn to that right now if you would please.”

Natasha flipped back a few pages to the thirteenth chapter. “Good.” The priest said. “Please read me the first few verses and pay close attention to the description of this beast.”

Natasha read it aloud.

Then I stood on the sand of the sea. And I saw a beast rising up out of the sea, having seven heads and ten horns, and on his horns ten crowns... Now the beast, which I saw, was like a leopard, his feet were like the feet of a bear, and his mouth like the mouth of a lion. The dragon gave him his power, his throne, and great authority. And I saw one of his heads as if it had been mortally wounded, and his deadly wound was healed. And ... he was given authority to continue for forty-two months.

“Very good,” the priest librarian assured. “Now let us visualize this beast. It is a leopard-like beast with seven heads and ten horns. Yes? Hmm. Does that sound familiar?” he asked.

“Yes, it does,” Natasha answered.

“Did you catch it? That this is the same beast that carries the whole of Babylon. I believe this beast represents the geo-political aspect of the Vatican. Now, let us look at other details and clues. First, Power was given unto it to rule for 42 months, or 1,260 days. In Bible prophecy, that means 1,260 years—remember this.”

Natasha knew the priest was correct on this issue. There were many instances in the Judeo-Christian scriptures in which an angel or another spokesperson for God interpreted that a day in this or that prophecy actually equaled a year. It was known as the “a day is as a year” principle of Biblical prophetic interpretation.

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“After completing construction of Hagia Sophia and dedicating it on December 27, AD 537, Roman Emperor Justinian appointed his own Pope. In AD 538, he sent this Pope to Rome with his own army. They besieged Rome and took the rightful Pope prisoner, where he died one year later. Justinian’s Pope Vigilius, I took power of the Vatican in AD 538. It was a point in history that marked the beginning of the Vatican as an arm of the Roman Empire. The Vatican ruled with supreme authority as the former Roman Empire fizzled away. In 1798, 1,260 years later, French General Berthier conquered the Vatican, and took the Pope prisoner, thus bringing an end to the prophetic 1,260 years.”

The priest-librarian scribbled notes on a blank piece of paper as he explained the timeline, periodically tapping his pointer finger against them. He pointed at the Bible verse. “Notice how the beginning and end of this period were predicted in the next clue in Revelation:

**He who leads into captivity,
shall be led into captivity.**

**He who lives by the sword,
shall die by the sword.**

“Remember what Paul wrote when he referred to those who might corrupt the chaste virgin? That their ‘ends would be according to their works.’ ‘He who lives by the sword, shall die by the sword’ is just another way of saying the same thing, yes? Whose end shall be according to their works? John’s language is a concealed reference to Paul’s warning of a possible future apostasy.”

The priest pointed back to his notes.

“So back to the timeline. For more than one hundred years, the Vatican remained poor and powerless—until 1935, when Mussolini restored the Papal States and returned to her the right to exist as a sovereign nation. Slowly and surely, she has recovered. Until now, she has almost completely recovered. That brings us to yet another clue: And I saw one of his heads as if it had been mortally wounded, and his deadly wound was healed.

“Now, the power of the Vatican is once again vast and global. Truly, her mortal wound has been healed.”

The priest pointed again to the Bible.

“And here. Another clue:

All the world worshipped the beast.

“Once again, indicating a religious aspect to this political power. And once again indicating global power.”

“Let me ask you a question,” the priest asked Natasha. “Do you remember your Roman Numerals?”

“Yes. Of course. V equals five. I equals one.”

Grant nodded that he also knew them.

“Yes. Good.”

The priest librarian turned to Grant.

“Now, let me ask another question. How often in your life have you ever needed to know them?”

Grant answered, “Almost never.”

“Do you think it is strange then, that practically every person in the world with a third-level education knows Roman numerals? Why do you think that would be? I mean, they are so useless right?”

Natasha tried to think of an answer. None came.

“Maybe it is because God wanted every man, woman, and child on earth to be able to do this:”

He excitedly pulled out a blank piece of paper.

“I told you before that pope’s official title is Latin. What I did not tell you was that the title may not have always been Vicarious Christi. The pope’s title—Vicarius Christi—may have had its origins in the document we discussed earlier—the Donation of Constantine. It is named Peter and his successors, Vicarius Filii Dei—which translates to Vicar of the Son of God. Thus, the beginnings of pope’s Title, Vicar of the Son of God. But how and why did the title change from Vicar of the Son of God to its present version—Vicar of Christ? They both essentially mean the same thing. The word Christ essentially means the same thing as the words Son of God. So why switch?”

Natasha and Grant leaned over spellbound, anticipating what the priest would say next.

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“You said you remember your Roman numerals. Now you have a chance to prove it. Decode this if you will.” The priest wrote out the title vertically.

Natasha took the paper and the pencil from the priest.

“V equals five. I equals one. C equals one hundred.”

She skipped over A and R.

“A has no value. R has no value. I equals one. U has no value.”

“Not so fast,” the priest corrected. “U is a relatively modern invention in language.”

“Of course,” Natasha remembered. “That’s right. Up until Benjamin Franklin’s alphabet reform, the letter U was simply the lowercase version of the letter V. They were considered to be the same letter.” She turned to Grant. “If you look at the writing on any old building of significance, you’ll see that our modern-day “U” is actually a “V”. The easiest examples are on old courthouses.”

Natasha remembered her dream in which she was scuba diving with Father Elijah and Tom, and they saw a domed megastructure with the words COVRT HOVSE spelled with “Vs,” and a chill went down her spine.

“Yes,” the priest said. “And even look at the letter in your alphabet known as W.”

He wrote a W, demonstrating that a W was actually two V’s put together. It is actually a double V. $V + V = VV$.

“Therefore, U has the same value as a V. Please continue,” the priest prodded.

Natasha wrote a value of five next to the U and continued.

“S has no value; F has no value. I is one. L is 50. I is one; I is one; and D is 500. E has no value and I have the value of one.”

Natasha added them up. She knew where it was leading, but to see it add up was astonishing.

“The values of the letters in this title add up to six hundred and sixty-six,” she said solemnly.

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“Yes,” the priest said. “And look here at the end of the chapter that mentions the number 666. It says it will be the number of a man, the number of his name.”

The number of a man, the number of his name.	
V	5
I	1
C	100
A	NA
R	NA
I	1
U	5—prior to alphabet reform, U was lower case of V
S	NA
F	NA
I	1
L	50
I	1
I	1
D	500
E	NA
I	1
TOTAL	666

The priest librarian continued his explanation.

“If the Pope’s title was ever in fact Vicarious Filii Dei, then we can understand why the Vatican might have changed it to its present version. If that were the case, then by changing a title that spells 666, they inadvertently changed it to a title that exactly translates as Antichrist. Yes. You understand? Now let us look even further.” He turned back to the thirteenth chapter.

“Look here,” he said, and read aloud:

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And all the world worshipped the beast, and he caused all to receive a mark on their foreheads or on their right hand. And no one could buy or sell, lest they have the mark of the beast, or the number of his name. Here is wisdom. Let him who hath understanding calculate the number of the beast. For it is the number of a man. It is the number of his name. And his number is 666.

“All right. Important thing to notice here is that the mark of the beast is not the number 666. The number is simply the number of his name. The mark of the beast is a different thing.”

“Yes,” Natasha said. “The mark of the beast is given on the right hand because that represents our actions, and on the forehead because that represents our thoughts.”

The priest nodded and tapped the Bible again with his finger.

“Yes. So when the beast forces all to receive this mark, it means he is forcing the world to act and think as it commands.”

The priest paused for a moment and looked at Natasha and Grant. He cleared his throat and continued, “The mystery of the beast and of its mark is this—there is a possible future in which a one-world government comes. This New World Order will endeavor to dominate the thoughts and actions of every person on earth.”

Natasha scratched her head and ran her fingers through her hair. She pointed back down to the Bible.

“So what does all of this have to do with us? If all of this has been known for centuries, then what does it have to do with people I know getting killed and imprisoned?”

“It has everything to do with them, but that is the third and final part of the mystery. It is the part I know only partially; the rest we will have to figure out. I believe the reason for the assassinations is to protect the well-laid plans of the biggest power grab of all time. You see? Do you remember the immediate times after America was attacked on 9/11? Remember how easily Americans gave up their freedoms in exchange for the promise of security? It will be the same—only a hundred times worse. There is a plan that involves something fearsome. A catastrophe of such horrible scope that it will cause all of mankind to give up national

identities and individual rights and drive the entire world to unite under the leadership of a single one-world government. Democracy will be exchanged for a global theocracy. All for the promise of peace and safety. You, me, and everyone else who knows the truth are a threat to those plans. However, Elijah and Jim Worley and others perhaps had even more specific knowledge. I don't know. As far as Tom is concerned, I think the only reason he is in prison is because Francis wants you for himself."

"This is probably the only reason you're still alive," Grant added.

The priest continued. "Natasha, your connection to Elijah and Jim Worley and Francis Charles—it cannot be simply a coincidence. You were put in this position for a reason. It must be because Francis Charles is one who is to fulfill this prophecy." He slowly raised his withered hand and pointed at Natasha. "You have a destiny to fulfill, too. You may be the only one who can stop whatever diabolical plan Francis Charles is setting into motion. You must go back to the Vatican and try to uncover whatever it is that he is planning."

Natasha looked over at Grant to see what he would say. His elbows were on the table, and his hands covered his face as if in prayer.

"Grant. Are you okay?" she asked. "Grant." She pulled his hands down from his face. Grant was in a trance. His eyes were shiny black.

"In girum imus nocte et consumimur igni," he hissed like a king cobra about to strike.

Natasha recoiled. "It's you. Who are you?"

The priest librarian jumped across the table at Grant. Grant easily deflected him and flung him across the room into a bookshelf, which came crashing down on top of him.

"Daughter of Eve. You must be destroyed!" he hissed and lunged at her.

"Awweeeee!" Natasha screamed. "Noohah!"

Natasha fell backward onto the ground as she panicked to escape the demonic monster. She was terrified beyond terror, knowing this was the same evil being that had possessed Lucas Phillip Renard.

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He jumped on top of her and pinned her to the ground. She struggled and fought with her hands. He gripped her neck with both hands and began to strangle her. Her face turned red, and her eyes bulged. She couldn't scream. He was so incredibly strong, and his grip was inescapable. He leaned forward, and his eyes rolled up in ecstasy as he prepared to inhale her soul.

The priest librarian came from behind and smashed a chair across the side of Grant's face.

"In the name of Jesus Christ, leave this man!" the priest shouted.

"He is ours!" the demon hissed.

The demon had momentarily lost his grip on Natasha's neck. She inhaled. She remembered the news clip and Lucas Phillip Renard's words: When my victims would cry out to Jesus for help, I would laugh. For it is Lucifer who has the power to save, and not the man Jesus.

The demon ignored the priest and turned his attention back to Natasha. She fought him as he grasped at her neck.

"In the name of Lucy Fur," she shouted, "I command you to release me and leave me alone!"

The demon recoiled, stunned. "You do not have the power to call on the name of Lucifer. You do not serve him!" he hissed.

"Oh no?" Natasha shouted. "Lucy Fur, I call on you to rebuke this demon. My body is to be kept for Lilith. The master has plans for me that you know not of."

The demon inside Grant studied Natasha. He shifted his weight from side to side.

"In the name of Lucy Fur, I command you to release me and leave me alone!" she shouted again, with even more determination.

The demon became aware of the priest standing next to him chanting exorcism prayers.

"I'll leave you for now, Daughter of Eve, but you wait right here!" he hissed.

The demon whipped around and thrust his arms at the priest with an explosive burst of power. The priest flew across the room again and crumbled to the floor.

“You cannot call upon Lucifer for help, can you, priest?” The demon marched over to where the priest lay dazed and mumbling prayers. He kneeled over the priest and smacked the rosary beads out of his hands.

“Priest,” the demon hissed, “I will take your soul now.”

The demon grasped the priest’s neck and strangled him. The priest kicked and flailed but could not move the demon. He clenched his teeth and tightened his neck muscles to resist the stranglehold. The priest’s eyes bulged, and he began to see darkness envelope his vision.

The demon shook his neck and squeezed harder. “Die! Give. Me. Your. Soul.” The demon could sense the man’s spirit departing. He leaned closer and opened his mouth to inhale the priest’s soul. He closed his eyes and began a deep, sharp inhalation.

Natasha, thinking quickly, quietly approached the transfixed demon. As he began his deep, soul-sucking breath, Natasha shot a stream of pepper spray directly into his mouth.

The demon recoiled in shock. He stood up disoriented, his lungs burning. Natasha followed up with a roundhouse kick to Grant’s abdomen.

“Ek ballete kakas pneumatias!” Natasha screamed as she kicked. “Huuuuuhh!”

“Εκ βαλλετο κακας πνευματασ”

Grant breathlessly collapsed to the floor. He huddled over and heaved, trying to catch his breath as his diaphragm convulsed in shock. The demon was gone. Natasha quickly went to the unconscious priest librarian. She put her cheek next to his lips to check if he was breathing. He was not.

Natasha pinched his nose and tilted his head back. She sealed her lips around his mouth and filled his lungs with air. The priest coughed and inhaled. His eyes opened. He stared up at Natasha and gathered his thoughts.

“You called upon the name of Lucifer?” he whispered with concern.

“No,” Natasha corrected. “I called upon my long-dead college roommate, Lucile Fur. I simply had to distract the demon by fooling him. Then I had to figure out how to save you from his evil clutches.”

“My angel,” he marveled. “How did you do that?”

“I just remembered that, in the original Greek scriptures, when Jesus cast the demon out of the possessed man, he said *Ek ballete kakas pneumatias*, which is usually translated ‘Cast out your evil spirit.’ But *ek ballete kakas pneumatias* can also mean ‘Expel your bad air.’

Anyway. It just felt like the right thing to do.”

She laughed as she remembered the shocked, disgusted look on the demon’s face.

“What happened?” Grant finally managed to ask in a hoarse, cracked voice. He looked up with a bewildered expression. Mucus poured out of his nose and his eyes were puffed out and bloodshot.

It was not funny, but Natasha and the priest librarian looked at each other and burst into a fit of laughter so severe that they shed tears and almost hyperventilated.

After the laughter subsided, the priest shot a serious look at Natasha. She knew he was worried about what to do with Grant.

“Grant, do you know what just happened?”

Grant was still a little disoriented and quiet.

“No. I must have blacked out. One moment, I was listening to the priest explaining the Apocalypse—and the next moment, I remember waking up to you two over there on the floor laughing.”

“Grant, you almost killed us,” Natasha said. “You were possessed by the same evil spirit that killed Father Elijah.”

“How do you know?” Grant asked.

“It used the same phrase: *In girum imus nocte et consumimur igni*,” Natasha answered, then turned her attention to the priest. “Now at least we know what that means. ‘We wander in darkness and are consumed in fire’ is akin to the demon that identified itself to Christ as ‘Legion. For we are many.’ Grant, the demon told the priest, ‘You are theirs.’ As in, you’re their property.”

Grant put his face in his hands. He looked up sorrowfully. "I'm so sorry, Natasha. I am cursed. I am damned. There's a reason why your powers are so random and why mine are so precise. It's because yours are natural and mine have been paid for. Bought—and at a horrible price."

"Did you sell your soul to Lucifer?" the priest asked.

"To my everlasting damnation. Yes. I did. Now I can be possessed by any demon that needs a body. They use me. I don't know what for, but they use me. It's one of the reasons I came here to Istanbul. I am also seeking help. Priest, is there anything you know that can break Lucifer's control over me?"

"Grant," Natasha said sternly. "Was it you who killed Father Elijah and Jim?"

"I don't know. Truly, I can't remember anything like that."

"But you admitted to me that you were at Jerrell's Cove the day before I arrived at the Vatican. That was the day Jim was found dead. Did you kill Jim?"

"If I did, it wasn't me. I swear to God. It wasn't me!"

The priest librarian interrupted, "All we know right now for sure is that you are definitely a demon-possessed man. I must do everything possible to cast the demons out of you and undo your curse. I must warn you that I cannot promise you anything. You may not even survive. Are you prepared to risk your life?"

"Yes," Grant answered. "I'll do anything."

"Natasha, we will have to keep Mr. Nuby locked up at the monastery. Grant, if you survive your cure—and that is a big if—you will then need to turn yourself in as a person of interest in the deaths of Elijah and Jim. Agreed?"

"Yes! I'm so sorry. I'll do anything."

The priest turned again to Natasha. "We need to act quickly and get him under lock and key right away. We cannot afford another appearance by you-know-who."

Natasha looked around the library. "We need something strong to bind him." She could not see anything readily available, but she realized

that the leather shoulder strap of her purse would work perfectly. She unclipped it and held it up to Grant and the priest.

“Do you know any demon-proof knots?” Grant asked the priest.

“I will do my best.” The priest walked around the table and stood next to Grant and Natasha. Grant stood up. The priest took the leather strap from Natasha. Grant held his hand out in front to be tied.

“I am sorry, son. I need your hands behind your back.”

Grant complied.

“I have to tie your wrists back here very tight. Do you understand it is for your own good?”

Grant nodded. The priest gave Natasha a nod as he finished the knot.

“Good,” the priest librarian announced. “Natasha, Mr. Nuby is under my care for now. We will go back to the monastery and do what we can for him. Now I have my mission and you have yours. Go. Hurry. Get out of here. Do not forget this evil demon will be after you.”

“And don’t forget what I told you before,” Grant said. “What I told you was the truth. Remember the tips I gave you. Stay positive. Pay attention to the clues in your dreams—and pray to Jesus.”

The priest was on his cell phone, speaking Russian. “Edee Sudah. Saychass! Reinforcements are on their way. We will be without problems.”

“Well, if it’s all the same, I’ll see you off,” Natasha said.

“Grant, it’ll be all right.” She hugged him and kissed him on the cheek. “At least you won’t be a tool of evil, no matter what happens.”

“Yes, Natasha. Please. If I don’t survive, please remember me rightly. Please remember me. That I was not an evil man.”

The reinforcements arrived just then.

“Thank you, priest.”

“Keep safe, Natasha. I will be praying for you.” He performed the sign of the cross over her. “Godspeed.” He turned and followed the four men who were already leading Grant out of the library. Natasha watched them leave. She looked around at the great library. Something was nagging at her. She was not ready to leave yet.

CHAPTER 30

Natasha hailed a cab outside the library to take her back to her hotel room. She pulled an apple out of her purse and ate it along the way.

When she arrived at the hotel, she checked her voicemail. She had two messages—one from Jeremy Benton and the other from Francis Charles. Jeremy had bad news. Since Tom was planning to fly to Mexico the day he was arrested, the judge ruled that he was a flight risk and denied bail. Francis had left a message begging her to return to the Vatican. He was worried about her and Tom, and he was still trying to save Tom's life.

The phone continued drawing her attention. It chimed again, signaling an unheard message. She flipped it open and listened. Once more, Francis pleaded with her to call him back and come to the Vatican, where he said he could protect her. He also had a bad feeling about her—the same feeling he'd had the night she fled Jerrell's Cove.

Natasha knew she needed to go back, to find out more about what he was up to—and to persuade him to help Tom's situation.

She dialed Francis' number.

He answered immediately. "Natasha! Thank you for calling me back. I'm so sorry, Natasha. I only meant good. Please come back to the Vatican. I'm trying to help Tom. Against all odds, I'm trying. Please. Just come back here. I'm worried about you."

"I've been thinking about things, too," she said. "Francis, I do love you—but it's agape love. Do you understand? I'm a married woman, and I love my husband with all my heart. You have to respect that. Do you understand?"

"Of course I do, Natasha. Please forgive me. I don't know what I was thinking."

JOSEPH NICHOLAS

“Okay. I can understand that after all those years of celibacy, the hope of companionship must be very special for you.”

“Yes. That’s it, Natasha. How could you blame me? You are an amazing woman. I was just not thinking straight. Please come back. I promise I’ll behave myself.”

“All right, Francis. I’ll come back.”

“I can’t wait. So you’ll be here on Christmas Day?”

“That’s the plan. I’ll call you with my flight info later. All right?”

“Good. Thank you, Natasha.”

“You’re welcome. Good night.”

She pushed the end-call button.

CHAPTER 31

The next morning, she stopped by the marketplace and paid a visit to Ishamel.

When he saw her, he smiled. “American lady. You’re back. Nice to see you.”

“Nice to see you too, Ishamel.”

He smiled again. “You remembered?”

“Ishamel. Do you know where I can find a chess set with hand-carved pieces?”

“Chass?”

“You know—the game. Checkmate. It’s a game.”

She gestured as if she were playing, but he still did not understand. She remembered the Russian word for chess. Natasha knew perfectly well that she was in Turkey, not Russia, but she also knew that Russian was to Turkey what English is to Mexico.

“Shock-ma-ti,” she said.

“Shock-ma-ti,” he repeated. “Yes. Follow me.”

Ishamel led her through a short set of turns within the marketplace. They arrived at a kiosk that sold chess sets. Natasha zeroed in on one with hand-carved wooden pieces. It was the Ottoman versus the Christians, a Medieval-crusades-styled set. She bought two sets—one for Tom and the other for Francis Charles. They both loved playing chess. She took off her backpack and slipped the chessboards inside. Then she walked the remaining two blocks back to the hotel.

The security and customs officials did not give her any trouble at the airport. She flashed her black passport to the security personnel, passed her backpack through the metal detector, and walked through it. She picked up her backpack and boarded her flight as usual with nothing more than her boarding pass.

CHAPTER 32

Natasha felt nervous as the limo neared the home of Francis Charles. *There is nothing to be nervous about.* She tried to push away the unsettling idea that Francis Charles could be the Antichrist, but it did not seem likely. *Was he really ambitious for more power? He always seemed so content to serve in whatever position he held. He is just lonely, and maybe a little egocentric,* she told herself, trying to steady her thoughts.

After the limo pulled up, Nicholas stepped out of the driver's seat and opened the door for her. A cold wind blew, and snow pelted Natasha as she made her way from the car to the entry. She was wearing the fur that Francis had given her, its warmth a small comfort in the bitter weather.

Francis was playing his music when Natasha entered. A large glass of wine sat atop the piano.

Tis the season of hope.

Tis the season of gifts and joy.

And peace can always be found.

It is the time of Christmas cheer.

"Natasha! Welcome back." He stood up from playing and embraced her without hesitation. She felt him smooth his hands over her fur as he withdrew.

She smiled. "Merry Christmas, Francis. Wait until you see what I brought for you. I will just go to my room to freshen up, then I will put your gift under the tree."

"Have you eaten yet?"

"No. I am starved."

"You will enjoy dinner then. Maria made the most amazing Chicken Marsala."

"Sounds great." Natasha smiled and turned toward her room. Francis returned to his music. As she walked, she found herself wrestling with why she was really there. The conflict tugged at her.

Was Francis Charles an ambitious, egomaniacal madman suffering from delusions of grandeur and a dangerous fascination with another man's wife? Had he played a part in the conspiracy against Tom? Could he really be planning a deadly event to seize world power?

Or was Francis simply an old friend who had discovered how lonely it was at the top? An old friend sincerely trying to help Tom—but who also loved her? She felt like a betrayer. Of course you feel that way. Alexei Kirov had sent her back to spy on him, to use his feelings for her against him. She was about to embark on a spying mission against a head of state. Well, practically a head of state. He was the Secretary of State.

She remembered her own advice: Test all things. Does it harmonize with known science? Does it harmonize with personal experience? Does it harmonize with other known truths?

Natasha put her backpack in the closet, opened her suitcase, and pulled out one of the chessboards for Francis's gift. She picked up the phone and dialed Nicholas.

"Could you bring me some wrapping paper, scissors, and cellophane tape?"

"Right away, madam."

She hung up and turned on her bathwater.

This idea that Francis Charles could be an up-and-coming Antichrist did not pass her test. *Does it harmonize with science? No. Prophecy has never been proven by the scientific method. Does it harmonize with my personal experience?*

She had to think. The concept of foretelling the future harmonized with her experience, but the real question was the true nature of Francis Charles. The idea that he was planning a deadly event did not fit the man she had known.

But then again, you do not really know him anymore. You have hardly seen him in twenty years.

Nicholas knocked. Natasha opened the door and thanked him for the gift-wrap supplies.

"For certain, madam," he said, then turned to go.

Natasha closed the door and returned to her thoughts as she wrapped the gift.

Does it harmonize with other known truths? A good question. There were several small pieces of evidence that seemed to support the idea—but he was also ambitious. That was a truth. He was also very political. Hmmm.

Natasha finished wrapping, undressed, and slipped into her bath. She decided to meditate, hoping for a little clarity. She cleared her mind, listening for any guidance.

IN GIRUM IMUS NOCTE ET CONSUMIMUR IGNI

The words floated across her mind's eye and startled her out of her meditation. "Eureka!" she whispered. "It is a palindrome!"

She got out of the tub, threw on a bathrobe, accessed the Internet on her phone, and searched for Latin palindromes. Her pulse quickened as she waited. The page loaded, showing several results. The first link had "Latin palindromes" in its URL, which seemed promising. The site listed everything from small words to complex sentences. In girum imus nocte et consumimur igni was on the list—and apparently known as the "Devil's Verse." She clicked on it and read.

Natasha paused. *This had to be well known to scholars. It was hard to believe Francis would not recognize it, yet he had acted as though he did not. He was like an encyclopedia.* She thought of all the languages he knew.

Could he simply not have known this one? Natasha kept scrolling. Near the bottom of the page she saw another palindrome—the proverb Francis had inscribed on her watch. It was a palindrome too: ROMA TIBI SUBITO MOTIBUS IBIT AMOR.

"By me, you arrive to Rome, the love of your travels."

Another familiar image flashed in her mind:

The Five Wounds of Christ. "Rotas arepo tenet opera sator" was also a palindrome—one of the greatest of all time. She remembered seeing it incorporated into a piece of art displayed prominently in Francis's office.

Palindromes were clearly a hobby of his. There was no way he could have been unfamiliar with the Devil's Verse. Why had he pretended otherwise? Was he hiding something?

Natasha finished dressing for dinner. She decided to see whether Kirov was right. She would spy on Francis Charles.

CHAPTER 33

Francis Charles was still playing when Natasha came down and gently placed his present under the tree.

“You cannot open it until at least tomorrow.”

She shook her finger at Francis, and he stopped his performance.

“But that is not fair. I let you open yours early.”

“Not until tomorrow,” Natasha teased.

They walked into the kitchen and dished up the dinner Maria had left on the island in heated catering trays. They sat down, and Francis poured very generous portions of Merlot.

“Natasha, I have a plan to help Tom. As I told you, I have been pushing for the Attorney General’s office to drop the charges. I do not think they are going to. However, if a good attorney fails to defend Tom and he is convicted, then I have a very good plan B.”

“What is it?”

“A presidential pardon.”

“How can you guarantee a pardon?”

“There are no guarantees, of course. But there are good probabilities. You would be surprised at what we know about the lives of just about every President. The sacrament of confession, you know. Of course we can never reveal anything, but they know that we know. And sometimes they think we know things we have no idea of. We can almost always rely on a favor from the White House. And there is also our friend from Washington, William Jaimeson. He is due to be sworn in as the new President next month.”

“Sounds like you are going to take care of us, Francis. Thank you.”

“Stick with me, kid.”

He winked at her.

“You can count on me to help you get Tom free.”

“In the meantime, I can just stay here as your guest in these luxurious accommodations?” Natasha took a bite of the chicken and smiled as she chewed.

“As long as you like. By the way, how was Turkey?”

“It was amazing! I loved it. I had never visited the Basilica Cistern until this trip. I do not know why. Well, you know how it is when you are in the State Department.”

“Yes. I have known some diplomats who would never leave the walls of the embassy compound.”

“Anyway. Turkey was amazing. I spent a lot of time exploring and—as you could probably tell from my bulging bags—tons of shopping. By the way, I saw a painting a lot like the one in your office. Maybe it was painted by the same artist.”

“You mean the Five Wounds of Christ?”

“Yeah.”

“Well, I doubt it was the same artist. I painted that one myself.”

“Wow. I had no idea. You are such a Renaissance man. You never cease to impress me.” Natasha leaned back in her chair. She held up her wineglass. “A toast,” she said. “To the most gifted man I know—Francis Charles.” They clinked glasses and drank.

“Let us go look at it.”

Francis got up and led the way. “I finished the last piece just two years ago. I have a studio upstairs that I rarely get a chance to play in these days.”

They entered the study and Francis flipped on the lights.

“Yes. The Five Wounds of Christ.” He named them and pointed to the corresponding parts of the body of Christ as he did so. “Rotas, arepo, tenet, opera, sator. The tradition of these being the names of Christ’s wounds dates back as early as AD 79, where there are records that it was known to the Ethiopian Christians.”

“Is that not something? But it is in Latin.”

“Yes. The Ethiopian version varied slightly, but one can tell it was the same. They had transliterated it into their own phonetics. Look at how

each word is five letters—and it all spells forward and backward the same. It is what mathematicians call a magic square.”

He looked away from the painting for a moment and stared seriously at Natasha.

“It was used in Medieval times as a prayer to ward off evil spirits and, down through the ages, as a charm to heal. During the time of the plague, people would chant it over and over again with the hope it would keep the plague away.”

“Fascinating,” Natasha said.

They sipped their drinks. Natasha sat down leisurely on the sofa. She curled her feet to her side and leaned against the arm. Francis sat kitty-corner to her in the easy chair and put his feet up on the ottoman.

“Mind if I smoke?” he asked.

“Go ahead.”

Francis stood and walked to his desk. He opened the drawer and pulled out a fancy cigarette case. He clicked it open and offered her the first cigarette.

Natasha waved it off.

“I will be fine with secondhand smoke.”

“Thought I would offer.”

The cigarettes had no filters, but the clove tobacco burned smoothly.

“I rarely smoke, but when I do, these are what I like. They are French.”

Natasha looked up again at the painting and then over at the desk. She could imagine that when Francis sat behind the desk, the paintings would be directly in front of him. She had a feeling that his password had something to do with those five wounds. She felt strongly about it—almost the way a gambler can be certain they are about to win the lottery. Only in Natasha’s case, her strong feelings usually ended up bearing fruit of some kind.

Natasha took a sip of her wine. Another good source to figure out his password might be his Bible.

"You know, Francis. Just because I am not a practicing Catholic, it does not mean that I do not like to read the Bible. Did you leave a Bible in my suite on purpose?"

"No. Not at all. I suppose most of my guests have their own Bibles if they like."

"Maybe you can loan me yours. Sometimes I like to read it late at night if I have trouble sleeping."

"Go ahead."

Francis leaned over to his desk, grasped the Bible, and handed it to Natasha.

"I have been thinking lately about the story of Noah and the Ark," he said, taking a drag on his cigarette.

"Why is that?" Natasha asked.

"Um. I do not know. I guess it is just interesting how God chose to deal with mankind at that point in time. They had become so evil that He just gave up on them. He decided to wash the earth clean and start all over again."

Natasha put her wineglass down on the corner table.

"Seems like I remember a Bible verse somewhere that says something like, 'So as in the days of Noah, so it will be in the time of the end'—or something like that."

"Yes. You are quite right. It does say that," Francis affirmed.

"So what do you think that means?"

"What do you think it means?"

Francis left the room and came back with the wine bottle. He filled their glasses and sat down again. Natasha picked up her wineglass and took another sip. "Kind of scary, do you not think? That global genocide can be so easily rationalized and justified. Do you think everyone who perished in the deluge was evil? What about the children? What about the babies?"

Francis looked upward. His eyes followed the bookcase all the way to the top of the high ceiling. "The innocent perished with the wicked, but it was for the greater good. And so it will be in our times," he said coldly.

“Innocent will perish along with the wicked, but once again it will be for the greater good.”

Natasha shook her head vigorously.

“See, I do not believe that, Francis. Do you not see how twisted that is? It is the same logic used by terrorists. I think it is really misguided how supposedly spiritual people—” Natasha caught herself mid-sentence and stopped. She leaned forward and put her glass down again. Francis listened, seemingly indifferent to her argument.

“I talk about this in my book,” Natasha continued.

“Well, anyway,” Francis replied. “Revelation says a third of mankind will perish.”

An awkward silence settled. They sat for a moment while Francis extinguished his cigarette.

“I think I am ready to retire for the evening, Francis. That was a very nice dinner.”

“The pleasure was all mine, Natasha. I am so glad to have you.” He stood up and they hugged goodnight. Natasha took the Bible with her as she walked back to her suite. Francis sat back down and lit another cigarette.

CHAPTER 34

Natasha was very disturbed by Francis' comments about the great deluge. His callous words made it seem more likely to her that he could be involved in the planning of a deadly event. A deadly event in which Muslims would be the victims.

She felt an urge to read Revelations again. Something about the phrase drew her attention: Revelation chapter 13 verse 10.

*He who lives by the sword,
shall die by the sword.*

She sat down at the desk next to the window and opened Francis' Bible and found the phrase she was looking for:

*He who lives by the sword
Shall die by the sword.
He that leadeth into captivity
Shall be taken into captivity*

Then I saw a second beast rise from the earth.
It had two horns like a lamb.
And it spoke like a dragon.

Natasha was surprised to see the mention of a second beast. She, like many people, had always remembered only a single beast.

Hmm. It's not just one world power—it's two world powers working together. There's the leopard-like beast, which Kirov identifies as the Vatican. There's also the lamb-like beast. If I can identify the lamb-like beast, it may help me to figure out with whom Francis is allied. It could be the key to stopping the deadly event. She opened the desk drawer and pulled out a notepad and a pencil. She wrote on the top:

Clues to the Second Beast

A. Come up out of the earth

B. Has two horns like a lamb

C. Speaks like a dragon

Natasha stared down at her list and tapped the pencil. The word “then” was used. “Then I saw a second Beast coming up out of the earth.” Natasha stared at the words and contemplated. The word “then” indicates a timeline. He who leads into captivity shall go into captivity. According to Kirov, that part was fulfilled when the Pope was taken prisoner in 1798. So this other beast rises after 1798. It comes up out of the earth. The first beast came up out of the water. The Apocalypse says:

**The waters where the beast sits are
people, nations, multitudes.**

Water represents a populated place—the “earth” would seemingly represent an unpopulated place. The second beast rose out of the wilderness sometime around 1798.

Natasha’s eyes widened and her mouth opened.

Does this text actually predict the rise of America? Was there any other power that could fit the clues? Was there any other world power that was born around the time of the fall of the Vatican in 1798? And it was a lamb-like beast. Could that be a clue that it would be considered a Christian nation? What else? What about the phrase “it speaks as a dragon”?

If a world power is speaking, that means it’s legislating. According to Kirov, the Dragon power was the ancient Roman Empire. The Apocalypse says it gave the first beast “its power, its seat, and its great authority.” That certainly happened in the case of Rome. It pretty much withered away and transferred all of her powers to the Vatican around 538 A.D.—it’s a Christian nation that is also a nation based on Roman law. It came into being around the end of the eighteenth century.

Natasha looked down at the text.

It brings fire down from heaven in the sight of men.

Could that be alluding to a ballistic missile-delivered nuclear explosion? Or satellites being brought back down into the atmosphere via remote control? She shook her head. *If this prophecy is real, then this has to be the United States. If this*

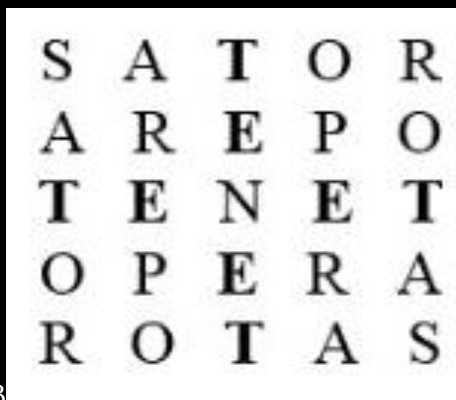
THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

prophecy is real, then it is predicting an end-time alliance of a corrupt Vatican and a corrupt US to obtain and maintain global power.

Natasha remembered Kirov pointing at her.

“You may be the only one who can save the world from whatever deadly event is being planned,” he had said. “I have my mission—and you have yours.”

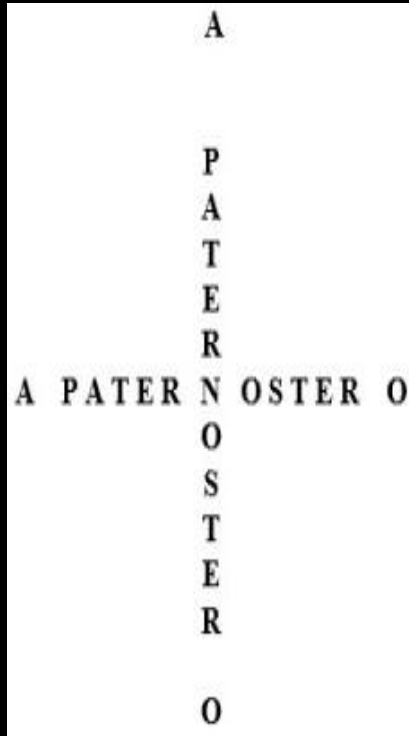
I have to figure out Francis’ password. She wrote down the five wounds of Christ.



B

Natasha noticed that the word TENET crisscrossed itself in the form of a sign of the cross. On top of everything else amazing about this magic square, that fact seemed significant. Her feeling was strong. She felt certain that she was on the right track. *I feel drawn to the feeling that the N in the center is important. Like it's a starting point,* she wrote the letter N.

Now what. *So what's the pattern? The pattern is in the sign of the cross. The paattttterrrnnn.* She saw something. This thought about the pattern. *Paatterrrnn. Pabbttttterrrnnnnnnnosssssterrr.* It was the phrase “Paternoster,”—“Our Father” in Latin. The title of the “Lord’s Prayer” in Latin. The famous street in England is mentioned by Benjamin Franklin in his autobiography. They were all known as the “Paternoster.” “Whoo!” she whispered to herself as she wrote it out.



The only remaining letters were the Latin equivalent of the Greek alphas and omegas. She added those to the end of each point on the cross. Using each letter from the five wounds magic square, the double “Paternoster” could only be formed one way—in the sign of the cross, because each word had to share only N.

That’s got to be it! Natasha got up from the desk and stretched. She looked over at the window, but couldn’t see outside because of the desk light reflection. She turned it off and stared out the window. Large fluffy snowflakes fell through beams of light emanating from the myriad street lamps. In the background, she could ever so slightly hear the music of Handel’s Hallelujah Chorus.

“King of Kings. Forever, and ever
 Lord of Lords. Forever and ever
 Hallelujah, Hallelujah”

Natasha thought about what to do next. She thought about the possibility of sneaking into Francis’ office right now. *He’s had a lot to drink.*

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

He's probably passed out by now. What if he walks in on you while you're at his computer? I'll just tell him I needed to use the Internet. What if he asks how I figured out his password? Then I'll just chastise him to not be so foolish as to leave clues of his password hanging on the wall. I'll tell him it was easy for me to guess it. Maybe my intuitive gifts helped. Lucky guess. Who knows?

Natasha made up her mind. She would do it now and get the heck out of there. She quietly tiptoed back to the study. She didn't make a single sound as her feet moved smoothly across the marble floors. Natasha opened the enormous study door. It moaned a low squeak as it swung open. Natasha stopped and waited to see if anyone had heard the door. Then she thought about how when she was in her room, she couldn't hear anything else in the entire apartment. *There was no way anyone heard that door. I can do this quickly. I know exactly what to do.*

She sat down at the desk without turning on the lights and turned the computer on. The computer booted up and prompted her for a password. *Hope this works.* She typed "paternoster." "Invalid password." The computer replied. Natasha pressed the Caps Lock key and retyped "PATERNOSTER." It worked. "Valid password." The computer replied.

Natasha plugged her thumb drive into the USB slot and began transferring files immediately. She tried to distinguish files of interest from files that weren't relevant at all. She had three specific objectives on his computer.

Copy all of his favorites

Copy all of his saved web pages

Copy all of his saved documents

As she transferred, she noticed some files that caught her attention. One file had population maps of the Middle East. Another file had all kinds of data about UFO sightings and the conspiracy theories that America is hiding the truth about what happened in Roswell, New Mexico. Another file had to do with the top-secret military base known as Area 51. Francis had biographical dossiers on the outgoing U.S. President Jackson, his cabinet, and the presidential candidates—including William Jaimeson. He also had biographical files on several

prominent senators and on numerous highly influential Roman Catholics. Lots of the files didn't have any title at all, just numbers. Some of the files had titles, but Natasha couldn't tell anything significant about them.

Natasha transferred the last file and pulled her memory stick out. It was warm from all the action. She snapped it onto her special neck chain and turned off the computer, standing up to go.

"You're a treasonous swine—just like your husband," the stern voice of Francis Charles startled Natasha intensely.

She froze in mid-step, her arms flailed, and her heart pounded with fear.

"How dare you?" she sputtered. "I was just trying to use the Internet. You must be out of your mind to say something horrible like that to me."

She tried to walk around him and out the door, but Francis stepped in her path and blocked her. She tried to push him aside.

"Let me out of here."

She pushed at his chest.

"You're lying." Francis slapped Natasha across the face so hard that she fell to the ground. He slowly walked over to her, bent over, and yanked her head back with his left hand clutched around her hair. With his right hand, he ripped the memory stick from her bosom. "Did you think you were just going to walk out of here with my files?" He pushed her head back with a jerk and walked around her in a circle. "We've caught you on video, Natasha." He pointed up at the far corners of the ceiling where two small video cameras were installed. "I am the Cardinal Secretary of State of Vatican City, a sovereign nation, and you have just been caught stealing classified documents from my computer." Natasha stood up. Her face was flushed with rage. "We have a special punishment for people like you."

"It couldn't be any worse than listening to your pathetic music." She spat blood on his face, and Francis wiped it off his cheek.

"I'll remember that. I'll make sure to have my songs played for you over and over again while you spend the rest of your life in a damp, cold, solitary dungeon."

The Swiss Guards entered the room. “Guards, arrest this woman on charges of espionage!”

“Stop!” Natasha shouted. She pulled out her diplomatic passport and showed it to the guards. “I am a United States diplomat. Any attempt to arrest me is a violation of international law. Besides, Francis, you wouldn’t want the content of these files to become evidence in a court of law, would you?”

The guards backed off because they knew she was right. Natasha snatched her memory stick.

“I noticed the file you have on the Attorney General.” Natasha let the power of her statement take its effect on Francis. She pushed through them and walked briskly to her suite to retrieve her backpack.

Francis stood speechless. He watched her walk down the hallway. “Don’t just stand there—arrest her!”

“I’m sorry, sir. We cannot. But we will stay at your side until she is gone.” Francis curled his fists in frustration. “Natasha. Natasha, Natasha. Wait. I’m so sorry. How did you expect me to react? Please! Please, Natasha.”

She came out of her suite wearing her backpack and toting a small piece of luggage. Nicholas appeared, and Natasha turned to him. “Nicholas, please help me with my things. We’re leaving for the airport right away.” Nicholas turned to Francis for authorization. Natasha turned to Francis and shot him a stern look. He nodded to Nicholas to take her.

“Please, Natasha. Let’s pretend this didn’t happen. Tomorrow is Christmas Eve.” He looked at his watch. “Actually, it’s today already.”

Natasha and Nicholas made their way down the hallway with her luggage. As they passed near the Christmas tree, Francis pleaded again.

“Please, Natasha. Please, it’s Christmas.”

“You did this to yourself, Francis.”

“Look. I’m opening your present to me. Ah. It’s a beautiful chess set. That’s so thoughtful, Natasha. It’s the nicest present anyone has ever given me.”

“Francis,” she said. She looked at him thoughtfully. He dropped his smile and waited for what she would say.

JOSEPH NICHOLAS

“What?”

“Checkmate! Game over! You lose!” Natasha walked out the door, and Francis stood defeated.

“This is not a checkmate, Natasha. The game’s not over! If anything, it’s a stalemate.”

CHAPTER 35

Once at the airport, Natasha bought a first-class ticket to Istanbul. The flight would leave at 7:00 a.m. and arrive in Istanbul at 1:00 p.m. She made her way to the terminal and went straight to the Internet booth. There, she sent a copy of everything on her thumb drive to Jeremy Benton—along with instructions on what to do with the information should anything happen to her.

She also sent an e-mail to Francis Charles, reminding him to make the arrangements for Tom's release and warning him about the safeguards she had put in place.

Time passed slowly as she waited to board. Natasha used the quiet stretch to think about everything and to try to make sense of it all.

She remembered Kirov's words: *"And what about the Antichrist himself? Would he have to be an evil man? Or could he be misguided, but with good intentions? Leading the world astray, thinking all the way that he is doing good?"*

Natasha felt the answer would be the latter. *"Misguided, yet with good intentions."* She thought Francis Charles played that role rather convincingly. He was a trusted spiritual counselor and advisor to William Jaimeson. It wasn't hard to see how easily the whole Apocalyptic scenario could fall into place.

What are his supposedly 'good intentions'? What are his motives? He thinks he will save the world by somehow ridding it of Islam once and for all—even if it means the murder of millions of innocent people. She remembered how callously he had spoken about the deaths of innocents in the Biblical story.

Can all of this really be true? Can Tom and I ever be safe again? Can I simply go back to Jerrell's Cove and enjoy a peaceful life of fishing, sailing, and writing books?

Natasha looked up. A few people were waiting at her gate, and a boarding agent stood behind the counter. She glanced down at the watch Francis Charles had given her and saw that it was 6:00 a.m. She

remembered how he had slapped her so hard, and she felt repulsed that she was even wearing the watch.

She boarded the plane and tried, unsuccessfully, to fall asleep. The flight was turbulent. When she stood to walk to the restroom, a wave of nausea overtook her. She hurried inside just in time to vomit into the sink. Oh no. I hope to God Tom is safe.

Natasha rinsed her mouth and looked in the mirror. Cosmetics disguised the bruising on her left cheek, but they could not hide the cut on her lip. Completely enraged, she unclasped the watch and threw it in the garbage.

CHAPTER 36

Grant lay on his bunk, sweating while he slept. His eyes moved rapidly back and forth as he dreamt. “Natasha!” he shouted and awoke abruptly. He was shaking.

Grant looked around his room. It was simple hardwood. The window was protected with iron bars. The solid wooden door was outfitted with an iron lock. Locked from the outside, Grant knew. The locking mechanism was loud and clunky as the key turned inside the door.

Grant hadn’t eaten since the lunch he had shared with Natasha after they toured the Basilica Cistern. The priest’s first exorcism treatment was a prescription of fasting in combination with a rigorous bowel cleansing. He was instructed to chant the phrase “Cast out the evil spirit” in Latin, Greek, and Aramaic during each session he spent on the commode. This latter part was an experiment by the priest librarian, inspired by Natasha’s method of exorcism, which had clearly worked.

Grant was weak, and his muscles trembled as he made his way to the door. He leaned against the door and hollered to the priest with painstaking effort. Grant knocked on the door with his knuckles. “Get me the priest. I have seen a vision that he must know about immediately. Tell him it’s about Natasha. Tell him she’s in danger!”

CHAPTER 37

Alexei sat at the controls in the closed-circuit security camera room. His monastery was locked up tight and the guards had been told to be on high alert.

Focused on a monitor, Alexei noticed movement in Grant Nuby's room. Earlier, Nuby had been frail, but now he seemed revived — standing with new strength and confidence. Alexei zoomed the camera in. It looked as if Grant was studying his surroundings for the first time. Alexei checked the computer to make sure it was recording. It was.

Locked inside his tiny room, Grant rotated as if trying to take a 360-degree inventory of the space with his own eyes. He looked either sleepwalking or possessed again. Grant straightened, faced the window, clasped his hands behind his back, and stared out with concentrated effort.

The gesture caught Alexei's attention immediately. It was a distinctive gesture — one particular to none other than Francis Charles.

"Shok-ma-ti!" Alexei muttered under his breath. He picked up his phone. "Euvgeny! Bistra! Eedee sudah! Hurry! Come here! Eta ocheen vazshna! It's very important!"

Euvgeny, a small, middle-aged Ukrainian man with sandy brown hair, arrived a minute later. His eyes were bloodshot and his face still sleepy. "What is it?"

"Something is going on with Mr. Nuby. Watch this."

Alexei played back a looped recording of the gesture. "Does this remind you of anyone?"

Euvgeny shook his head. "No. What about it?"

"I have seen Francis Charles use this body language many times. His mannerism is almost exactly the same."

"What does it mean, master?"

“We are all pawns, Euvgeny. We are all pawns. The question is who the master is. I believe Francis Charles may be practicing a well-honed ability of remote-control consciousness. Look at the way Grant moves in a circle — as if he has never been in that room before.”

“Why would he be interested in Mr. Nuby’s room?”

“He is trying to figure out where Mr. Nuby is at this very moment, so he will know how best to use him in his deadly plans.”

They studied the monitor in silence for a moment.

“You see, Euvgeny, Mr. Nuby is a pawn on his game board.”

CHAPTER 38

Natasha was met at Istanbul International by Alexei. Once on the street, his driver pulled up. Alexei opened the door and put Natasha's backpack on the back seat. The car drove off, leaving them at the curb. Alexei hailed a taxi, opened the door for Natasha, and followed her into the back seat. He leaned forward, spoke to the cab driver, and they drove off in a different direction from the car carrying her backpack. Natasha was wondering what was going on, and *why the car with her backpack was being taken on a separate route.*

"We are being followed," Alexei whispered sideways to Natasha. "I sent my driver without us as a decoy, but I can see they are still following."

"But why did you send him away with my backpack?"

"Because we must make sure it has not been compromised with a homing beacon. It is frighteningly easy to slip one onto a person's backpack—one of the most common methods. We obviously do not want anyone tracking us, so I have a plan."

The taxi made a right turn at the next street. Natasha looked out the window and saw the Black Sea. The taxi continued toward the water until it finally stopped near the entrance to a marina.

"Follow me," Alexei hustled. The two hurried down to the docks. Natasha was amazed at how physically fit Alexei was—even in his old age. At the docks, he strode up to a shack and spoke quickly with the attendant. Alexei gave the man a rather sizeable wad of cash, and the man handed him a set of keys, pointing him in the right direction. He walked back to Natasha and whispered hoarsely.

"We just bought ourselves a jet ski." He kept walking, and Natasha followed. They jogged only a few moments to the Ski Doo.

Alexei and Natasha ripped out of the marina. Natasha clung to his waist. They went airborne as he accelerated full throttle over the choppy waters.

Their pursuer and his partner hurried into their sedan and followed as far as they could up to the marina.

"They're headed to the marina. We will pursue on foot. Over. Bring in the helicopter. We'll rendezvous at the marina. Over."

"Affirmative," the voice on the radio answered. "You are authorized to use lethal force. Over."

Ahead of the marina, they rocketed almost out of sight. Alexei rode close to shore and curved around a bend in the shoreline to the next small marina. They tied up to the dock, and Alexei helped Natasha off.

"We need to switch our transportation. We will need to borrow one of these boats. But which one?"

"We do not have much time. Do you know how to hotwire a boat?" Natasha asked.

"I have absolutely no idea. We must find one with the keys in it."

The dock was slippery. They looked around again.

"Use your intuition. Do you have any idea which boat we should try first?"

"It depends," Natasha answered. She strained to pick up any clues. Then she heard the faint noise of scuba tanks being tested.

"Come on. Give me your gun."

Alexei pulled the handgun out of his pocket and gave it to her. They ran down the dock.

"What are you doing?" Alexei yelled.

"We do not have time to find a boat with keys waiting for us in the ignition. The solution is clear. We are going to have to hijack one."

They arrived at the boat. Two scuba divers were standing on the deck checking their equipment. They looked up as Alexei and Natasha approached. Natasha jumped aboard immediately. "Sorry about this, guys, but we need your boat. It's an emergency."

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Alexei climbed in and translated. The scuba divers looked at each other with stunned faces. Natasha glanced down and saw the keys were in the ignition.

“Untie the boat and get off!”

The divers just stared at Alexei until Natasha pulled out her gun and screamed, “Now!”

The divers jumped off the boat and untied it.

“Full throttle! Get us out of here, Alexei.”

“Where to?”

“Out of here and back to the city.”

Natasha took a defensive position in the rear and scanned for their pursuers. The divers were running toward the marina clubhouse. One of their pursuers arrived at the new marina and scanned for movement. Natasha knew he had spotted them. The boat was now just barely out of the marina. Alexei shoved the lever full throttle and the boat powered out, turning the corner and disappearing from sight.

“Scuba diving in Turkey is best this time of year!” Natasha yelled over her shoulder as she watched for danger. “I had a dream that we were scuba diving in a life threatening situation. And here we are.”

“But we are not scuba diving.”

“We are on a scuba boat. Same difference. It is close enough!”

“So what is the plan?” he asked.

Suddenly, the fearsome sound of a helicopter hummed in the distance. Natasha looked at Alexei. “We’re out of time.”

CHAPTER 39

Francis Charles climbed a narrow, steep staircase in his palace. It led to a secret chamber room, which lay hidden behind his art studio. It was a small, plush room. Around the perimeter of the room lay dozens of silk and velvet pillows. The pillows were in various shapes and sizes, colored in bright shades of red, purple, and pearl.

The ceiling was curved into a dome and, along the walls, a display nook displayed a secret collection of treasured antiquities. Francis reverently approached a tiara. He held it in his hands and enjoyed its heavy feel. He closed his eyes and raised his brow in pleasure as he placed the tiara on his own head. He inhaled a breath of satisfaction and exhaled slowly.

Francis relished the feel of his triple crown. His mental powers were magnified by the tiara. It was like an antenna booster, catching brainwaves like tinfoil on rabbit ears.

A unique golden chess-like game board was centered on the main table. On the surface was an old world map of the earth. The intersecting lines of longitude and latitude created the checkerboard pattern. Instead of traditional chess pieces, Francis had hand-carved his own personal set. They were meticulously carved to resemble the person they represented as closely as possible. He had a Natasha the Empress, William Jaimeson the President, and Grant Nuby the Seer. There were many other such pieces, which covered the space of his special game.

CHAPTER 40

The helicopter flew up over the rocky, hilly peninsula that protected Natasha and Alexei from view. The pilot scanned the waters below for the boat. It was further away than he had expected. The pilot pushed a control and tilted the craft forward to accelerate toward Alexei and Natasha.

“Target is in sight,” the pilot reported.

“Excellent,” a voice in his headphones affirmed. “Blow them out of the water.”

“Missile is locked onto target.”

“You are going for a missile launch.”

The pilot pulled the trigger, and a missile bulletted toward Alexei and Natasha, accelerating almost instantly to near the speed of sound. It shot out of the helicopter with a muffled roar and then swerved to target the heat of the boat’s exhaust precisely.

Within moments, the missile reached its target. The boat exploded into a fireball. Thousands of fragments and jagged splinters burst out in all directions.

“Target destroyed,” the pilot reported.

“Excellent.” The commander gloated.

CHAPTER 41

Natasha and Alexei survived the missile attack by diving into the Black Sea with partial scuba gear. The bubbles flowed out of Natasha's mouthpiece and up through the water as she handed the secondary breathing apparatus to Alexei. He purged it as he placed it into his mouth and inhaled deeply. He looked at Natasha. She was beautiful with her hair swirling in the blue abyss. They heard the chopper get close, then the boom of the missile launch. The boat exploded into flames. Fuel sprayed out across the water's surface and burned overhead. They looked at each other with a wide-open expression of amazement.

Natasha pointed to Alexei with two fingers. Alexei acknowledged that he understood, but then he patted his back and reminded Natasha that he didn't have his own tank. Natasha nodded. She knew that. She just wanted to tell him. "I know where we need to go. Follow my lead."

They surfaced carefully onto the high bank waterfront. There was a small dock and a steep set of stairs affixed to the cliff. They shed their weights, Natasha shed her tank and vest, and they carefully made their way.

"We are safe for now, Natasha. They think we are dead. Do you still have the gun?"

Natasha patted herself and pulled the gun out of her front pocket.

"Do you still have your cell?" she asked.

He patted himself, pulled his cell from his pocket, and flipped it open. Water drained from its inner casing. "I still have it, but it is only a paperweight now. What about yours?"

"Mine's in my backpack."

"Then it is safe at least."

At the top of the stairs, they stood near a busy roadway and thought for a moment. Alexei turned right and pointed down the road.

“There is a phone in that direction we can use to call my driver. It will be just a short walk.”

A few minutes later, they arrived at the phone. Alexei pulled damp coins out of his pocket, pushed them into the slot, and dialed. Natasha looked around, still being vigilant, scanning for signs of danger, while Alexei spoke with his driver.

After 10 minutes, the driver pulled up.

“It is a short drive, but you will need to put this on.”

He handed her a blindfold.

CHAPTER 42

Alexei led Natasha blindfolded into the heart of his monastery. Natasha couldn't see, but she perceived that they were in a large building. Maybe it was the groan of the front doors or the echo of their footsteps. Somehow, she had a sense.

Natasha was brought into a room. The doors were shut and locked. She was seated at a rustic circular conference table, and her blindfold was finally removed. "Welcome," Alexei greeted her. "We are inside what some refer to as a bubble room, in technical terms, a SCIF, sensitive compartmented information facility. It is a room insulated on all sides to block any electronic signals. A giant Faraday cage. No signals can get in and no signals can get out."

Natasha looked around. She was relieved to see her pack set neatly against the wall. She walked over to it and took it back. They were in what appeared to be an extensive circular library. Tall bookcases lined the walls and soared high until the walls began their arched transition into a domed ceiling. Other than the bookcases, the walls appeared to be made entirely of wood. There was no sheetrock and no paint. It felt like a mixture of a cedar lodge and a castle.

"We have a problem to solve," Alexei said. He produced a flask and two shot glasses. Alexei poured the vodka into each glass. He raised his glass into the air. "Let us drink to the success of our sacred mission."

Natasha consumed the vodka with the ease of a seasoned diplomat. The alcohol took its medicinal effect, helping to calm her nerves. Alexei opened a laptop computer and turned it around for Natasha. He played the film loop that he had shown to Euvgeny. "As you can see, that is Mr. Nuby in his quarters here at my monastery. Please watch his body language and tell me if it means anything to you."

Natasha watched. Grant Nuby arose from his bed. He stood in the center of the room and rotated clockwise 360 degrees. He stopped and

stood straight as a soldier. He clasped his hands behind his back and spied out his window with concentrated effort. Natasha recognized it right away. “That reminds me of Francis Charles.”

“Tochna! Exactly! I saw it right away myself. Can you tell me what you think is happening here?”

Natasha waited for him to explain.

“I believe Francis Charles has mastered the skill of remote-control consciousness. For these few moments, we have not been watching Mr. Nuby. We have been watching Francis Charles.”

Natasha’s mind made a startling connection. If this was Francis Charles acting remotely from inside Grant’s body, then it could have been Francis Charles who killed Father Elijah. Remotely, of course. Perhaps Frances had used Mr. Nuby all along to spy on her all these years.

The part of Natasha that was a handwriting expert pondered this thought. It had been Francis Charles who had sparked her interest in paleography when she had witnessed his everyday handwriting. It was an incredibly beautiful and distinctive calligraphy. She had never seen handwriting like it, ever. It was a perfect melding of ancient and modern styles that he had made his own. Of course, she could never have made the connection before. It was impossible not to think of the writing on the wall next to the body of Father Elijah.

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She closed her eyes and focused on her memory—especially on the letters G, S, and U. She pictured them on the wall. Then she pictured the last note he had written to her. She remembered noticing the very distinctive way Francis formed those particular letters. The bloody writing on the wall next to the body of Father Elijah was consistent with the distinctive and very rare writing of Francis Charles. Natasha looked up. “It was Francis Charles who wrote the Devil’s Verse. It’s so obvious to me now. I’m certain of it. He is a remote killer.”

Alexie nodded affirmatively. “Now do you understand the reason for the blindfolds?”

CHAPTER 43

Natasha looked around at the book-lined walls of the room, searching her mind for the next step. “We need to think about what we can possibly do,” Natasha said.

“We need to get some kind of proof,” Alexei answered. “From what you have told me thus far, the information you pulled off of his computer doesn’t prove Francis is planning a terrorist event.”

“If we could just get some good evidence, we could show it to the Swiss Guard.”

“I agree,” Alexei said. “We need proof of a plot.”

“But how can we get more proof?”

There was silence again until Natasha spoke up. “What if we can’t find any proof that’s good enough? We can’t just let him go through with his plan. People’s lives are in danger.”

“So we must work on two goals simultaneously,” Alexei said. “We must work to find and stop the deadly event, and we must try to gather more evidence.”

“But how?”

“We have to use our heads. We need to think about our next move carefully.”

“So what can we do?” Natasha asked.

There was silence for a few moments.

“Alexei, can you get out some paper and pens. We need to brainstorm. The key is not to restrict our thinking. Write down every thought—no matter how crazy it may seem. Don’t censor. Just write everything freely.”

They looked down at their blank notepads for a long few moments before they suddenly broke loose, quickly jotting one idea after another and looking for connections.

Wait a second. Maybe there is something. Natasha bent over to the backpack at her feet and pulled out the Bible of Francis Charles. Maybe there's a sample of his handwriting in his Bible. Then I can show how distinctive his writing actually is.

She flipped through the Bible, and it fell open to a well-thumbed page. It was as if it had spent a lifetime opened to that page. Four words were outlined with a yellow marker—"You shall not die."

Interesting. Natasha continued to make notes as she brainstormed. A few minutes later, she looked up from her notes. "Listen to this, Alexei. I think I may have found something. Francis seemed to be fixated on this passage in the Book of Jude, and maybe I'm crazy, but it seems connected to the IN GIRUM IMUS NOCTE ET CONSUMIMUR IGNI palindrome 'wander in darkness, consumed by flame.'"

Natasha looked down and read aloud from the one-page Book of Jude.

"Beloved, I found it necessary to write to you exhorting you to contend earnestly for the faith which was once for all delivered to the saints. For certain men have crept in unnoticed, who long ago were marked out for this condemnation, ungodly men, who turn the grace of our God into lewdness and deny the only Lord God and our Lord Jesus Christ. And the angels who did not keep their proper domain, but left their own abode, He has reserved in everlasting chains under darkness for the judgment of the great day; Woe to them! For they have gone in the way of Cain, have run greedily in the error of Balaam for profit, and perished in the rebellion of Korah. These are wandering stars for whom is reserved the blackness of darkness forever."

Natasha looked up to Alexei.

Alexie seemed to be processing and remarked, “Another example of how the apostles feared the hijacking of their faith.”

“It is more,” Natasha continued. “Do you see the second-to-the-last sentence? ‘Perished in the rebellion of Korah?’ The rebellion of Korah was a 250-strong uprising by leading Israelites against Moses and Aaron. Moses used the Rod of Aaron to call down fire from heaven to destroy those who were against him. Then God told Moses to put the Rod of Aaron inside the Ark of the Covenant, next to the Ten Commandments, in order that those who perished in the fire ‘may not die!’”

Natasha quickly turned the pages and read aloud, “The Book of Numbers Chapter 17, verse 10.

The Lord said to Moses, “Put back Aaron’s staff in front of the Testimony, to be kept as a sign to the rebellious. This will put an end to their grumbling against me, so that they will not die.”

Natasha continued, “According to Jude, it is these, the ones who perished in the rebellion of Korah, that are destined to infiltrate the Church. It is these rebels that were also killed by the wrath of God by fire, and were also cursed by the same God, so that they would not die. It is these souls that *wander in the night, consumed by fire.*”

Not only that, Natasha continued. “An 11th-century compilation of Hebrew scriptures and their explanations and interpretations, known as the Yakut, volume two, records a list of supposed immortals, and included on that list are *Korah* and three of his sons.

“What are you getting at?” Alexie asked.

“What I’m getting at is one of the most important questions. The question of who Francis Charles is. Who is he really?”

“Yes. I see where you are going. He is not just an ordinary person, is he?”

“No. I’ve never known anyone like him. Even twenty-five years ago, he seemed to have vast, superhuman knowledge of our world—philosophy, science, literature, history, culture, languages, art, music, calligraphy. He seemed to be a genius in every category.”

“So what are you thinking, Natasha?”

“He wants to perpetrate genocide,” Natasha answered. “He thinks he will save the world by doing so.”

“Noted,” Alexei responded. “But what does your Bible story have to do with it?”

“Well. As we were saying, the question of who Francis Charles is an important one. Who is this man? Who is this brilliant, amazing person who, among so many other talents, has also demonstrated a skill for remote control killing?”

“Buddhist monks say it takes a lifetime of disciplined training even to cultivate the slightest skill at remote consciousness. It is not something you can learn at university.”

“Right. It’s more like a skill one would develop after spending fifty years communing with mystical monks,” Natasha finished.

“Who is this man who seems to be poised to take world power? We need to know if we plan to be successful in stopping his deadly plans.”

“All right. I’m just floating this as a free idea. Remember brainstorming—no censoring, let everything flow.”

“Yes. Yes,” Alexei encouraged.

“A curse of immortality”

Alexei leaned forward. What a bizarre and interesting idea.

Natasha continued, “What if the man who is seeking world power through the vehicle of the Vatican government is a man who feels it’s his for the taking? A man who knew Moses himself, who challenged Moses for the leadership of the people!”

“This is an interesting idea,” Alexei admitted. “And, of course, that makes sense if he were immortal,” Alexei said. “He would be forced to relocate every fifty years or so to keep people from growing suspicious. Not for fear of death, but for fear of imprisonment. The worst punishment for an immortal.”

“He would have to ask himself: When will someone finally figure out that I’m immortal? When will they arrest me and try to kill me in every conceivable way? How many times and how many different ways will they try to kill me? Will they burn me alive? Will they cut me into pieces?”

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Natasha continued, “And so, at the right time, Korah escapes to the land of the Far East. Every fifty years or so, he will suddenly appear in a new town and assume a new identity—but with all of his knowledge, skill, and wealth, he must still always worry about that one horrible possibility. The possibility that forced him to run from his land of Israel. The horrible prospect of being tortured a thousand ways and then locked in a prison cell. It’s a fate worse than death.”

“That is why he aspires to be the unquestioned leader of the world,” Alexei concluded.

“Yes,” Natasha affirmed. “Not only does he see himself as uniquely qualified and entitled, but it’s the only way he can guarantee his own safety and well-being. It’s his only possible escape from his 4,000 years of reinventing himself. It’s a position he feels he will finally be able to apply all his vast knowledge, experience, and abilities to the good of humanity. Could Francis Charles really be Korah?” Natasha asked.

“Yes” Alexei said. “If this is true, if Francis Charles is actually an Immortal named Korah, it means that he and the immortals from the rebellion and the fallen angels are all after the same thing. They have joined forces to take possession of the Rod of Aaron. If they succeed, they will be an unstoppable army of the damned.”

“How could we possibly know if we are right about this theory?”

“I can think of at least two separate ways to verify this hypothesis independently,” Natasha answered. “But I’ll need Mr. Nuby’s assistance.

CHAPTER 44

Red lights began to flash.

“It is the alarm!” Alexei announced.

There was a sound of the lock on the inside of the door being rotated. The door swung open and Euvgeny entered. “Master, we are under attack.”

“Attack? From whom?” Alexei demanded.

“From mercenaries, presumably.”

“But how could they know our location?”

Natasha pointed to the laptop computer.

“You were paying attention to Mr. Nuby’s body language. But were you paying attention to what he might have been able to see from out of his window?”

“Of course, we thought of that. But there is nothing out there that could help Francis Charles know where we are.”

“Nothing on the ground,” Natasha stated. “He may have been able to see the planes landing and taking off. That would give Francis Charles our position relative to the airport.”

“In any case, it doesn’t matter. They found us now. We must bring Mr. Nuby here right away. It will take the mercenaries some time to break through our defenses, and the bubble room is in the innermost, most secure area. We have a little bit of time, but we must hurry.”

“Natasha, you stay here. Do not open the door for anyone except me. Euvgeny and I will retrieve Mr. Nuby. You can monitor our progress by watching the video feeds from our security cameras.”

Alexei pointed at the LCD screen, which displayed twenty separate video feeds.

“Euvgeny, radio,” Alexei demanded.

Euvgeny unclipped his radio and handed it to Natasha.

“Radio us if you see something we should know about.” Alexei opened a Velcro flap on his robe and handed her a pistol.

“Do not hesitate to use it, Natasha.”

“Don’t worry. I won’t.” She took the gun from him and placed it on the table next to the laptop. Alexei and Euvgeny quickly shut and locked the door behind them. They ran down the corridors lit by flashing red bulbs. Natasha watched the video monitors. Video feeds 4, 8, 12, and 16 showed the perimeter areas. The mercenaries were preparing to blow the locks on the front door of the monastery. One of the mercenaries ran up and back. He had just placed the explosive. There was a flash, and the mercenaries were in.

Natasha pressed the button on the hand radio. “They’ve just blasted through the entry,” she announced.

“Understood,” Alexei answered.

Natasha looked down at the video feeds. She was watching Grant Nuby’s room. She saw the door open. Alexei and Euvgeny propped the weakened Grant Nuby onto his feet. They each took one of his arms and put it over their shoulders. Alexei put the radio to his mouth.

“Is the corridor clear?”

“All clear,” Natasha radioed back.

Natasha looked down, trying to see if any of the mercenaries would intercept them or catch them from behind. She pointed at one of the video screens herself and grabbed the radio. “Run!” she commanded. “They’ll be on your rear end anytime.”

Alexei and Euvgeny ran, dragging Mr. Nuby along between them.

“Get out of that hallway!” Natasha yelled.

The mercenaries turned the corner and saw Alexei, Euvgeny, and Grant at the far end of the corridor. They raised their guns to fire. In that instant, Alexei swung shut a steel door. The automatic gunfire ricocheted off in a deafening thunder.

Alexei put a huge key into the door and turned it with great effort to secure the lock. The three of them ran ahead to yet another steel door, locked it behind them, and then ran to another steel door. A moment later, it was the lock on the enormous bubble room door being turned.

Alexei, Euvgeny, and Grant Nuby rushed in. Alexei locked the door again.

“Try not to panic. We have time. We are at the innermost center of my compound. Underneath the wood façade, the doors and walls are impermeable steel.”

“What about the Turkish police?” Natasha asked. “Won’t they help?”

“If the mercenaries have come this far, it means the police have been bought and paid for.”

Grant looked very bad. His eyes were sunken, and they were ringed with dark circles. His hair was matted and stuck to his forehead with perspiration. Natasha hugged him, but he barely responded.

“I’m sorry,” he said. “I’m not well.”

“It’s okay, Grant. We need your help. And we need it fast. Alexei, do you have any water for him?”

Euvgeny walked across the room and pushed on a cabinet door. It was a secret panel that hid the wet bar and mini fridge. He took a bottle, opened it for Grant, and handed it to him.

Grant grabbed the water and quickly drank the entire bottle. “I’m weak because I’m fighting to stay in control,” he stuttered. “I’m fighting off the control from another entity.”

“That has to be Francis Charles,” Natasha exclaimed. “We can use this to our advantage.”

“How?” Euvgeny asked.

“Remember when the Russians stopped that shipment of typewriters that was on its way to the U.S. embassy? They planted bugs in them that would transmit the sound of the print ball spinning as it typed.”

“Yes,” Alexei answered.

Natasha turned to Euvgeny. “It was ingenious. The Russians could listen to that ball spin, and they could tell which letter was being typed. For years, they deciphered every document typed on embassy typewriters. When the CIA discovered one of the bugs, they used it as an

opportunity to feed bad information back to the Russians—and, for years, the Americans were able to use the bugs for their own purposes.”

“I understand what you are saying,” Alexei said. “We use Mr. Nuby to send false data back to Francis.”

“But wait,” Natasha said. “This is a bubble room. I thought no signal could come in or out.”

“That is right. I was going to do this anyway,” Alexei said as he made his way to the other side of the room.

He turned a large wheel around and around. Above them, the large domed ceiling opened as if it were the electronic iris of a camera.

“Grant, it’s Francis Charles trying to get inside your mind.”

“How do you know it’s not a demon?” he asked weakly.

“It’s him, Grant. We have something that he wants.”

“Grant, now that you know it’s him, we need you to tap into whatever wavelength he’s using and use it against him. Follow his signal back to his own head and tell us what you can find. Can you do that?”

“I can try.”

“Must do better than try, Mr. Nuby. You must make atonement!”

Natasha put Francis’ Bible in Grant’s hands, so he could focus on Francis more easily. “Grant, we want to know more about who he really is. What are his fears and weaknesses? What are his deadly plans? Especially, we need to know about the attack he is planning.”

Grant nodded his head. “I will make atonement. Remember me well, Natasha. Remember that I am not an evil ma—.”

“It looks like the signals are getting in now,” Alexei announced.

Grant bared his teeth in effort, and more beads of sweat appeared on his brow. Natasha put her hands on Mr. Nuby’s shoulders and looked him in the eyes.

“Grant, we’re going to blindfold you. Let Francis take you over. While he’s staring at blackness through your eyes, you follow his signal back. Tap into it. I’ll give you five minutes. After that, I’ll electroshock Francis Charles out of your brain. Do you understand?”

“Yes.”

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Alexei put the blindfold on Grant and helped ease him into a chair at the round table. Euvgeny came back with the remains of what used to be a lamp cord. The positive and negative wires had been separated, and the plastic insulation stripped from them.

“The sensory deprivation will confuse Francis Charles. It may cause him to intensify his remote ability, which might make it easier for you to tap into it.” Natasha grabbed the earplugs and pushed them into Grant’s ears. Grant relaxed his tense muscles, and the room went silent.

CHAPTER 45

Alexei whispered sharply. “We must prepare our escape simultaneously.”

He hurried over to his control panel and began turning a hand crank in circles. Euvgeny lifted on the back of Grant’s chair and pulled him backward from the table. Two cylinders rose out of the center of the table like a bull’s eye. The center cylinder pushed out first. It was an enclosure for a tall, thin, compressed gas tank—the type used for helium.

The second cylinder rose up around the compressed air encasement. Alexei finished turning the hand crank. He hurried back, jumped up on the table, and pushed a button on the air tank, igniting a flame.

He pulled blue nylon fabric from the cylinder that ringed around the center. The fabric came out like tissue. Alexei held it over the flame and pulled a drawstring closed. The fabric began to inflate and rise higher. It grew larger and taller as more fabric climbed out of the ringed container. Alexei put his finger to his lips, signaling Euvgeny and Natasha not to utter a word about their escape vehicle. Natasha stood in awe as she watched the round conference table transform into a hot air balloon.

Euvgeny reached under the side of the table and unlatched something. It was the basket walls. They were folded in on the underside of the table. Euvgeny unlatched them, swung them into position, and locked them into place.

Now the tabletop was transformed into the balloon’s floor, and chest-high walls were in place along the circumference.

Alexei continued feeding the balloon more fabric as it inflated. Euvgeny joined Natasha in watching the video feeds. The mercenaries easily blasted through the door that had previously deflected bullets. There were only two doors left.

Natasha looked at her watch before she looked down at Grant. Grant was moving his head around. His wrists pulled against his

handcuffs. He caressed the cover of the Bible. He rubbed his finger over the gold-embossed name on the lower left corner, and his eyebrows raised.

He held the Bible up to his nose with his cuffed hands and inhaled. A look of acknowledgement manifested itself on Grant's face. Then he began to inhale again.

An alarming idea washed over Natasha. This isn't just remote viewing. It's remote sensory. He's sniffing for info. Natasha took the positive and negative ends of the lamp wire from Euvgeny. She pressed them onto Grant's chest. Grant seized in a tremendous spasm. His chest arced outward, and his eyes rolled back into his skull.

He fell forward unconscious. Natasha checked his pulse. His heart was still beating. She shook his shoulders.

"Grant. Grant!"

Grant looked up and smiled. "You won't believe what I just learned."

An explosion rattled the room.

"Quickly!" Alexei shouted. "The only door left for them to break through now is that one. Get in here now." Alexei gave Natasha his hand, and she pushed off against it as she climbed in. Euvgeny helped Grant inside and sat on the floor, his back against the wall. Euvgeny jumped in, and Alexei unclipped the anchor lines.

A pile of rope spiraled out of the basket as they ascended. The end of the rope was attached to a lever that controlled the iris.

As the basket cleared the iris, an explosion shook the tower. The rope attached to the iris lever became taut, and the balloon jerked to a stop. Alexei freed the rope's end from the balloon floor. He leaned over the edge and yanked on the line like a fisherman trying to free a snag.

"Help!" he yelled. "We must pull the lever to shut the iris. Otherwise, they'll be able to shoot up at us through its opening!"

Natasha and Euvgeny pulled on the line too. Suddenly, the lever jerked and released; the iris began to close. Beneath them, they could see the mercenaries rush into the room. One of them was directly below the iris. He fired his automatic weapon. The iris was closing. His bullets

ricocheted off the underside of the iris, and the hot air balloon speedily ascended into Turkish airspace.

Natasha looked below. The buildings appeared smaller and smaller. The mercenaries were scrambling out of the monastery like ants rushing out of a disturbed nest. They rushed out and tried to follow, but were thwarted by heavy rush-hour traffic.

“Alexei sent a missile-armed helicopter after us.”

“Hopefully that won’t happen again.”

“So what did you find out, Grant?”

“He’s a powerful adversary. You already suspected it, didn’t you? That’s why you asked me to find out who he really is.”

“Yes. Who is he?” Alexei asked.

“He’s Korah the Rebel. He’s Francis Charles. He’s a hundred lives in between. When I entered his mind, I entered thousands of years of memories. They flashed at me one after another. Only the prominent ones, of course—The escape from Egypt, Moses returning from Mount Sinai with the 10 Commandments, his rebellion against Moses, the fiery punishment dealt to him from God, His discovery of his own newfound powers of immortality, fear of imprisonment, the fear of torture, his ambition to be emperor, his obsession with Natasha.”

“And then I saw his plans. It will be an airplane. It will be hijacked and flown into the United Nations building.”

“Oh my goodness! I’ve been having a recurring nightmare of that,” Natasha exclaimed.

“I told you,” Grant gloated. “Pay attention to clues in your dreams.”

“It will happen on January 1. The pope will be addressing the world from the United Nations podium.”

“What plane? Which flight?”

“I don’t know. All I know is that Francis leaked the pope’s itinerary to the American Islamic Militia.”

“How can we prove it? Where is the proof?”

“I don’t know,” Grant said. “I guess he more than leaked it. They have an agreement.”

“Francis is too smart,” Natasha remarked. “He’s not going to leave us any proof of his involvement.”

For a moment, there was silence as the four crusaders floated through the skies.

“Where are you taking us?” Natasha asked.

“I have been trying to figure that one out.”

“We have six days. Between now and then, we need to try to find another way short of sending Grant to the airport with a set of witching sticks.”

“True,” Alexei agreed. “Are there any suggestions as to where we should land this balloon?”

Natasha stood up and leaned against the wall, looking out at the sky. Grant stood up too. It was as if everyone was looking for shapes in the clouds to give clues on what to do next.

A friendly pigeon flew near. It made Natasha smile. The bird seemed to float and fly so effortlessly.

“When Paris was surrounded by the Prussians in 1870, all of the communications were cut off. The only way Paris could communicate with the outside world was via pigeon mail,” Natasha remarked.

“Pigeon mail?” Grant asked.

“Yes, pigeon mail,” she continued. “In fact, they used hot air balloons to transport the pigeons safely over enemy lines.”

“Interesting.”

“Yes. Amazing, but true. They were also used in World War I and World War II. I read about one pigeon that was actually awarded a medal by the French government. Despite being shot, it delivered its message, which barely dangled from the poor bird’s exposed tendon. The message saved more than two hundred American soldiers who were trapped by the Germans.”

“Wasn’t there also speculation that Osama Bin Laden at one time used pigeons to communicate?” Evgeny asked.

“I think I once heard something about that, too,” Natasha remarked.

“Either him or the Taliban. Something like that. There are still mountain

villages in India in which the only means of communication is, in fact, pigeon mail.”

Grant’s eyes rolled as if he were using them to access a file in his brain.

“What?” Natasha asked.

“I’m just remembering some images from Francis Charles. I have memories of him handling mail pigeons going back almost one thousand years.”

“How do you know how long ago?” Alexei asked.

“Just guessing based on clues from the images and impressions of the memory. Instinct. It’s hard to explain.”

“Of course,” Natasha exclaimed. “That makes perfect sense. Of course, he would be a master at pigeon mail.”

Grant looked up at Natasha.

“He’s using pigeons now, too.”

“I’ll bet that’s how he’s communicating to the Islamic radicals,” Natasha speculated.

“You said it yourself,” Alexei said. “You heard Osama Bin Laden and the Taliban used them.”

“I sense that’s correct,” Grant said.

Natasha said, “I know that when the French used the pigeons, they would send as many as thirty of them with the same message to the same location to guarantee that the message would arrive. If Francis Charles is communicating with terrorists via pigeon mail, then his messages would have to be encrypted in some type of cipher code.”

“That might be the proof we need,” Alexei said.

They all looked at him.

“I will bet that right now we have two pieces of information that will get us the proper attention from the Swiss Guard,” Alexei explained.

“Number one. We tell them that we know the pope is planning to travel to the United Nations on January 1. I am sure that the pope’s itinerary is top secret. That should get their attention. Number two. We can tell them that we know why they have been finding postal pigeons with indecipherable messages. If what you say is true about the need for

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multiple pigeons, then I will bet that a stray pigeon has found its way to the Swiss Guard office more than once.”

“We have a way that may be able to prove our theory and also catch Francis Charles and the terrorist red-handed,” Natasha added.

“That answers the question then,” Alexei announced. “We go to Rome”

CHAPTER 46

Several hours passed. “The balloon is blue and white camouflage,” Alexei remarked. “We are hard to see from the ground with just the naked eye.”

Natasha looked out into the distance. Sunset transformed the skies into a beautiful collage of fiery clouds on a violet canvas. The setting sun stole the last remains of warmth. Natasha sat down and leaned against the wall of the basket. She crossed her arms around her drawn-up knees. Alexei sat next to Grant. They were scrunched together as a family seated at a semicircular diner booth. The flames burned above them like a levitating campfire.

“There’s something else I discovered,” Natasha broke the silence. “I think I may have stumbled onto the third part of the mystery.”

“What is it Natasha?” Alexei asked.

“When you talked to Grant and me about the beast of the Apocalypse—the one with seven heads that sits on the seven hills—you were very convincing. I believe you were right. That beast is the Vatican, but you never mentioned the second beast in that chapter. I suspect you read right past it like most people.”

Natasha opened her backpack, pulled out the Bible, and re-read the passage. “Notice that there are actually two beasts,” Natasha said. “The second beast has *two horns like a lamb and speaks as a dragon*. Remember that the first beast comes *out of water* and that the Apocalypse describes the symbolic meaning of water as ‘*peoples, nations, multitudes*.’ In other words, ‘a densely populated region. But the second beast does not come out of the water. It comes out of the symbolic opposite of water. It comes up out of the earth. Earth would then be symbolic of wilderness or a sparsely populated region.’”

“Hmm. Very good,” Alexei encouraged.

“But look at this,” Natasha continued. “You said that when France conquered the Vatican in 1798, it was the fulfillment of the prophecy in which the 1,260 years of power come to an end, and also that it fulfilled the part of the prophecy that states the beast would be mortally wounded. Last but not least. The conquering of the Vatican in 1798 was specifically marked in this prophecy by the words: Revelation 13:10:

“He who leads into captivity shall go into captivity.

He who kills by the sword will be killed by the sword.”

Well. Look at the word that follows this line.”

Natasha handed the Bible across to Alexei and continued her explanation. “It’s the word *THEN* that denotes a timeline. The beast is mortally wounded in 1798, but *then...*”

“But then what?” Euvgeny asked.

“But then look at the very next verse. No... the very next word, in fact. After the word then.”

Alexei looked down and read aloud. Chill bumps ran down his arms as he read.

**Then, I saw a second beast
coming up out of the earth.**

“Unbelievable!” Alexei exclaimed in complete awe.

Natasha nodded as the idea sank into his mind.

She continued, “Name me one world power on the face of the entire planet that sprang into existence in a sparsely populated area in the world immediately after the period of 1798.”

“Australia!” Euvgeny interjected.

“Australia has never been a global power,” Alexei countered.

“But America wasn’t founded in 1798,” Grant argued.

“It wasn’t founded in 1798, but in 1798 it was an infant. That’s for sure,” Natasha defended.

“It was coming up out of the earth, so to speak, in 1798,” Alexei said.

Alexei used his cell phone to connect to Onlineclopedia. He read aloud: 1776—Declaration of Independence.

1783—Great Britain officially recognized America as a sovereign nation.

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1787—Constitutional Convention. Delaware, Pennsylvania, and Georgia became states.

1788—Connecticut, Massachusetts, Maryland, South Carolina, New Hampshire, Vermont, and New York become states.

1789—North Carolina

1790—Rhode Island

1791—The Bill of Rights. Vermont becomes a state.

1792—Kentucky

1796—Tennessee”

Natasha explained, “So, as one beast is going down, mortally wounded ... another beast comes up. One goes down—the other comes up. “Now look at the rest of the chapter. You see. It’s the American beast that enforces economic boycotts on the inhabitants of the world. This chapter does not speak of one power. It speaks of two powers working together. It speaks of an alliance between two powers for the purpose of global control.”

“Shok-ma-til” Alexei exclaimed. “Natasha, this is it. It is the missing piece. The lamb-like nation that will change into a nation that speaks like a dragon.”

“Yes. But there is more. Now that we know who Francis’ ally could be, we have some clues as to how he may proceed. Here is one possible scenario. I believe he is planning not one deadly event, but two. The first event will be to bring about its own power. The second event will be the deadliest and will require his alliance with that second beast power. It will be the terrible and fearsome event that you spoke of. The newly elected Pope Francis Charles will remind the world that the Book of Revelation predicted that a third of the earth would be scorched and that a third of mankind would perish. He will quote scripture that states, ‘*As it was in the days of Noah, so it will be in the time of the end.*’ The horrible, crazy, and terrifying reality will unite the world under the dictatorship of Francis Charles. William Jaimeson would be his accomplice. We must find a way to save these two great powers from falling into the hands of these two men and this dark destiny.”

The three men around her sat silently as they digested what Natasha just said. They looked at the flames.

Natasha looked at Grant. She could tell that he was fighting his own mind as it thought about all of these things.

“We won’t just be able to land this balloon on the Vatican helipad so easily,” Natasha said. “We’re going to have to call the Swiss Guard. We’ll have to convince them.”

“Yes. And we will need to make sure we are off of Francis’ radar,” Alexei answered.

They turned to look at Mr. Nuby. He had been sitting quietly, but suddenly he became a little bit twitchy.

“Grant, are you all right?” Natasha asked softly.

“I’m fighting the entity. He’s trying to get into my head again.”

“You mustn’t let him in, Grant. Please fight him off.”

“I know. I know,” Grant answered.

Natasha remembered that earlier he had said that he had become weak from fighting off the entity.

“Alexei, you have survival food and water in here, right?”

“Not exactly water. It is a vitamin drink. Yes, I understand what you are saying.”

Alexei opened up a box and handed out chocolate bars and plastic pouches of vitamin water. He gave Grant an extra granola bar.

“Please eat right away, Mr. Nuby. Do not allow your defenses to weaken. If Francis breaks into your mind, he will know our plans.”

Grant sat silently, but Natasha knew that he could tell what they were thinking.

“Don’t be afraid!” he said resolutely. “I will not fail. Francis Charles will be going to sleep soon. He’ll become tired of his attempts at me.”

“But what if he gets to you while you sleep?” Natasha asked.

“I can’t allow myself to sleep. It’s my burden. If you see me sleep, please wake me up—or kill me,” Grant answered. “Throw me over like Jonah.”

Natasha looked at his tired eyes and cried.

“You would give your life, wouldn’t you?”

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“I will do whatever it takes to help us save the world. It’s my chance at redemption.” He shuddered with effort as he fought another wave of intrusive remote energy. It was as if he had a brief seizure, and then he recovered.

CHAPTER 47

Natasha awoke to the sense that someone was watching her. She looked up at Grant and smiled. This adventure was so radically different from how they normally spent time together. She was used to seeing him as the celebrity he was—dressed like a million bucks, a powerful and charismatic presence. He’s never seen me like this either. She shook her head.

“I know what you’re thinking,” Grant said.

“Well, I know what you’re thinking, too,” she whispered.

“What?”

“You’re thinking that I can’t tell you what you’re thinking.”

“Nice try, Natasha. But not quite.”

“Then what?”

“Natasha, I need to go my own way. I’m not supposed to be here,” he whispered.

Grant looked up into the dark sky. The moon was bright yellow. He rolled his eyes up again as if accessing information.

“It’s not just me that’s not supposed to be here. None of us are. That’s why I feel uneasy.”

“What?” Natasha asked. “What’s wrong?”

“We’re not safe.”

Natasha stood up and looked down. The ground below was dark. She knew they were over land, but that was all she could tell.

“Wake up, everyone! Grant senses danger, and so do I.”

Alexei and Euvgeny opened their eyes.

“Get up!” Natasha said. “Hurry.”

“Alexei, do you know where we are?”

Alexei reached into his pocket and pulled out a handheld GPS monitor.

“We are currently sailing over the farmland of Romania.”

He looked over the side of the balloon to confirm.

“No lights, just farms.”

Euvgeny leaned over the side as well but didn’t say anything.

“Is there anyone here who feels safe right now?” Grant asked.

“Because I’m sensing danger.”

Alexei and Euvgeny looked at each other, then at Grant. They stood quietly as they assessed how they felt.

Grant broke the silence.

“Alexei, what would be your plan of escape if you knew a Black Ops chopper was about to intercept us?”

“It would depend. How much time do we have?”

“Minutes,” Grant answered.

“That would not be enough time to land. We are too high up,” Alexei said. “We have two choices. We can either try to ascend to where the air is too thin to support the helicopter, or the four of us could tandem dive using the two parachutes onboard.”

“He is right, master,” Euvgeny announced. “Radar indicates an aircraft closing in on our position rapidly.”

“Natasha, do you wish to ascend higher or tandem dive?”

“We have seen what a helicopter can do. We will dive.”

Alexei pulled out the parachute.

“Who is first?”

“Hurry!” Euvgeny shouted.

“Grant first,” Natasha volunteered.

“Turn around.”

Alexei secured the parachute onto Grant and then hooked Natasha to his front. The sound of the helicopter grew louder. He handed the radio to Natasha and the GPS to Grant. “When you land, make your way south to the railroad, then head west. I will meet you in Rome.” He placed the ripcord in Natasha’s hand and swung open the gate.

Natasha stepped to the edge and looked down. Her old recurring plane-crash nightmare flickered through her thoughts.

Unbelievably, Natasha and President-Elect William Jaimeson had been experiencing the same horrible nightmare because of a rare psychic

phenomenon known as “Dream-sharing.” In the nightmare, she was the attractive woman in the back of the plane. She remembered screaming, “You are all going to die anyway. The chutes will not open. You are going to fall like little bombs. It is all part of the diabolical scheme of horror?” Horror? Did she mean “terror”? Or did she mean, “It is all part of the diabolical scheme of the WHORE!” The Whore of Babylon—not horror, but WHORE. She remembered how she had envisioned the people falling to their deaths. Their eyeballs shooting out of their sockets, their spines ejecting through the tops of their skulls.

Natasha looked over the edge into the blackness. The wind blew against her face. She was petrified. The sound of the chopper was closing in. Alexei made the sign of the cross over them.

“Count to ten, then pull the cord!” Alexei yelled. He put his foot on Grant’s back and literally kicked them out. Natasha closed her eyes tight and locked every muscle in her body. The wind whipped furiously as they fell through the moonlit sky. The countdown felt like an eternity, and Natasha was terrified they would hit the ground at the count of ten.

Natasha pulled the ripcord. The chute burst open above them. She felt the hard jerk as air filled the canopy, suddenly slowing their fall. Floating through the night sky, they heard the chopper somewhere above. They looked up but saw nothing. Then a bright explosion lit the atmosphere. Natasha and Grant knew their friends had likely just perished. Moments later, the earth rushed toward them. Grant yanked down on his control cord to break the landing sideways.

They unclashed the harness and checked their gear. Natasha still had the gun and the radio. Grant had the GPS. He powered it on, and they looked at the screen. They glanced around—the middle of a field, no landmarks, no lights. They immediately set out at a brisk pace, heading due south.

CHAPTER 48

The GPS device guided them to a small Romanian farming village. They didn't even know the name of the village, just that it had a train station. They arrived at the station exhausted, hungry, and freezing. Natasha immediately went to the large wall radiator heater. There was no food, but at least she could get warm. Grant approached the cashier to buy tickets. A few moments later, he returned.

"We have a problem," he said.

"Let me guess," Natasha answered. "They don't accept American Express."

"Or Visa or MasterCard, or debit, or out-of-state checks."

"So what do we do?"

"The cashier pointed me north and said the word bank."

"We have to hurry because the train we need leaves in forty-five minutes."

Natasha looked up at Grant. "No problem. The bank can't be far. Let's go."

They went outside and looked up the street to see if the bank was immediately visible. It wasn't.

Grant stuck his hand out at passing cars. A car pulled over to the curb, rolled down its window, and the driver asked Grant a question.

"Do you speak English?" Grant asked.

"Where?" the man asked.

"Bank," Grant answered.

"How much?"

"Ten dollars," Grant answered.

The man agreed and urged them into the car.

"My name is Favro," he said.

Grant opened the back door, and Natasha entered. Grant followed her in.

“Nice to meet you,” Natasha said. “We need to go fast. Can you take us to the bank and then back to the train station?”

“No problem!” Favro exclaimed.

Just as they had hoped, an ATM was near the bank entrance. Grant put in the card and withdrew \$500 in local currency from the machine.

Favro raced them back to the train station. They ran to the cashier and bought their tickets. Then they had to run out to the train’s loading platform. They heard an announcement on the loudspeaker and were sure it was the last call.

They ran on a concrete pathway with trains parked on both sides. The smell of burning coal was in the air. The trains were green. They ran up the length of their train and finally reached the entrance cabin. A worker was there to check for their ticket. Natasha showed him her ticket and climbed the metal stairs leading into the train. She led the way for her and Grant. They had purchased a cabin for themselves that could accommodate up to four people.

They entered the train cabin as the train slowly began to depart from the station. They looked out the window and watched the train station and the train on the rail across from them slide out of view. A small table folded out from the wall just below the window. On either side of the table lay the narrow bunk beds.

There was a knock on the door.

“Who’s there?” Grant asked. On the other side of the door, they could hear an old Romanian woman, but the only word Natasha understood was “te.” She jumped up.

“Tea, they offer tea,” she told Grant and opened the door.

The hunchbacked woman held out an empty glass. “te?”

“Si,” Natasha answered before breaking off in Italian. A few minutes later, she returned with a full teapot, sugar cubes, teaspoons, napkins, as well as an uncut loaf of French bread, a stick of kielbasa, and a sharp knife.

Soon, the scene outside the window changed to small snow-covered village cottages, one after another. Grant and Natasha sat across from each other as they drank the tea and ate the bread and kielbasa. The

simple food was extremely rewarding after their many miles of walking in the Romanian countryside in the pre-dawn hours. They had been nearly frozen by the time they made it to the train station. Natasha put her feet up on the bunk and leaned back against the wall next to the window. The rhythm of the tracks underneath was calming. Grant lay on his back, his left arm extended beneath his head for a pillow. His eyes stared up at the bunk above him. Natasha closed her eyes. She could hear the voice of Francis Charles echo in her mind. "Go in peace child, go in peace."

She had only dozed off for a few minutes when she heard a noise at the door. The doorknob was slowly being turned. Natasha shot forward, alarmed. Who was breaking into their room? Natasha looked around, reached down into her jacket, and pulled out her pistol. She silently climbed up to the top bunk so that she would have high ground against the intruder. Grant had accidentally fallen asleep, but Natasha couldn't control that. She held her gun pointed from over the door and switched off the safety with the side of her thumb. The door slowly opened from the opposite side of Natasha's position, and a figure emerged into their room. Natasha recognized the gray hair and musty aroma right away. She let out a sigh of relief when she recognized Alexei.

"You could have knocked," she whispered harshly. "I was about to kill you."

Alexei smiled, seemingly amused.

"Mr. Nuby, you'd better say something before she kills me.

Grant was sitting up on the bunk underneath Natasha. He looked up sideways to see Natasha.

"What are you doing up there?" he asked.

"I was about to save us from an intruder, only it turned out to be Alexei. Here," she said, and held the pistol out to him. "It's yours anyway."

"That is okay, Natasha. I am glad to see you will not let it go to waste. That is why I gave it to you in the first place. May I sit down?"

The scholar, the seer, and the priest talked and planned out their next moves.

CHAPTER 49

Natasha couldn't shake the idea that if Francis Charles used pigeon mail, his messages would have to be encoded with a cipher because of the high probability that one of the pigeons would misdeliver at some point. He wouldn't be able to write anything as plain as, "Dear Mr. Terrorist, This is Vatican Secretary of State Francis Charles." *Please move forward with the deadly event.* No. If he were to use pigeon mail, it would have to be written in code.

Natasha disconnected from the conversation with Alexei and Grant. They were debating American history and playing their hands of obscure French-American Revolutionary War trivia, but Natasha felt compelled to continue on about pigeon mail code. She pulled her phone out of her jacket pocket, curled up on the opposite end of the bunk above Alexei, and began to make notes.

First, she thought that the interchangeability of the letters U and V might be relevant. It was the key to properly decoding the "Vicarius filii dei." She was also able to envision an interesting pattern.

Up until Benjamin Franklin's alphabet reform, the letters U and V were simply the upper and lowercase of the same letter, and the ampersand symbol (&) was the English alphabet's twenty-seventh character. Therefore, if U and V are interchangeable, then logically they would both have the Roman numeral value of five.

Then there is the letter W. Literally two V's next to each other. Its numeric equivalent would be a "double five."

So if one writes the letters down in alphabetical order, she typed them on her cell phone note-taking app. She wrote "S T U V W X Y Z &" and then on the line underneath the U, V, W, she wrote 5, 5, 5, 5.

S	T	U	V	V	V	X	Y	Z	&
		5	5	5	5				

Hmm, that's interesting. All fives, all right in a row. What happens if we build off of that pattern?

Natasha wrote out the alphabet and on the line underneath the alphabet she wrote a pattern of numbers starting with zeroes under A B C and D, then ones under E F G H, then twos under I J K L, then threes under M N O P and continued the pattern until she ended with 6666 resting underneath X Y Z and the ampersand symbol. The numeric pattern fits the alphabet perfectly.

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O	P	Q	R	S	T	U	V	V	V	X	Y	Z	&
0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	2	2	2	2	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	5	5	5	5	6	6	6	6

Natasha looked up and then continued her notes. *Isn't it also interesting that in this particular cipher, the last three letters are assigned the numeric value of 666? Is it just a coincidence? Is this a cipher key?* The cipher key seemed more than her own invention. She felt like it was real. She decided to test it out a little. *How would the word "bomb" be expressed in this cipher?*

B=0, O=3, M=3, B=0

So, according to the cipher key, the word bomb would be written as 0330. So, in order to decode it, one would first have to write a magic square of sorts and then connect the letters as in a word-search puzzle.

Natasha decided to test her theory and wrote 0 3 3 0 horizontally, then, under each number, listed the corresponding letters according to the cipher key. The result was a magic square, 4 characters across and 5 down. Underneath zero she wrote A B C and D. Under three, she wrote M N O P and continued to fill out the pattern.

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0	3	3	0
A	M	M	A
B	N	N	B
C	O	O	C
D	P	P	D

Natasha raised her eyebrows. This box reminded her of the PATERNOSTER box. The exercise seemed similar to the one she had used when she deciphered the magic square and figured out that it hid the double Paternoster. Her heart pounded with excitement. Eureka! She looked down at her notes once again.

0	3	3	0
A	M	M	A
B	N	N	B
C	O	O	C
D	P	P	D

Reading from left to right, was “bomb” the only word? She scanned for other possibilities. AMMA, ANOD, BOPA, COOC, CONA, COMA, BONA, BOND. Actually, the words “COMA” and “BOND” could also be spelled out. Part of the code's actual genius. Almost impossible for a computer to break. A human being would have to figure out the correct meaning by using context.

“The XYZ Affair,” she overheard Grant answer back to Alexei.

Natasha looked down at them. “What did you say?”

Grant looked at Alexei, then back at Natasha. “The XYZ affair, I said. It’s what was happening between the Americans and the French in 1798. Alexei asked me if I knew what was going on in American history at the time that France was overthrowing the Vatican. Of course, it was the XYZ Affair,”

“Natasha,” Alexei said. “You have made some connection, what is it?”

“What if the XYZ Affair didn’t just coincidentally occur during this timeframe? What if it were somehow linked to the overthrow of the Vatican? Look at this,” she answered. She climbed down and turned her phone screen to them.

“I extrapolated a pattern based on the significance of the interchangeability of U and V and its correlation to the Roman numeral V. I discovered a pattern that fit our American alphabet exactly. And when you build the pattern out and apply it to the whole alphabet, the last three letters—X, Y, and Z—have the number six assigned to them. Therefore, the phrase XYZ Affair, according to this cipher, could be translated as the 666 Affair.”

“XYZ is code for 666,” Alexei said. “Not an insignificant thing when you consider many at the time saw the overthrow of the Vatican as a partial fulfillment of the Beast/666 prophecy of Revelation Chapter 13. I failed to mention it before, but there was actually dancing in the streets of Paris at the news of Pope Pius’ arrest. The crowds came out in the bitter February cold and burned—” Alexei searched for the right word. “I forgot how you say. They burned representations of the man—in celebration of his capture.”

“Effigies. Very interesting,” Grant said. “Have either of you ever heard of the Society of Cincinnati?”

Natasha and Alexei shook their heads no.

“Most people haven’t. It’s one of the most powerful and secret of all societies—the most exclusive, too. Membership can only be passed down from father to firstborn son. That’s it. You can’t buy your way in or earn your way in. It’s only from father to firstborn son. George Washington was the society’s first president. Benjamin Franklin was a

member, as were many more of the most powerful and influential Americans, including several other American presidents.”

“But what’s the connection to the XYZ Affair?” Natasha asked.

“I was just about to get to that,” Grant answered. “Also among the members were all three diplomats who were the principals in the so-called XYZ Affair.”

Grant squinted his eyes as he accessed old files of information in his mind. “Charles Cotesworth Pinckney, John Marshall, and Elbridge Gerry—all three were members of the society.”

CHAPTER 50

The train began to slow, and a whistle blew as it chugged into a simple station platform. Outside, Natasha could see that there were a few people selling small things. One elderly lady sat at a vegetable stand. A man with a brown hat and a beard tended meat behind a small barbecue. A few people unloaded, and a few people climbed aboard. A plume of smoke puffed out of the train, and it jerked forward as it started down the tracks.

Grant continued, “It seems like I remember reading a speech in which John Adams warned of how society might be dangerous for the young Republic, as it could be too influential as to be able to sway presidential elections whichever way it seemed fit. The fear was that such an influential society could undermine the Republic.”

“Do you know why it was named the Society of the Cincinnati?” Grant asked.

They didn’t answer. As a former history teacher, Grant was clearly in his element and happy to show off his knowledge of obscure trivia.

“During a time of great distress, the Roman senate sought to appoint a man who would lead Rome through the crisis, but relinquish power afterward. They found such a man. Cincinnatus took power, led Rome through the crisis, and then relinquished his power to return to his farm and family. His willingness to relinquish power was thought to be ideal, and the sentiment was echoed in the presidency of George Washington.”

“The reluctant ruler—so to speak,” Alexei added.

“Yes,” Grant continued. “The society named itself after this noble idea of willingness to relinquish power for the good of the people. However, when you think about it, there is actually another side to the story. There is the man who relinquished power, Cincinnatus, but there is also the elite group that bestowed the power upon him in the first place.

“A society of kingmakers. They can bring a man to power—and they can take him out of power,” Alexie interjected.

Grant nodded his head. “Kingmakers—the puppet masters. Revelation speaks of the rise to power of a one-world dictator, so the idea does not seem unrelated. And if the Society of the Cincinnati had some connection with the overthrow of the Vatican in 1798, that also would not surprise me. And it means the XYZ Affair might well be called the 666 Affair.

Alexie concluded, “If this theory is correct, the Americans and the French conspired to overthrow the Vatican in fulfillment of the 666 Prophecy.”

CHAPTER 51

At Rome's Central Station, Alexei hung up the telephone. He stood inside a small red telephone booth, looking out the door at Natasha and Grant.

"The commander of the Swiss Guard is a man named Karl Wiley. I am going to call him right now."

"Alexei, be very careful what you say," Grant warned. "Don't let them know where we are until you're certain he'll be on our side."

Alexei nodded his agreement. "Yes, if Francis learns of it, he is powerful enough to do whatever it takes to eliminate a threat against him. For his own good—and ours—he mustn't know who we are quite yet."

"Grant is right, Alexei," Natasha added. "I have an idea. Alexei, you make the call. Tell the switchboard operator that you have an emergency message for Commander Wiley. When he connects you, ask him if he would like to know the meaning of the pigeon mail. That should get his attention."

While they planned the call, Alexei took a series of deep breaths.

"No! Wait!" Natasha exclaimed.

Alexei was startled and put down the receiver. Natasha always trusted her instincts. "We lose too much control over the telephone. It's better for us to make this an e-mail conversation."

"You are right," Alexei agreed. "We will be able to craft our words more carefully, react better to his responses, and be more in control."

"But how can we make sure to e-mail him without one of his underlings screening it first?"

"Yes. We need a way to get in front of his eyes only," Grant agreed.

"That gives me an idea," Natasha said as she remembered what a friend in the State Department had taught her. "We need a safe place to connect to the Internet."

"No, we don't. We can just use your phone," Grant suggested.

“Right, but we need to go someplace where we can be comfortable—and possibly wait a number of hours to make this work. After all, there’s no guarantee of when he will be in front of his computer.”

Natasha looked down at her phone, and her face lit up. She had an idea that enhanced their plan.

“Let’s just get somewhere safe and comfortable.”

Natasha looked at Grant and Alexei to see if they had any suggestions.

“I think we need to stay off the grid for now,” Natasha said.

“I have an old girlfriend here in Rome,” Alexei answered. “I will tell her we need a place off the grid. She can rent it for us.”

“No,” Grant said. “I think it’s dangerous to contact anyone we know in Rome.”

“He’s right,” Natasha chimed in. “Francis is powerful enough to get Tom framed, send helicopters after us, and have a mercenary army to attack your monastery. Plus, he’s got this remote viewing power. Staying off the grid means staying away from anyone else we know.”

“Wait here.” Alexei left them and walked up to the ticket counter. He had a conversation with the lady behind the counter and then returned.

“The train to Rimini has excellent cell phone coverage. It leaves in thirty minutes. We can get a cabin.”

Natasha remembered her journey from Rome to Rimini, but was able to shake it off. “That’s a good idea,” Natasha agreed. Once aboard the new train, Natasha sat down and went to work on her computer phone right away. Grant and Alexei peered over her shoulders. She explained what she was doing. “I’m setting the advanced search filter in the search engine to allow e-mails.” She clicked the drop-down menu and then typed “Karl Wiley” in the search box. Thousands of possibilities showed up. She went back to the advance search criteria and added the words “Vatican” and “Swiss Guard.”

The narrowing of the search worked. She began to open the e-mails, right clicking on them, scrolling to the properties, and scanning for the IP address. “This is his home computer, this is his office computer. And

this one is the IP address for his Eurofone account. We can interface directly with his cell phone.”

“Fantastic!” Grant praised her.

“Impressive,” Alexei agreed.

“We are now looking at the screen of his cell phone,” Natasha announced. She double-clicked on the instant messaging software. She typed: Pigeon mail messages are the work of a powerful Vatican imposter. Assassination attempt imminent. Tell no one. Have you broken the code? Please respond. Natasha sent the message.

“That is good,” Alexei said, looking over her shoulder.

CHAPTER 52

Commander Karl Wiley looked down at his cell phone. He reached for the table for his bottle of mineral water and took a drink as he opened his phone mail. What appeared on his screen was the Christmas present that he had hoped for. Finally, a clue to the cryptic note that had been found on stray Vatican pigeons.

He reached back toward the table to put his water back, but he was so distracted by the message that he missed the table and dropped the bottle on his lap. With a startled jerk, he caught the bottle and put it back firmly on the table. He looked down at his cell phone again and began to type.

Natasha waited and stared at the screen, as if willing her message to reach the commander. Her phone made an electronic chime sound.

The commander's response came back. Who is this?

Natasha responded: "I only want to help and also to stay safe. You can call me Bird Dog for now."

"Bird Dog: Can you decode the messages?"

"Affirmative. I have broken the code."

A minute later, a new e-mail appeared from Karl Wiley. It was a string of digits ranging from zero to six.

532410 3042334 2035046 12444.

Natasha smiled as she began to decode. First, she created a magic square for each set of number groupings, using the cipher key.

ABCD	EFGH	IJKL	MNOP	QRST	UVVV	XYZ&
0000	1111	2222	3333	4444	5555	6666

Working it like a "word find" puzzle, she traced a line along letter combinations that spelled out words, picking up speed as she progressed. She read her conclusion aloud to Grant and Alexei. UNITED NATIONS JANUARY FIRST. They looked at the decoded sentence

very seriously, and the knowledge sank in just a bit deeper that this situation was more real than it had ever been.

Natasha started typing her response, but Alexei put his hand on her shoulder.

5	3	2	4	1	0	3	0	4	2	3	3	4	2	0	3	5	0	4	6	1	2	4	4	4
N	M	I	Q	E	A	M	A	Q	I	M	M	Q	I	A	M	U	A	Q	X	E	I	Q	Q	Q
V	N	J	R	F	B	N	B	R	J	N	N	R	J	B	N	V	B	R	Y	F	J	R	R	R
W	O	K	S	G	C	O	C	S	K	O	O	S	K	C	O	W	C	S	Z	G	K	S	S	S
P	L	T	H	D		P	D	T	L	P	P	T	L	D	P		D	T	&	H	L	T	T	T

“No,” he whispered. “If you tell him the exact translation, they will crack the code without our help. We need to give him as little information as possible.”

Natasha looked back at Grant and Alexei.

She typed, “This message details a where and a when.”

Wiley answered, “How do you wish to proceed?”

“He’s playing it safe,” Alexei remarked. “He knows he needs us and wants to make sure we come along nicely.”

“So how would we like to proceed?” Natasha asked.

Alexei sighed and scratched his chin.

“This is as far as I can go with you here in Rome, Natasha. I cannot enter Vatican City. You two must be my eyes and ears.”

Natasha typed, “At 2100 hours, send a driver to Central Station; he can hold a sign for ‘Bird Dog.’ The vehicle needs to be tinted so no one will be able to see us. There are two of us. The driver should take us directly to your office, but we need to avoid all other people. Just you and your office for now.”

“Agreed,” Wiley replied.

CHAPTER 53

When they arrived at Wiley's office, he motioned them to sit down in front of his desk. Wiley appeared as she imagined. He was a tall, blond Swiss with a hooked nose and a direct stare. Wiley sat behind his desk and took a long, hard look at them. Finally, he spoke.

"So, who is this imposter?"

"Before we tell you, you must promise not to say or do anything about it immediately. Surveillance of this man will be the only way to catch his co-conspirators and to get the proof you will need."

"All right then. Who is it?"

"The individual is a man I have known for many years. It is Francis Charles."

Commander Wiley's reaction seemed odd to Natasha. He didn't seem very surprised. "That seems rather impossible. What evidence do you have of such an allegation?"

"You are the one who has the evidence, actually. Let me see the message," Natasha demanded.

Wiley pulled an enlarged photocopy of the mysterious pigeon-mail-coded message from a file and handed it to Natasha. She studied it for a moment before pronouncing.

"Commander Wiley, as a professional handwriting expert and as someone familiar with the hand of Francis Charles, I can tell you for certain that this is his handwriting."

"Unless I know exactly what this message states, who cares if he wrote it?" Wiley answered. "You said it details where and when. Now it is your turn to trust me. Give me the cipher so that I may verify the details."

Natasha wrote it out for him and then showed him how she decoded the numbers.

Wiley snatched the paper and held it up in the light as if he were a cashier checking for a watermark.

“This is quite serious. Very few people on the planet have any idea that the Holy Father had planned an appearance at the United Nations this week. Francis Charles would be one of them.”

Wiley put his hands together under his chin with the tips of his fingers tapping underneath his jawbone.

“Just the leaking of this information is a most serious crime.”

Wiley picked up the phone.

“Your analysis had better be correct. Send Brandioni to my office right away.”

Wiley looked at them again. “Mr. Brandioni is our handwriting expert.”

“Can he be trusted?” Natasha asked.

“Most definitely.”

“No. Wait!” Grant urged. “We can’t take that chance. It must be an independent analysis.”

Wiley picked up the phone again. “Cancel Brandioni.”

He looked at Natasha and Grant somewhat impatiently.

“What do you suggest?”

“In order for an independent handwriting expert to match the handwriting on this message to the handwriting of Francis Charles, they will need an extensive handwriting sample,” Natasha advised.

Wiley rubbed his eyes. “But you did not need an extensive sample,” He challenged.

“I have an extensive handwriting sample. I’ve received handwritten cards and letters from this man for two decades. His handwriting is very distinctive. It’s what inspired me to study handwriting in the first place.”

“This is a problem,” Wiley responded. “All of his work for the Vatican is, of course, in print.”

“Yes. The most likely place to find an adequate sample would be his personal home office,” Natasha added.

Wiley bowed his head again and then looked back up at Natasha.

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“The problem is twofold. If we detain him and search his home and we don’t find incriminating evidence, there will be nothing more I will be able to do except perhaps tender my resignation. Francis would be able to call off his plans and cover up his trail. Of course, we would miss out on the opportunity to find his co-conspirators. Hmm.”

There was silence for a moment.

“On the other hand, if we could get firm confirmation that the evidence we will need is in fact within his home, we could proceed more confidently.”

Wiley looked down at his desk and placed his hands together in front of his face. He shook his head as if acknowledging that he could not readily identify a solution.

“What if I could get you the evidence?” Natasha suggested. “If I were able to find it, I could photograph it, and that would be proof enough, at least to proceed more seriously.”

Wiley picked up the phone. “Have Mr. Andreason call me on line one immediately.”

“Who’s Andreason?” Natasha asked.

“Mr. Andreason is in charge of security for Francis.”

“But wait. What if your question tips him off and he warns Francis?”

“Don’t worry. Mr. Andreason is trustworthy.”

The phone rang, and Wiley answered.

“Commander. It is Andreason, sir.”

“Andreason, I need you to answer a question for me.”

“Yes, sir. Please.”

“Mr. Andreason. The subject of my question is of the utmost importance. You must not speak to anyone about it. Do you understand?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Good, Mr. Andreason. Please tell me. Does the Cardinal Secretary of State keep any pets?”

“No sir. No pets.”

“Are you certain? No cats or hamsters or birds or fish?”

“Well... now”

“Mr. Andreason!” Wiley urged.

“Yes, sir. Sorry, sir. Yes. His personal assistant Nicholas keeps pet doves. We have seen him perform illusions with them from time to time. He is an amateur magician of sorts.”

“I see. But no other pets then?”

“No, sir.”

“Thank you, Mr. Andreason. That is all. Speak to no one of this question.”

“Yes, sir.”

“That is all, Mr. Andreason.”

Wiley hung up the phone and looked at Natasha.

“How did you take over my cell phone?”

Natasha didn’t answer. She simply smiled.

Wiley continued, “According to Mr. Andreason, Nicholas keeps pet doves in the flat.” Wiley looked down at his desk again and shook his head with disapproval.

“Miss Ashton, there is no evidence here. Certainly not enough to obtain a search warrant. Without a legal search of his home for evidence, anything we would find would be useless. I’m afraid all we can do is to cancel the Holy Father’s visit and restrict the cardinal’s access to the itinerary. Of course, we can also watch him closely.”

Natasha shook her head.

“No,” she said. “He’ll know we’re onto him.”

“Perhaps you underestimate us?” Wiley responded.

“Perhaps you underestimate Francis Charles?”

Natasha had an idea.

“You say that Nicholas is an amateur illusionist who performs with pet doves?”

“Yes,” Wiley affirmed. “It is what Mr. Andreason says.”

“Have his doves been tested for Asian bird flu? After all, bird flu could not only endanger the Secretary of State, but also the Holy Father, since they work so closely together.”

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"I like the way you think, Dr. Ashton. Of course, we have a legitimate reason to inspect and test these birds. We would be derelict in our duties unless we ensure those birds do not carry disease."

Wiley picked up the phone again.

"Mr. Andreason, ask the young man to surrender his birds. You may tell him that we simply need to ensure that the birds are not carrying any diseases. That is all he needs to know. Bring the birds to my office as soon as you have them."

"Yes, sir," Andreason answered. "Do you suspect disease, sir?"

"Just a precaution, Mr. Andreason. Get this done quickly." He hung up the phone. Wiley stood up and looked out his window toward the apartment of Francis Charles. He spoke with his back turned to Natasha.

"When the birds arrive at the office, we will tag them with RF transmitters. It will look as if we are injecting a vaccination into the birds. Then we will release them."

"But what about Nicholas? He'll be expecting his birds to be returned to him," Natasha said.

"We'll have to tell him that the birds are being observed for an undetermined period of time and that they will be returned to him at such a time as we feel they pose no health threat."

"All of which is technically true," Natasha affirmed with a wide smile. "I like the way you think too, Commander."

CHAPTER 54

After the doves were injected with the RF transmitters, they were released from the commander's office window. Wiley sat down at his desk and navigated to a website. He looked up at Natasha and Grant and signaled them to come around to his side of the desk. He pointed to the screen. "This site is how we can track the birds. Wherever they go, we will see it in real time."

Natasha looked at the map and saw the red dots slowly moving out of the city. "Looks like they're headed west," she said. "What will you do when they're out of your jurisdiction?"

"The only thing we can do. We will track them and arrange cooperation with local authorities. Believe me, we can count on the utmost cooperation."

Natasha looked at the screen and then at her wrist, once again forgetting she had no watch. "New Year's is just three days from now. What if the birds have to fly a long distance?"

"Then we will have to wait for them, but we don't have to stay here any longer. We can track the birds from our cell phones." Wiley rapidly typed on his keyboard. "I'm sending your phone the link to this page."

"No, thanks," Natasha said. "We're perfectly happy waiting here in your office."

She gestured at the multiple pieces of furniture around them.

"If we get tired, we can take naps. You have coffee, and we have kielbasa and bread. So, I'm quite ready for the long night of watching these birds."

"Let us just pray they will lead us to the terrorist."

CHAPTER 55

Harstine Island was slowly recovering from the recent string of deaths that had shaken the small, secluded village. The island-folk seemed reassured that the popular President Elect was taking some well-needed rest at his country home on the island. William Jaimeson picked up the phone to call Douglas Blair. His wife, Jessica, answered. They exchanged greetings.

“He said he was headed out to the island to meet with you. He’s not there with you?” she asked.

“Perhaps I’m mistaken, but I don’t recall any such plans. When did he say we were supposed to meet?”

“This morning he told me 2:00 p.m.”

William shot a glance at the clock on his wall; it was 3:40.

“Well, I’m sure there’s an explanation. Please have him give me a call when you have a chance.”

“I’ll do that.”

“Thank you, Jessica.” He hung up the phone and dialed the Blair residence, just a few blocks away. No answer. He got up from his brown leather chair and walked to the living room, where Meredith was curled up on the couch, reading one of her favorite books. A fire was burning in the fireplace, and holiday music played in the background. He approached her, bent down, and kissed her on the lips. “Meredith, dear, I’m taking a walk over to Doug’s place. I shouldn’t be gone too long.”

Meredith rolled her head forward to touch her forehead to his. They looked into each other’s eyes up close; they seemed almost crossed and cockeyed. They both smiled.

“You better not take too long, William. Or I’ll be very disappointed,” she said with a playful smile.

He kissed her again and walked out of the room. He threw on his coat, laced up his boots, and stepped out the front door on his way to Douglas Blair's home.

Doug's Cadillac was parked in the driveway, and the neighbor's fluffy orange cat sat atop the hood. The cat jumped down and padded alongside William up to the front steps. William rang the bell.

He looked behind him; he was still getting used to his Secret Service detail following him everywhere. Agent Franks and Agent Mathews seemed like good men—steady, respectful, and just distant enough that he sometimes forgot they were always there.

He rang the doorbell again, but there was still no answer. The cat looked up at him and let out a meow. William moved along the porch and looked through the window. A fire burned vigorously in Douglas's enormously oversized fireplace. It was built from large stone blocks, and to load it with logs, one almost had to step down into it. The fireplace's opening was about five feet wide and four feet high. It burned long logs that had been split lengthwise into pie-shaped wedges.

William squinted to see anything else, but there was nothing. He turned around.

"Mr. Franks, let's walk around the home and see what we can see, shall we? Douglas is supposed to be here, but he's not answering the doorbell or the phone. His car is parked out front, and the engine is still warm."

"Sir, would you like us to place a man here at the Douglas residence?"

"Yes. That's a good idea," William said.

Agent Franks spoke into the small microphone in his hand.

"All right, sir. Let's go ahead and see if he's around back."

The ground was still covered with snow, but William didn't see any tracks. Behind the home, a set of prints led from the back porch to the woodshed. But there was still no sign of Douglas. Suddenly, the holiday lights lit up all around the house, making it feel as though Douglas had switched them on from inside. William looked at the darkening sky and then at his watch, which read 4:15 p.m. The timer had turned the lights on.

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He turned to the Secret Service agent.

“One of you stays here. The rest of us will head back home for now. Let me know the moment you make contact with Mr. Blair.”

William began the short walk back to his own home. He played with the large gold ring on his right ring finger. It had grown loose recently, and he had gotten into the habit of sliding it back and forth between his knuckles. The ring had been passed down from his father. An American bald eagle was artfully embossed on it, and around the eagle, the Latin phrase *Societas Cincinnatus*.

CHAPTER 56

At the Vatican, Commander Wiley's radio sounded an alert. "CSOS1 is on the move. CSOS1 is en route to base camp. Over. CSOS1 en route to base camp. Over."

Wiley picked up his radio. "10-4. Over."

"What's going on?" Natasha asked.

"The Cardinal S.O.S. is on his way," Wiley replied.

Natasha looked nervous and surprised.

"Do you think...?"

"Don't worry," Wiley answered. "If he was using these birds to send these treasonous messages, he'll be quite disturbed that we have taken them from his home."

Francis Charles reached the door to Wiley's office. The Swiss Guard stood at the entrance. He looked at the guard as if to dare him. "Try to stop me from opening this door. Who do you think you are?"

The guard stepped back; Francis flung open the door and barged into Wiley's office. He immediately saw Natasha and sneered. "You! I should have known, Commander Wiley."

He snapped his attention to Wiley. "This woman is utterly insane."

He turned to face Natasha and pointed his finger in her face. "I've had enough of your games. Karl, I demand to know what is going on right this instant. What are your men doing taking my doves and what is this spy doing in your office?"

"Your doves?" Karl put his hand out sideways to shield Natasha. With his other hand, he reached under the edge of his desk and pressed the lockdown button.

"I understood the doves belong to Nicholas," Wiley challenged.

Francis stood silent and looked at Wiley with a piercing glare.

"It's convenient you have come here, Cardinal Charles. Please have a seat. There is a matter we need to clear up. Cardinal Charles, two months

ago, a dove—in fact very similar to the ones we took from your home this evening—flew into the Holy Father’s window. It apparently made a very loud noise. Upon coming to investigate, the Holy Father discovered the bird to be dead. The Holy Father cupped the delicate dove in his hands and bowed his head in prayer. His staff and guests circled around to watch. He lifted his head, slowly opened his hands, and the bird was miraculously alive. Everyone was stunned. Witnesses reported they could feel the energy radiating. The guard who told me his account gets chills every time he tells the story.”

Francis interrupted, “Yes. The Holy Father told me the story himself.”

“Not all of it, I’m sure,” said Wiley. Wiley opened his desk drawer. “The observant guard noticed a pill-sized capsule attached to the leg of the dove and called attention to it. We removed the capsule, and inside we found a coded message.”

Wiley looked around the room. “We ran the message through cryptology, and we even asked the FBI for help with it. No one could break the code. But tonight, Natasha Ashton caught my attention when she deciphered the encrypted message.” He pulled the sheet of paper out and slapped it on the desk forcefully. “She unlocked the code. You see.” He pointed to the letterboxes Natasha had written out on another piece of paper. “The decoded message reads: ‘United Nations January First.’” Wiley looked at Francis’s eyes to see his reaction.

Francis squirmed in his chair. “Commander, I’ve suddenly become very bored of your story. We’ll talk more about this tomorrow.” Francis walked to the door, but Wiley signaled his guard to block the exit. “I wasn’t finished yet, Cardinal Charles. You haven’t heard the best part of the story.”

Francis Charles turned around. Natasha was staring at him with satisfaction as Wiley delivered his next line. “We know that it was you who wrote the secret message.”

“That’s preposterous! I suppose it escaped you that the birds belong to my manservant Nicholas, who also has access to my handwriting. He’s obviously the one you need to speak to regarding this issue. Very sloppy, Mr. Wiley. Let me guess. Natasha the psychic-investigating-paleographer

is your handwriting expert. She won't testify in trials anymore because as soon as the jury finds out she thinks she can talk to dead people, she loses all credibility. She's famous—or infamous, I should say. Her irresponsible testimony led to the acquittal of one of America's worst killers, Gilbert Carver. You two are the ones who will need attorneys."

Francis turned to go. He waved at the guard dismissively to move aside. "Have Nicholas arrested immediately. If you had any brain at all, you would know this is his doing."

Once again, Wiley shook his head at the guard. "Don't open that door," he commanded.

Francis turned around again, but Wiley stood confidently.

"We obviously knew the dove had been trained as a mail pigeon—and we were interested to see where it would lead us if we let it free. So we injected it with an RFID and tracked its flight. Do you know where it ended up?"

Francis didn't answer.

Wiley continued, "This dove ended up in London and stayed put on the most interesting street. Do you know what street the dove lives on even to this day? No? The dove lives on Paternoster—one of the oldest streets in London. Isn't that interesting? We released the other four doves that were taken from your home. They're headed on a course to England. The English authorities will raid whatever apartment the birds land at. Of course, when all four end up at the same location, it will eliminate coincidence. And what will they find in this Paternoster apartment? We believe it will be your coconspirator. We'll probably find pigeons there, too, that will, when released, fly to your apartment. And we'll probably find evidence of a terrorist plot to strike the United Nations building on January First." Wiley continued, "Until the birds arrive at Paternoster, I feel very comfortable placing you under arrest on charges of conspiracy to commit terrorism and conspiracy to commit murder. And I feel very confident in Dr. Ashton's abilities. I feel very confident letting her into your apartment with my men and a search warrant. She will be able to find a handwriting sample that will do the job."

Natasha stepped forward and glared directly into Francis's eyes. "Checkmate!" she told him with satisfaction.

The Swiss Guard chained Francis Charles's hands.

Wiley shouted, "Take him to prison!" The Swiss Guard led Francis Charles out in handcuffs.

"You're making a mistake. It's Nicholas. Not me. I'm the Secretary of State of Vatican City. Of course, your accusations are misplaced—"

Wiley turned to Natasha. "We better get you over to his apartment right away." He picked up his radio. "Bring Nicholas to my office right away. We must investigate if he has any role in this."

Natasha stepped forward and glared directly into the eyes of Francis. "Checkmate!" She told him with satisfaction.

The Swiss Guard chained the hands of Francis Charles.

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"You're making a mistake. It's Nicholas. Not me. I'm the Secretary of State of Vatican City. Of course, your accusations are misplaced—"

Wiley turned to Natasha. "We'd better get you over to his apartment right away." He picked up his radio. "Bring Nicholas to my office right away. We must investigate if he has any role in this."

CHAPTER 57

Captain Andreason escorted Natasha back to the palace apartment of Francis Charles. As they walked down the hall to his private library and study, Andreason waved the search warrant up near Natasha. “We have a search warrant,” he reminded. “So take all the time you need to find what you’re looking for. My men, of course, will also be looking.”

“Thank you, Captain. It may not be easy to find an adequate writing sample. I guess I’m hoping to find a handwritten journal or perhaps speeches he may have written by hand before typing. Or perhaps articles or essays he may have handwritten.”

As Natasha stepped into the apartment, she shuddered, recalling how Francis had assaulted her. Her eyes landed upon a large painting hung on the wall near the library entrance. The painting depicted an eighteenth-century nobleman writing at a desk. The man held a feather pen in his left hand and looked as if he were about to dip it into the ink jar. The parchment was nearly filled with unreadable script. The man’s face seemed familiar to Natasha. His cheeks were full, and his forehead was prominent. He wore small, round spectacles and was dressed in the fashion of late eighteenth-century France. Suddenly, Natasha realized that the man in the painting reminded her of Francis Charles himself. “Captain Andreason, who is the man in the painting?” she asked as they entered the library.

“I believe that is a painting of Giovanni Angelo Braschi,” he answered thoughtfully.

“That name sounds familiar.”

“He’s better known as Pope Pius the VI. The painting depicts him practicing law before his ascendance to papal power.”

“You mean he didn’t make his way up through the priesthood?”

“No. He practiced law up until just three years before he was elected pope.”

Natasha registered the information, noting to herself that it was Pius VI who had been dethroned by Napoleon’s army in 1798.

Snapping back to the task at hand, she opened the drawers in his desk and riffled through his papers. “Keep your eyes out for anything that looks like it might be his handwriting—and of course anything that looks like those pigeon messages.”

Captain Andreason looked at Natasha from around a bookcase corner. “Perhaps we will find what you are looking for where this stairway leads.”

Natasha walked over to Andreason. It was a secret staircase hidden behind a false wall panel. It was steep and narrow, and there was no light. Andreason pulled out a Zippo lighter and lit the staircase with the lighter’s single flame.

“There’s a combo lock on the door.”

“Let me see,” Natasha said. She maneuvered past Andreason and looked at the lock. It was similar to a briefcase lock. It had four wheels, each of which rotated to display the numbers 0 through 9. Natasha looked at it for a minute. He thought no one else would ever figure out the key to his code. Wasn’t he just wrong?

She pictured the cipher she had figured. *Underneath the UVW were the four fives*. Natasha rolled each wheel to display the number five and pushed the door lever. She felt the spring action of the mechanism opening. The door swung open. Inside was the secret lair of one of the world’s wealthiest and most powerful immortals. The man currently known as Cardinal Secretary of State, Francis Charles.

The circular room displayed treasured rare artifacts. Natasha noticed an ancient papal tiara among them. In the center of the room, Natasha noticed the island, which showcased the special playing board with hand-carved pieces. None of the pieces was carved precisely enough for Natasha to recognize any one person. She did not even recognize herself as the empress, but that didn’t matter to Francis—he knew who the pieces represented.

"Take a look at this game board." Natasha ran her fingers along the longitudinal lines and handled one of the wooden pieces, which was definitely a Swiss Guard. "It's not quite chess, but it looks similar."

Andreason walked over and picked up one of the pieces. It was a modern man in a suit and a long dress coat. The man had his right hand raised in the position of taking an oath. "I think he carves these pieces himself," Andreason stated.

Natasha walked along the display shelf that ringed the room. It was also a display countertop. She came across a leather document case. "This is interesting," she said. She unwrapped the leather strap and opened the leather cover to reveal a stack of extremely antique papers. The collection of writings was in Italian, French, and English, but all by the same hand. She scanned through. These are the personal correspondence of Giovanni Angelo Braschi. She continued to flip through the pages carefully.

"Miss Natasha, come look at this," Andreason called.

Natasha suspended her study of the ancient letters and joined Andreason.

"See how he's got this magnifying glass mounted to this hobby desk. It would be just right for writing those small messages."

Natasha agreed, but she was more interested in the antique papers. Natasha returned to Braschi's writings. His writing style seemed related to Francis. Certain letters matched almost perfectly. For example, the way Francis crossed his "F". There was a unique squiggle. In addition, they both used the same squiggle to cross their lowercase "T".

Andreason walked up behind Natasha and looked over her arm at the papers. "Angelo Braschi again. Interesting. You know, he kept doves too?"

"What?" Natasha asked.

"Pius the Sixth kept doves too," Andreason answered. "He is said to have tenderly released one just before Berthier's soldiers broke into his apartment and placed him under arrest."

"What happened to him after he was arrested?"

"That's an interesting question, Miss Natasha. Braschi was said to have died in prison after only eighteen months. But the French somehow

misplaced his corpse, which was never recovered, and his funeral was postponed for three years.”

How could they have misplaced the corpse of the pope? Natasha reflected. She sensed something significant surrounding the circumstances of Pope Pius VI’s death and the subsequent misplacement of his corpse. Her mind raced. She pictured the painting of Braschi and the similarities to Francis Charles. The prominent forehead and the intelligent, dark eyes. She focused on the stack of Braschi’s letters. “Look at this,” she said. “Braschi was writing to Benjamin Franklin regarding alphabet reform.” She flipped through more papers and found a letter with a broken wax seal. It had an eagle embossed on it.

Natasha’s mind was racing, trying to make connections.

The aftermath of the so-called XYZ Affair lasted about three to four years. Braschi’s body had been missing for about three years. Natasha’s mind made the connection just as she had found the PATERNOSTER pattern on the wall art in Francis’ office. Just as she had figured out the significance of the palindromes. And just as she had made the connection regarding the interchangeability of “U” and “V” being the key to a special apocalyptic cipher. Her synapses fired, and her eyes grew wide. *Eureka!* She went into vision—just as she had when she had seen the acts of Lucas Phillip Reynard. In her mind’s eye, she saw Braschi releasing his doves. The dove carrying secret instructions for his escape from the French prisons and a promise of an amazing treasure for men who would secure his release.

Of course, Braschi’s body went missing. Because there was no body. He had faked his own death, relocated to America, and assumed a new life in the new world. Braschi and the XYZ affair are the missing link to how the immortal Rebel of Korah eventually became the American Francis Charles. Natasha snapped out of her vision. She turned to Andreason. “He’s got an escape plan. He’s already ahead of us.”

She stopped. Andreason was holding his pistol aimed straight at her at point-blank range. Natasha shot a glance back at the game board, confirming that one of the pieces was, in fact, a Swiss Guard. That would be Andreason. She knew why he was pointing the pistol at her. It wasn’t

because she was under arrest for a crime that she did not commit. No. His intention was to make her an illegal prisoner.

Natasha quickly surveyed the room. "Mr. Andreason? What's the gun for?"

She held the leather document case in her hand. A leather strap and buckle were attached to secure it. Natasha grasped the end of the strap and swung the document case instantly, wrapping it around Andreason's wrist as if she were an expert with a bullwhip. The documents of Giovanni Angelo Braschi flew out in every direction and swirled around the room like flakes in a snow globe. Natasha yanked hard as soon as the strap had spiraled around his wrist and stripped the gun from his hand. With the strap wrapped tightly around his wrist, she pulled down on the leather and cinched it tighter, simultaneously using her right hand to bend his wrist backward. She forced Andreason to his knees, twisted his arm behind his back, pulled back his other arm, and tied his two wrists behind him.

Natasha retrieved Andreason's pistol and came back. Slowly, while aiming the gun at him, she reached out and caught hold of the top of his radio antenna. She pulled it off from its belt clip and repositioned it in her hand so she could depress the talk button. She composed herself and spoke into the radio. "Bird Dog to Base Camp. Over." She waited for a response.

"This is Base Camp. Go ahead, Bird Dog." Wiley's voice sounded a bit surprised to hear from Natasha over the radio.

"Red alert. Red alert. CSOS1 to attempt escape imminently. Reinforce security around him immediately."

Natasha ran down the stairs as fast as she could. On the last stair, she tripped and fell through the secret panel door in Francis' library. The library was dark; no one was there. She picked herself up and ran out of the apartment. Once on the street, she ran as fast as she could to Wiley's office. As she ran, she attempted to maintain contact with Wiley to confirm that he was acting swiftly regarding her alert. After his first response, he did not answer any more of her radio calls. "Bird Dog to Base Camp. Bird Dog to Base Camp. Over," she panted.

Natasha began to panic. Grant Nuby was with Wiley. *What if Francis broke through and took him over? What if he killed Wiley? Why isn't he answering?* Natasha's mind raced. Wiley was her ally, the only one she could trust after the incident with Andreason. What if he were dead now and Francis Charles back in power—ready to squash his adversaries like insects? *Get out of here. Just get the heck out of here.* She told herself. *Turn around and go back out of these city walls.* But she couldn't stop.

She yelled into the radio again. "Bird Dog to Base Camp! Over!" *Forget him! Get out of here while you still can.* In her mind's eye, she imagined Grant Nuby turning into a werewolf and chasing her down through Saint Peter's Square. The alarms in her mind were relentless. She found herself acknowledging how powerful the thought was, but her reasoning overpowered her fear. If she ran now, when would she ever stop running? Somehow, she pulled strength from somewhere deep inside. She was already running fast, but she broke free to a whole new level of speed—an Olympic sprinter summoning her last power to shoot ahead and cross the line first.

CHAPTER 58

Grant Nuby sat in the background, listening as Wiley interviewed Nicholas. Wiley was pushing him hard to reveal what he knew. Nicholas insisted that he knew nothing of any of this. He acknowledged that the birds were his, but he didn't know anything about their capabilities to deliver mail. Wiley called for Nicholas to be taken to a holding facility for further debriefing.

"I sense he is telling the truth, Commander Wiley," Grant said.

"I agree. He seems innocent for now, but he may have important details."

Just then, Natasha's voice came over the radio, alerting them to Francis' likely escape attempt.

CHAPTER 59

The Swiss Guards escorted Francis Charles straight from Wiley's office. Instead of marching him to Vatican City's criminal holding facility, they marched him to the Vatican helipad, where a large transport helicopter awaited them. Its rotors were already spinning as Francis and his loyal guards climbed aboard.

Wiley looked at the video monitor and saw the guards were off route and heading toward the helipad. He raised the alarm and sprinted toward it as fast as he could, drawing his pistol as he ran. Then he stopped short. Natasha caught up to him as he stood there, frozen.

Wheezing and out of breath, she yelled in exasperation, "What are you waiting for? You're just going to stand there and let him escape?"

"The helicopter is armed with missiles. If Francis still wants to assassinate the Holy Father, he certainly has the means to do so."

He called into his radio to abort the pursuit, but the radios were jammed. The helicopter lifted off and immediately flew out of Vatican airspace to an unknown destination. It was a clean, almost effortless escape for Francis Charles.

Wiley and Natasha ran back to his office. He immediately dialed his liaison at Scotland Yard, urging him to raid the flat on Paternoster Street before Francis could tip them off.

Wiley hung up the phone and turned to Natasha and Grant. "We are in your debt already. You have undoubtedly helped us thwart Charles's plan against the Holy Father. And I can promise you this. I believe your husband is innocent, and you have my word that I will do everything possible to secure his release—even if it takes a phone call from the Holy Father himself. There is just one more thing I must ask of you."

"What?" Natasha asked.

"I need you to be my eyes and ears in England and to make yourself available to Scotland Yard if they need you. They've agreed to your

presence at the Paternoster site. The jet is waiting for you now. Miss Natasha, Mr. Nuby—will you go?”

“We’re on our way!” Natasha said solemnly.

She took a rubber band off Wiley’s desk, gathered her hair, and snapped it into a ponytail. She pulled her bag off the floor and slung it over her shoulder.

“Absolutely!” Grant agreed.

He extended his hand to Wiley in a firm handshake. Wiley nodded at them.

“Then go. And Godspeed.”

Natasha and Grant ran out of Wiley’s office and down to the waiting helicopter. As Natasha boarded and sat down, it occurred to her that she hadn’t slept since those few short hours in the balloon. Once again, her only chance to sleep would be high up in the clouds.. Just before she passed out, she thought, *this is definitely a red eye.*

CHAPTER 60

In London, Inspector Ivor Patterson met Natasha and Grant at the Paternoster apartment. He was a pudgy, freckled man, dressed in a crisply ironed Scotland Yard uniform. “We missed him. I’m sorry to say,” he told them as he introduced himself and shook their hands. “But we found loads of those coded messages—and the birds, too. The birds have been RF-tagged and released. We’re monitoring closely, but unfortunately the messages have been shredded. We’re scanning the shreds right now; our program is designed to find English word combinations, using algorithms and microanalysis to assemble the pieces of the puzzle. The problem is that not only are the messages shredded, they’re also undecipherable strings of numbers. We will need every tool in our toolbox—and I’m not shy to reach out for help. Commander Wiley told me that you can read the code quite fast. So, if you’re ready to go to work, I have a table set up for you.”

“Microanalysis?” Grant asked.

“Yes. It’s rather like ballistics—only on paper shredding. Each blade in the shredder is unique at the micro level.”

Natasha understood immediately. It would be like matching two pieces of paper that had been cut in half with a pair of wavy-bladed scrapbooking scissors. Some scissors have sharp, angled waves; others have round, lazy waves.

“I get it—so I’m the shortcut at the end.”

“At least until we can write a program to read the cipher. But I don’t even know if that’s possible with the unique aspects of this particular code. Wiley said you’re a genius. So yes. You are the shortcut.”

Natasha sat down at the desk. “Grant, you can help with this, too.”

“No. I already know where this is taking us—and I think you do, too. Good-bye, Natasha,” he said softly and hugged her.

Grant exited the apartment, went out onto the street, and took a taxi back to the airport. Natasha looked back down at her work. The computer had reassembled three of the messages so far; Natasha began decoding them right away.

The first message was: "I would love a dove. Send twenty to Rome's farmer's market."

The second message was: "Pocket change."

The third one was: "What else do you need?"

Ivor walked over and looked over Natasha's shoulder. "That was fast, Natasha. Looks like you decipher them faster than we can get them to you." He handed her four more pages.

Natasha looked up at him. "How many of the messages do you have?"

"We estimate we may be able to restore as many as forty," Ivor answered.

Natasha picked up the one she was working on and waved it. "I can tell you right now that Francis Charles didn't write this one. Let me show you something."

She showed him the second message.

CHAPTER 61

Brian Jones walked into Heathrow International and checked his luggage. As the American prepared to walk through the metal detectors, he emptied his loose change, keys, and cell phone into a tray. On the other side of the detector, he retrieved his items from the tray.

Five other American businessmen checked luggage and passed through the security screening on their way to board the same flight as Brian Jones—AeroEuro Flight 900 to Rome. None of the security screeners noticed that the six businessmen were wearing professional makeup and wigs. None of the security screeners noticed that the loose change these men emptied from their pockets as they passed through the metal detectors didn't produce a normal tone.

Brian Jones, Keith Thompson, John Sanders, John Colgate, Jackson Hobbs, and Randal Fauntleroy. The six men boarded without the slightest hint of a suspicious eye. Except for one man, one man felt something was wrong. His logic told him he was crazy, but his intuition told him otherwise. Flight 900 departed Heathrow on time.

CHAPTER 62

Natasha looked up at Inspector Patterson. “Do you see how he writes his numbers so precisely? Just like a professional font. See. Now look at this one.” Natasha showed him the “pocket change” message. “This handwriting is messy in comparison. Tell whoever is sorting to prioritize shreds with perfect penmanship.”

“Excellent, Natasha.” Patterson praised.

Natasha continued to decode. She found an important one. It read: “If notified, target Vatican instead.”

She shouted, “Inspector, we’re looking for an international flight from either London or Paris to Rome—Cross-reference with the name Ahmad Ahmid. The target has been changed. Their Plan B is to strike the Vatican.”

“Exceptional, Miss Ashton.” The inspector immediately flipped his phone open and called Wiley.

“One other thing, Inspector. Use dogs at the gates to detect plastic explosive, which I believe will be hidden in false coins.”

“Exceptional, Miss Ashton. Right away!”

Ivor dialed again and gave his team full instructions.

“Please, Miss Ashton, continue. We need to know what is written on every scrap of paper.” Another inspector walked up to Ivor and whispered in his ear. Natasha went back to work.

CHAPTER 63

Grant Nuby stood up after takeoff and walked to the lavatory. As he did so, he looked for the others that he knew must certainly be on the plane.

Over the years, he had experimented with his condition. Even though he lost control while he was possessed, he found that if he focused on certain tasks just before his mind was taken over, the demon somehow had to perform those tasks before it could go on to its own agenda.

The way Grant understood it was that, at first, the demon was still trying to fit into its new brain and, until the takeover was complete, the brain more or less went on autopilot. Many times, Grant had awoken from an episode of his demonic possession only to find that he had accomplished impossible tasks that he could not remember.

But that's a last resort, he told himself. He made his way to the cockpit and approached the stewardess. He was sure that if he notified the captain, they would take measures to land the plane immediately.

It was too late. Amid Ahmad, a.k.a. Brian Jones, exited the lavatory and began taking over the airplane. Grant was frail and no match for these trained warriors, but he knew the fate of this plane if he did nothing. He tuned out the words of Amid Ahmad and focused on the other members of his team. He visualized what he would do to each of the terrorists if there were no limits, and then he let the demon take over.

With the speed of a Tasmanian devil, Grant lunged across the plane to where Amid Ahmad had just stuck the plastic explosive to the window. A booming voice reverberated from the demon-possessed Nuby, shouting, "Go to hell!"

Grant snatched the explosive from the window, grabbed the astonished Amid Ahmad in a bear hug as tight as a boa constrictor, and pressed the detonation button. It was a small, muffled explosion. A fine

mist of red blood sprayed in all directions. Amid Ahmad's head rolled down the aisle, his eyes still wide open in shocked horror.

Grant fell to the floor. Finally released by his demons he looked up at the faces of some of the people whom he had saved and uttered a single word: "Atonement." He closed his eyes and peacefully released his spirit. Flight 900's passengers rose up against the remaining five terrorists.

CHAPTER 64

One of the younger investigators ran into the room and interrupted Patterson and the other inspectors.
“Turn on the news,” he yelled.

He ran over to the television and turned it on. Natasha stopped decoding and watched the television news coverage. The headline banner at the bottom of the screen read: The renowned psychic medium Grant Nuby sacrifices his own life to thwart a terror attack.

At first, Natasha was stunned. The room roared with a victorious cheer. She smiled and, overwhelmed, burst into tears. Ivor Patterson offered his hand to help her out of her chair and hugged her.

Natasha’s cell phone rang. It was Wiley.

“I’m sorry for your loss, Natasha. I know he was your friend.”

She tried to smile, but burst into tears again. “He was. He was. But I know that, more than anything, he would have wanted to go out like that. I think he found peace.”

“Natasha, something else has happened, and I need you back here right away.”

Natasha could tell from his tone that the matter was serious and urgent. “What is it?”

“I’ll tell you when you arrive here in Vatican City. Please hurry to the jet—time is critical.”

“All right. The Vatican requires my assistance on another matter.”

CHAPTER 65

The Swiss Guardsman escorted Natasha to where Karl Wiley stood working in the middle of Francis Charles' home office. The apartment was full of guards poring through papers and examining every small detail.

Wiley looked up from the document that he and a guardsman were reading.

"Natasha! There's no time to waste. The Holy Father was abducted and his life is in danger."

Natasha was totally shocked. She had expected that the urgent matter had something to do with Francis Charles, but she hadn't expected this.

"I know you have a gift, Natasha. Please, now more than ever, we need it."

Natasha put her hands over her face and stretched them back across her temples. She looked around the office and combed her fingers through her hair. Her eyes came back to Wiley. "Grant, Alexei, and I theorized that Father Elijah had discovered powerful secrets within the pages of the Bible, which, if revealed, would interfere with Francis' scheme to achieve his aspirations of global dictatorship."

Natasha breathed deeply and continued to look around the room. She bit the tip of her finger. "But now with his plans completely blown and his true identity known, what motive would he have to abduct the Holy Father?"

"He is a very logical sort," Wiley said. "We also asked the same question. He must have a reason."

Natasha nodded.

"Why else would he make himself the target of such an intense manhunt?"

She turned in the direction of the narrow staircase. "I need to look around his secret room." She climbed up the narrow, dark staircase, and Wiley followed her.

"That was impressive work you did on Mr. Andreason," Wiley remarked as they entered the circular room. "We found him tied up and comatose on the floor." Wiley smiled and looked at her.

Natasha stepped across the room to the display shelf and picked up the papal tiara. "If Father Elijah was endeavoring to authenticate the Vicarious Filii Dei theory, the holy grail of that quest would be to find a tiara with that title inscribed on it. I researched the subject a little. A quest to find such a tiara would be fruitless, since the whereabouts of only a few of the tiaras are known. Only five have survived, and none of them bear an inscription. One of the tiaras that survived is the one Napoleon bestowed on the successor to Pius VI. Napoleon supposedly had an inscription engraved on that tiara, but whatever it said was considered offensive and removed. But I was thinking ..."

Natasha turned to Wiley. "It turns out that from the middle of the Dark Ages, every pope in history possessed many tiaras. They were a traditional gift from royalty, so there should actually be hundreds of these tiaras. None of the tiaras survived the fall of the Vatican in 1798."

"Where did they all go?" Wiley asked.

"That's one of the greatest unasked questions in all of history. Where is the missing Vatican treasure of 1798? Hundreds of priceless jewel-encrusted triple crowns, all manner of gold and silver and treasures and relics and secrets.

Elijah was not killed because he was about to reveal his Antichrist theories; he was killed because he stumbled across a path leading to the greatest missing treasure of all time. A path which would also intersect with the ambitions of a powerful immortal, hell-bent on world domination."

She walked along the circular edge of the room, looking at the paintings, artifacts, and books. She noticed a photo of the Holy Father taken at a time before he was elected.

“Wiley, before Andre Saracini became pope, he was perhaps one of the world’s foremost paleographers.” Natasha bit her lip and stared out in thought. Her eyes brightened, and she turned back to Wiley. “That’s why Francis abducted him. That’s why Francis is obsessed with these Latin and Greek palindromes. They contain clues to the whereabouts of another treasure room. A treasure vault that stores not only the lost Vatican treasure of 1798, but also the missing treasures from the temple in Jerusalem. Think about it. In 1797, Pius VI sued France for peace, months before the invasion. Plenty of time to have the treasure moved. Moved and consolidated.”

“Dear God!” Wiley exclaimed in a low whisper.

He stared at a painting leaning against the wall depicting the Ark of the Covenant.

“Natasha, you’re talking about the Ark of the Covenant!”

“The Ark of the Covenant and something much more dangerous—The Rod of Aaron.” Natasha pointed to another painting. It depicted Moses with his outstretched arms waving a rod high in the air as he commanded the sea to divide. She pointed to the rod.

“It’s the original magic wand, splintered from Eden’s tree of life and, according to sacred writings, more powerful than you can imagine.”

“How do you mean?” Wiley asked.

“Moses waved it into the air to execute just about every miracle that he performed—from turning Egypt’s water into blood to the parting of the Red Sea.”

Wiley took his eyes off the painting and looked back at Natasha.

“Why would Francis be obsessed with the palindromes?”

“Commander, suppose you compose a clever proverb and wordsmith it in such a way that it is also one of the world’s most sophisticated palindromes—it would pretty much guarantee the preservation of that proverb. Now, if you hide secret clues within the wording of that palindrome, then those secret clues will also survive all down through the ages.”

“So—within the palindrome, a proverb; within the proverb, a clue.”

“Eureka!” Natasha whispered, her eyes widening in epiphany, as she ran down the narrow stairs to the study.

As Wiley caught up to her, she pointed to the large work of art across from the office desk. “Look! The Five Wounds of Christ.”



Natasha hurriedly snatched a writing pad and a pen from the desk. “The letters in this palindrome are hiding another meaning!” Natasha shouted, her voice quivering.

She wrote out each letter:

“SATAN, TER ORO TE REPARATO OPES. Satan, I bid you thrice: Return my treasure!”

Wiley turned white. “Unbelievable. This man really is the Antichrist.”

“Grant told me that he told you everything, and even though outwardly you seemed skeptical, he sensed that you believed. Now, I’m sensing that you believe. We need to start calling this man by his name. His name isn’t Francis, he is the man known to the world as Korah the Rebel”.

Wiley put his hands on his hips and stared at the magic square. Natasha cracked her knuckles and stared at the paintings. There was something else nagging at her. The magic square seemed so full of surprises. First, the double paternoster cross, then this satanic anagram. She shook her head. As hard as it was to believe, she felt as though she was being guided to believe that it would bear out one final clue. To think so wasn’t logical, but the influence upon her mind was pervasive, and she recognized that she was being influenced.

The Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse. White horses and black horses. Of course. The thought seemed to come from nowhere, and unrelated, but the Apocalypse is what we're dealing with.

She ran across the room and took a knight from a chessboard and held it up to the magic square. Starting at the letter O, she moved the knight over the letters as if in a game of chess. She read the letters out loud as she went. Wiley wrote them down, as she called them out:

“O R O T E P A T E R O R O T E P A T E R”

Natasha turned to Wiley, took the writing pad from him, and translated it out loud. “Oro te Pater, oro te Pater. I beg you, Father. I beg you, Father.”

She circled the unused letters and showed Wiley. The leftover letters spell the Latin word SANAS, which means, “You heal.”

Natasha puzzled over the clue. *Father, we beg you. You heal. Of course, it was clumsy, but what did it mean as far as being a clue for where to start looking for Korah's lost treasure room? What did this phrase have to do with anything? Did it play off of any of the other palindromes?*

Natasha remembered the Fountain of Hagia Sophia. A sophisticated Greek palindrome was inscribed over the fountain. She pulled out her phone and opened the memo she had copied it into. “NIPSON ANOME MATA ME MONAN OPSIN.”

νιψον ανομη ματα μη μοναν οψιν

Natasha focused her thoughts. *The palindrome translated “wash your lawlessness, not only your face.” But it was inscribed over a fountain, wasn't it? Yes! Of course, in Biblical times the sick would go to the fountains and beg to be healed. What else?*

Natasha hurried to the bookshelf, pulled out an atlas, and opened it to Turkey. She pointed down at the map of Istanbul.

“Since the beginning, I've felt that Istanbul has some significance to this whole mystery. Here we have an ancient fountain with a sophisticated palindrome, and another where the sick would go to be healed by God. I also had a dream that I was scuba diving with Father

Elijah—he had an artifact and a treasure map. I remember seeing an underwater cityscape with vast domed structures and medieval towers. In the dream, I thought it was Atlantis, but now I know it was Istanbul.”

Natasha’s eyes widened. She hurried back to the wall of books and her eyes rapidly scanned it. She pulled out a huge art book and rapidly flipped pages until she came to the painting she was thinking of—another painting of the Ark of the Covenant. It depicted the Ark on a giant flat rock in the middle of a wheat field. At the base of the Ark were six golden rats.

“Look! When the Philistines took possession of the Ark from the Israelites, they were cursed with a plague of rats and disease. The Philistine priests believed the source of the plague was the Ark. Hoping to stop the curse, they returned the Ark to the Israelites, leaving it to them in a field with six golden rats as an offering to the God of the Israelites.”

“Now clear your mind, Commander.”

“All clear.”

“What do you think of when I say the phrase ‘Plague of rats’?”

“The bubonic plague.”

Natasha nodded her head. “The bubonic plague started at the docks of Constantinople right around AD 538.”

Natasha pulled another volume from the shelf and opened it on the desk. She flipped through the book, found the passage in Greek, and translated it aloud.

“In the first Holy Crusade in AD 533, the Byzantine Belisarius seized the treasure from a royal ship fleeing the Algerian harbor of Hippo Regius. It was then shipped to Constantinople, the capital of Byzantium. In AD 534, Emperor Justinian brought the Vandal king into Constantinople. The historian Procopius of Caesarea clearly describes the treasures of Jerusalem being paraded at the head of this triumph.”

Natasha looked up at Wiley. “Everyone in Constantinople who knew about the secret location of the Jerusalem treasures died from the plague. Even Emperor Justinian was not immune. The only clues to the treasure’s location are these Greek palindromes.

Wiley was bent over, looking at the book. He straightened out and stretched his back.

“This all leads you to believe that the lost Jerusalem treasures are hidden somewhere in modern Istanbul?”

“Yes,” Natasha answered. “And Istanbul is where Francis has taken the Holy Father. They are there. I know it!”

Wiley put his hands together and rested his chin on his fingertips. He shook his head negatively. “This is an impossible situation, Natasha. Our diplomatic ties with Turkey are strained at best. Shall I call their ambassador and tell him that the Holy Father was kidnapped by the Vatican Secretary of State, whose true identity is the immortal Korah the Rebel, in order to help him on his quest for a magic wand so he can become the Antichrist? It sounds crazy.”

Natasha looked down at the floor. It did sound crazy. And what would even sound crazier would be this business about the Ark of the Covenant.

“Natasha, we can’t send our army in there either. It would violate international law.” Wiley pulled an asthma inhaler from his pocket and held it up for Natasha to see. “The Holy Father is far from immortal. He could die without his medicine. A dusty city like Istanbul, I don’t even want to think—If the Holy Father has been kidnapped and taken to Istanbul, you will have to save him. I will support you from here in any way possible.”

Natasha took the medicine and tucked it into her pocket.

“Please book me a commercial flight right away. The Vatican’s jet is too high profile. It would make the news in Istanbul and take away my only advantage—the element of surprise.”

“Absolutely, Natasha! If anyone can do this, it is you. May heaven help you. Go and Godspeed!”

CHAPTER 66

Alexei met Natasha at Istanbul International Airport. Natasha explained her theory to him as his driver shuttled them through the city's nightscape on the way to Hagia Sophia.

Natasha looked ahead through the windshield. The temple glowed; its mega-domed structures and tall, narrow towers seemed almost extraterrestrial. She wondered whether Emperor Justinian could ever have imagined the temple lit up at night.

"Those hooligans!" Alexei whispered hoarsely. "Wiley sends you here all by yourself."

"Not exactly," Natasha explained. "He gave us an unlimited budget—and if we confirm the exact location of the Holy Father, he will send an incursion of Swiss Guard."

"He should have sent some with you right now."

Natasha looked out the window. The neon street signs glowed on her face, blue, then green, then red. The street lamp's glow cast crimson across the faces of Natasha and Alexei, illuminating the pages of the Bible in her hands. Natasha flipped the Bible to the book of Revelation and read it aloud.

"And they gathered them together to the place called in Hebrew Armageddon."

CHAPTER 67

The van stopped in front of Hagia Sophia, and Natasha and Alexei climbed out. Natasha pulled on her backpack and gazed at the moonlit wonder. The windows that ringed its dome cast out dim light, and its enormity eclipsed the starry night sky.

Natasha ran to the fountain, and Alexei followed. It was a short run through the gardens to the fountain. Natasha stopped in front of it. The garden and the fountain were dimly lit by landscape lighting, but the atmosphere was filled with shadows. She slung off her backpack and pulled out one of four emergency flares taken from the van's roadside emergency kit. She struck the flare alight and handed it to Alexei, who then aimed its light at the amazing palindrome inscribed across the fountain.

Natasha gazed, waiting for inspiration. She flipped open her phone and wrote down the proverb with the English translation underneath of it.

Nipson Amone Mata Me Noman Opsin
Wash your sins not only your face

She stared at it. She felt helpless, but hopeful. *What is it? What am I missing?*

“Alexei, what if instead of one reading it from left to right, one started reading it in the center, and then out in both directions? In this case, only the second half of the proverb would be read, but it would be read twice.”

She took the flare from Alexei and used its burning red tip as a pointer. “Begin reading at the T in the center.”

νιψο νανομ ημ α τ α μη μοναν οψιν
ecaf ruoy ylnō ton <> not only your face

Alexei translated, “Not only your face, not only your face.”

“If this is the right way to read the clue, then it’s being repeated twice for emphasis.” Natasha surmised.

Alexei took back the flare and shone it on the inscription. “Maybe you are correct, Natasha. Just like you said earlier. The proverb is preserved within the palindrome, but a secret clue is within the proverb.”

Natasha stared at the fountain. *So why is it telling me this at the fountain? Because at the fountain, one would normally wash one’s face. But the “Not only your face, not only your face” is directing me to fully immerse myself. Not only my face, but my whole body.*

“We’re at the fountain. The ‘not only your face, not only your face,’ is a command for full immersion to wash the sins. It’s directing us to the larger body of water.”

Natasha pointed to the Basilica Cistern. She flung her backpack around her shoulders and ran toward its entrance. Alexei ran beside her, the flare in his hand streaking a red glowing trail. “Alexei, since the cistern is a hundred times larger, it’s much more appropriate to be fully immersed in.”

“Not only that,” Alexei answered. “The Emperor Justinian baptized his army in the Cistern. Baptized by full emersion.”

They reached the entrance, and Alexei shone the flare to illuminate the inscription over the enormous doorway. Natasha thoughtfully pondered the words. It was also a palindrome. She wrote it out the same way as she had the other and showed it to Alexei.

“It translates ‘Whoever you are, let the law be your guide.’ But if we read the clue out of it, as in the last one, starting at the center and reading it out in both directions, it repeats the phrase, ‘The Law be your guide, the Law be your guide.’

ΓΟΝΙΟΚΑ ΤΕ Χ ΕΤ ΑΚΟΙΝΟΣ
Ediug ruoy eb wal law be your guide

“What law?” Alexei asked.

Natasha smiled. “The Law of Archimedes. That’s what law?”

Alexei looked puzzled. “The law of buoyancy?”

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“It’s the only law that I know of that has anything to do with a place like this. A place entirely dedicated to the collection, treatment, and distribution of water. What other law has anything to do with water?”

Alexei didn’t have an answer, and Natasha felt relieved. She smiled and took a deep breath. *This idea of a secret chamber feels right. But is it right? Or is this your overactive writer’s imagination? There’s only one way to find out.* She grasped the door handle and pushed her weight into opening it, but it didn’t budge. The door was locked.

Alexei pulled out his army multi-tool knife and brandished it toward Natasha. “Tough soldiers no longer having use for tweezers and toothpicks in their knives.” He pulled out the tweezers, bent back the thin metal, and slid the slender end into the lock. He applied a clockwise torque while simultaneously slipping the hooked end of the toothpick. He pushed up the tumblers within the lock while maintaining clockwise pressure. “These things from a pocket knife are the soldier’s lock-picking instruments.” He pushed up the final pin, and the lock turned over. Alexei pushed the tweezers and toothpick back into their respective slots and kissed the knife. “Big thanks to army knife,” he said and swung open the door.

Natasha entered first, shining the flashlight ahead to the stone stairway that led down to the pool. The cool, humid air smelled musty. No theatrical lights, no eerie music, as when she toured with Grant. No tour guide, no chattering of tourists, or shuffling steps. They stepped down the stairs in ghostly silence.

At the bottom of the stairs, they walked to a far corner near the edge of the cistern pool. Alexei held the flare up to light the area. Natasha crouched down. She pulled her cell phone out, placed it in a plastic bag, and tucked it into her hip purse along with her pistol and the asthma inhaler. “Take whatever you can with you in your pockets. We’ll definitely need your knife, the three flares, and the duct tape. Natasha handed Alexei the tape. He squished it flat and pocketed it.

The flare burned down to its end. Alexei placed it onto the stone floor before it burned his fingertips. He pulled out the second flare, struck a light, and stuffed the two remaining flares into his beltline.

Natasha looked at Alexei in his priestly robe. The flare cast a red, flickering glow, and Natasha almost laughed at the thought that he looked like some kind of absurd comic-book hero. She realized that she also looked just as unusual, dressed in a black, skintight athletic shirt and black skinny jeans.

“Are you ready?”

“Da, pashlee! Yes, let’s go!”

“Follow me.”

Natasha took the flare from him. She pivoted off the edge of the pool and submerged herself in the dark cistern waters. The maze of underwater marble columns was eerily illuminated by the flare's flickering glow.

Natasha took a deep breath and swam underwater to the far eastern side, surfacing twice for air along the way. At the corner, she waited for Alexei and caught her breath by leaning back and floating.

Alexei surfaced and rested for a few moments. Natasha took another deep breath and dived down. Along the bottom, the stones were enormous—one meter high, one meter deep, and 1.5 meters long. She searched for a bottom stone that would have some natural feature to grip.

Natasha felt a rush of adrenaline as she noticed one with the features she expected. The second stone in from the corner had two natural features that were conveniently spaced if their purpose was to serve as handles for the stone.

With the flare still in her left hand, she pointed to her eyes and then to the stone. She handed the flare to Alexei and placed both hands on the stone. She pushed down and felt the stone give ever so slightly. *Eureka!* She felt her heart skip a beat. *This is really happening. This is crazy.* She pushed down again and dislodged the buoyant stone just as she had visualized. She swung it open and swam into the secret chamber. Alexei followed behind her.

When Alexei came through, the flare lit up the area around them. She swam over to where the small underwater cavern became shallow. Alexei appeared a moment later, gasping for large gulps of air. He held the flare up and illuminated the chamber.

They stood in a subterranean cave. A terraced rock floor gradually stepped out of the water and then leveled out. Natasha looked up at a stalactite-covered ceiling. The light from the flare danced off the moist rock walls. She stepped up to the terrace and was amazed.

The room was stacked with unimaginable treasure. Gold coins, jewels, and all kinds of priceless artifacts, including hundreds of jewel-encrusted papal tiaras. She marveled as she panned around the room.

“Bolshna Moy. My God!” Alexei crossed himself. In the center of the room, an empty pedestal demanded their attention—at its base were six golden rats.

Natasha pointed to it. “The Ark was here! They’ve taken it.”

Alexei was mesmerized by the immense treasure.

Natasha noticed a dark hole where the light did not reflect off the walls. It was clearly the primary entrance and exit. “Come on! We don’t have any time!”

“He already has the Rod of Aaron and the Ark! What can we possibly do?” Alexei asked despondently.

Suddenly, red sores appeared across Alexei’s hands and face. He looked at the disease on his hands.

“Bolshna Moy! Francis has initiated the plague of sores—a third of mankind will die!”

Natasha looked at him and fought the emotion welling up inside. Swallowing her fears, she laid calm hands on him and cradled his head in her palms. “The question is not ‘What can we do?’—it is ‘What must we do?’ All of heaven is on our side. We must have faith.” She told him.

Alexei visibly summoned his courage and nodded affirmatively. He threw the remnant of the flare into the water, ignited the third flare, and handed it to Natasha.

“You lead the way, my dear. I am to be right behind you.”

“All right then! We must hurry!”

CHAPTER 68

Natasha ran down the stone corridor. She heard the voice of Francis—at first just barely, then louder and louder. There was the sound of cheering and applause, and then the voice of Francis again. “We will do what God either will not do or cannot do! We will save the earth from mankind and mankind from himself!”

A thunder of applause echoed down the corridor. Natasha reached the end and looked forward to the empty space lit by the flicker of torchlight. She extinguished the flare. The voice of Francis and the sounds of a cheering crowd emanated from below. She was at the top of an ancient auditorium. She snuck into a balcony-like area and looked down.

The audience circled around in the balconies 360 degrees, each level higher and farther from the center. The audience looked like it was made up of 200 or more cardinals in crimson capes. The costumes were not modern, but rather styled after some earlier versions that Natasha did not recognize.

Francis stood at the center stage at the lowest point, draped from head to foot in pearl white pope’s attire; on his head, he wore a magnificent triple crown. In his right hand, he waved the sapphire Rod of Aaron.

The Ark of the Covenant lay showcased center stage and, off to its right side, Andre Saracini, the man known to the world as Pope Luke, was laid out on an altar as a spectacle—powerless and fighting for his life with every asthmatic wheeze.

Alexei caught up to Natasha and looked down.

“The rebels of Korah!” he mouthed silently. “The Rod of Aaron must stay in close proximity to the Ark, or they will perish.”

Francis continued his speech. His voice boomed powerfully with the tone and tenor of a motivational speaker.

“The plague will destroy a third of mankind, but two-thirds will live. The human race is ready for our leadership. They will see clearly that only a world united in common cause can reverse catastrophic global climate change.” Another round of cheers and applause thundered.

Alexei looked up at Natasha and quietly quoted, “Exodus 4:17.

**Take this rod in your hand so you can perform
miraculous signs with it.”**

God told it to Moses. We must take the Rod of Aaron from him somehow.”

Natasha knew he was right. According to legends and ancient texts, the Rod was a relic from the original tree of life. It had power all on its own. This was demonstrated when Moses threw down the rod in front of Pharaoh, and it became a serpent. Pharaoh’s priests attempted to match the miracle by throwing down their rods, which also became serpents, but the serpent that was the Rod of Aaron, subdued the other serpents and swallowed them.

Natasha crouched low to where Alexei sat, leaning against the wall. His face was covered in sores, and his sweat-drenched neck reflected the torchlight. He breathed in raspy, phlegm-tattered breaths.

Alexei struggled to speak. “Where two or more are gathered, there I will be,” he quoted the words of Jesus Christ and performed the sign of the cross.

Natasha repeated Grant’s words, “That’s the power of intercessory prayer; pray unceasingly.”

Natasha held Alexei to her bosom and looked upward, tears streaming down her face. She cried out in a hoarse whisper, “Jesus! Please forgive me. I now realize I’ve kept you distant all these years. I substituted true faith with a shallow academic experience and an intellectual religiosity that truly was the opposite of faith. But I know you have begun a work in my heart, and I feel blessed to have also felt your spirit of love and witnessed your miracles. I do believe in you! Please Lord, draw close to us now in our time of need. In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, save us!”

Natasha whispered into Alexei's ear, "Don't you die on me. Don't you dare!" She placed him carefully on the ground and looked down at the altar. Barring a miracle, the Holy Father would die without his medicine. Curled in a fetal position, he was unable to utter a prayer to save even his own life.

If I throw the inhaler, it would take a miracle for him to catch it. He's an old man in a weakened state—about to pass out from lack of oxygen.

In her mind's eye, she envisioned the inhaler hitting his fingertips and cruelly bouncing out of his grasp and onto the floor.

Natasha thought of an idea, reached into Alexei's robe, pulled out a roll of duct tape and a pocket knife, and used the supplies to quickly construct a rope. She secured the pocket knife to one end of the rope to give it enough weight so she could leverage centrifugal force for maximum casting and grappling-hook-like function.

"God help me!" she breathed as she lassooed the chandelier.

An instant later, she jumped off the balcony and swung down, dismounting next to Pope Luke and administering his life-saving dose of medicine.

An uproar sounded immediately. Natasha struck her final flare alight and waved it in her left hand. She pulled the pistol out of her hip bag and aimed at the encircling immortals in an effort to guard Pope Luke.

Pope Luke breathed another life-giving breath and stood on top of the altar, his long silver hair windswept and his deep blue eyes burning with the power of the Holy Ghost. The hum of angelic voices flooded the room and filled the atmosphere.

Andre Saracini, known to the world as Pope Luke, summoned all of his vitality and boldly commanded, "In the name of the God of Israel and of Isaac and Jacob, and in the name of Jesus Christ and of the Holy Ghost and in the name of the God of the souls of all mankind and as the representative of Christ on Earth, I rebuke Satan and his angels and cast them down into the bottomless pit. And I command that the spell of immortality be broken upon the fallen Korah and upon his band of

rebels. By the power of the almighty God you are cast into eternal darkness.”

Natasha looked at the beings that filled the cardinal costumes and watched as they burst into piles of dust.

Francis waved the Rod of Aaron and shot a blue, laser-like force field that protected him and the remaining fallen beings. From where the Holy Father stood to where the blue field divided the room, the unholy beings continued to burst into dust plumes like a falling chain of dominos.

Francis pushed his open palm outward, extending the protective field farther. It covered some of the already perished rebels and revived their piles of dust into living beings once again.

Pope Luke pushed his right hand out to push back the blue barrier and shouted, “John 3:16: For God so loved the world that he gave his only begotten son, that whosoever believes in Him should not perish, but have everlasting life!”

The hum of angelic voices elevated to a higher pitch. Natasha looked around and saw beautiful and ghostly glimpses of angels shimmering like holograms of rainbow light.

She looked beyond the blue light barrier that shot out from the Rod of Aaron and focused as the rod shape-shifted into a monstrous, vicious serpent. The serpent opened its mouth wide, exposing two huge fangs and a split tongue that shot out of its mouth like a blue arc of electricity. In an instant, the serpent plunged its fangs into Francis' hand and shot him full of the poisonous venom of damnation and electrified his body. Blue fire shot out of his eye sockets, and his flesh evaporated under his skin. The rippling skin sucked in against his smoldering skeleton, and a moment later, he burst into dust. The serpent in his hand dropped to the ground and slithered to where Pope Luke bent down, picked it up by its tail, and it once again became the Rod of Aaron.

The remaining rebels and other followers of Korah burst into piles of dust like exploding kernels of popcorn.

Natasha turned her attention to Pope Luke. He looked at her with a warm smile and grateful eyes.

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“Thank you, Dr. Ashton!” He opened his arms and embraced her, and she embraced him in a gentle, reverent hug.

“Please, Holy Father, hurry.” Natasha led him up to where Alexei lay on the cold stone floor, his lifeless body covered in bloody sores. Natasha fell to her knees, held Alexei, and sobbed. It felt like she was holding her own father.

“Your Imminence, is there anything you can do?” She pleaded.

He reached down and caressed the top of her head. He held the Rod of Aaron out and knelt down next to Alexei. The Holy Father performed the sign of the cross and then slowly lowered the Rod to rest across Alexei’s forehead between his eyes and down the bridge of his nose. The Rod glowed blue, and the hum of angelic voices filled the air once more. A blue aura enveloped Alexei as the sores on his skin vanished. His chest hitched as he suddenly breathed in, and his eyes opened wide in surprise.

Natasha smiled down at Alexei and caressed his head. She looked up to Pope Luke. “Thank you, Holy Father!”

The Holy Father put his hands on the sides of her face and temples. She felt a radiant warmth flow from his hands into her body. He smiled down at her with loving eyes. “Thank you, my angel. Power-hungry tyrants—and even immortals disguised as mortals—have always aspired to conquer the Church from within. The Apostles Paul and John warned us of it, as you know. But the forces of good, holy, and pure have almost always prevailed. Most people don’t understand that the Church’s darkest times are the result of such attacks.”

Natasha smiled as he looked into her eyes. “Don’t worry about anything, my child. As the Lord Jesus once said, ‘The flowers don’t think about how to clothe themselves, yet they are clothed so beautifully. And the birds worry not about the next day’s food.’”

“Thank you, Holy Father.”

“Will you pray with me, Dr. Ashton?” He reached out with his arm and embraced her as he prayed. “Dear Lord Jesus. Thank you for your child, Natasha Ashton. Thank you for her genius and abilities, and for her loving heart. I pray for her well-being both now and for the future. Let your spirit always guide her and teach her the things that she should

know. And give her peace and answers to her questions. In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.”

As they stood up, the Holy Father kissed her on the forehead. “I am aware of the situation with your husband, and I know he is an innocent man. The Lord has already answered your prayers for him. He’ll be home as soon as they can process the paperwork, my dear.”

An incursion of Swiss Guards rushed in and surrounded them. Pope Luke addressed them, “This woman and this man saved my life. Please attend to them.”

Pope Luke turned to Natasha and gazed intently into her eyes. “Good-bye for now, my dear. You are in my prayers, and I am in your debt.”

As his entourage rushed him out he stopped momentarily, turned around, and waved goodbye, before disappearing as his wall of Swiss Guards closed ranks behind him and ushered him out of the stone chamber.

CHAPTER 69

It was a crisp, sunshiny, winter day in Seattle. Natasha marveled at the beauty and majesty of Mount Rainier. A fresh layer of snow blanketed the countryside, but the roads were clear and safe. Natasha had arranged the Hummer option with the car rental company. She felt safe and protected and enjoyed the ride back to Jerrell's Cove. She couldn't wait to get back home to reunite with Tom.

When Natasha entered her home, she was disappointed. The house was cold and empty. No Tom to greet her and hold her. Just then, her cell phone rang.

"Natasha? Jeremy Benton. Happy New Year!"

"To you, too. So, what's going on?"

"I'm at the Federal building right now. Tom is officially free. They're processing him right now. I'll have him home to you in a couple of hours."

"Oh, thank God." She smiled and looked upward to heaven.

"He'll call you as soon as he gets a chance."

"Great! Good job, Jeremy!"

"I don't think it was me, Natasha. Chalk it up to a miracle."

"Well. Thanks again anyway, Jeremy. You were really here for us when we needed you."

"See you soon."

"All right. Bye-bye." Natasha turned the heat up in the house and drove to the store. As she was shopping for groceries, Natasha sensed a familiar spirit. It was a happy spirit—it was the spirit of Father Elijah. She sensed him smiling at her and embracing her. She could picture his blue eyes. Natasha stood in the bread aisle, enjoying the moment. She consciously thought that she wanted to visit and leave wreaths at the gravesites of Father Elijah, Jim Worley, and Sheriff Darwood.

However, there was something else she felt like Elijah was trying to show her. He was trying to influence her to buy something else. It was something that had to do with the sign of the cross.

The sign of the cross, sign of the cross. To protect me from the evil spirits? No. For something else. I think I know what he's trying to get me to buy. She thought.

On the way home, Natasha stopped at the graveyard and laid the three wreaths. One for Sheriff Darwood, one for Jim Worley, and, lastly, she visited the grave of Father Elijah. "Thank you, Elijah. Thank you for inspiring me to a deeper spiritual journey and a closer friendship with Jesus. I'll never forget you."

Once at home, Natasha fired up the oven, turned on the radio, and began baking fresh cookies. The phone rang.

"Babe! It's me!" Tom announced. "I love you!"

Natasha burst into tears. Her voice momentarily locked. "I love you too, honey! So much!"

"I'll be home in less than an hour."

There was silence for a moment. Natasha was so overcome with emotion that she couldn't speak. She gulped and took a deep breath. "Can't wait, love. See you here."

"Okay. I love you, honey!" The line went dead.

CHAPTER 70

Natasha happened to be watching out of her living room window when Sheriff Green drove past on his way to meet with William Jaimeson at the Blair residence. She wondered what he was up to this late on New Year's Eve.

William Jaimeson waited for Green on the front porch of Doug's house. He rocked back and forth in a wicker rocking chair. He was eager to resolve this matter with Douglas one way or the other. A Secret Service agent stood guard two meters to William's left, diligently scanning the evening air for anything that could be a threat.

Green pulled up into the driveway and approached the front porch. The Secret Service intercepted him, but William called out to them to let Green alone.

"Congratulations, Mr. President. We're all so proud of you."

"Thank you, son. I am proud of you, too. Thank you for the fine work you are doing here at Jerrell's Cove and for your assistance this evening. As you can see, my chief of staff is nowhere to be found. His car's engine was warm four hours ago, but still no sign of him."

Green dangled the house keys. "Barbara O'Brian cares for Mr. Blair's home when they're out of town. I stopped by her place on the way here to pick up her set of keys."

Green said nothing more. He just opened the door and walked into the house.

Inside the house, the air was warm. "Mozart's Requiem" floated down the stairs and softly filled the room.

"The fireplace was burning four hours ago, too," William commented. "It was like Douglas was just here."

Green walked over to the fireplace and noticed a blemish on the mantel and scratched it with his thumbnail to see what it was. Suddenly, it was apparent to him.

"IN CIRUM IMUS NOCTE ET CONSUMIMUR IGNI"

was written in blood on the fireplace mantel. The blood was difficult to notice at first because it had faded color as it baked into the surface.

Green looked down into the fireplace, where a charred, melted syringe lay. The cremated remains of a human body smoldered.

Will had not yet approached the fireplace. He was standing back and observing the room as a whole.

Sheriff Green turned around. "Sir, I think I found Mr. Blair."

CHAPTER 71

Waiting for Tom's return seemed like an eternity to Natasha. She kept herself busy, but suddenly felt an impulse to check her voicemail. She discovered a missed message from Grant Nuby, from the day he had died.

"Natasha, it's Grant. I don't have very much time. I'm about to board this plane, and I don't think this will turn out well for me, but I had to call you to say goodbye. You have been a true friend. Please remember me well—that I was a good man. And there is something I must tell you about the killings at Jerrell's Cove. Isn't it suspicious how the murders seemed to be customized so conveniently to attract your attention? How many murderers leave bloody handwritten Latin Palindromes as clues to taunt investigators? Natasha, I know that I did not kill those men. The killer is someone whom you already know. Remember my advice. Stay positive, pay attention to your dreams, and always pray to Jesus. Good-bye."

Natasha looked around. The house seemed so empty, and Grant's message creeped her out. She couldn't wait for Tom to get home. She walked to the kitchen and put some water on to boil for hot chocolate.

She turned around to go back to her bedroom, and what she saw petrified her. Once again, she felt the most horrible sense of evil. Bright red, bloody letters spelled out one more palindrome for her.

AH SATAN SEES NATASHA

Natasha froze in pure terror, knowing that Satan was indeed watching her. She heard the bloodcurdling, high-pitched voice of Gilbert Carver as he appeared from behind the corner.

"Ah, Satan sees Natasha!" He taunted, smiling slyly.

He was hiding something behind his back. Natasha tried to think rationally. She knew a little about this man—actually, too much. If she

showed she was afraid of him, she would be like all the other women who had feared his grotesque appearance. Since childhood, he had suffered from the relentless progression of Proteus Syndrome, commonly known as Elephant Man's Disease. His head was a misshapen wad of dough; he was lumpy from multiple tumors growing all over his body.

As an adolescent, Gilbert suffered even more severely from ridicule as his parents forced him to attend public school despite his horrific deformity. At the age of thirteen, his deformity hit its peak. Natasha remembered him recounting in court how he was traumatized by the sight of his own mother vomiting from his appearance. She left him and his father the day after his thirteenth birthday.

"I did it for you," he whined in his high-pitched voice.

Natasha noticed he swayed like the demon she had battled in the library. *He was obviously controlled by the same evil, the demon that had also possessed Lucas Philip Renard, the killer of that poor girl Jeanette Downey.*

"Gilbert?" She addressed him.

"I did my research, Natasha. I made a mystery just for you—with special handwriting clues for you to solve. But you didn't guess it was me, did you?"

Natasha stared at him.

"Gilbert, what are you holding behind your back?"

Gilbert's face contorted, and, with a gruesome smirk, he brought forth from behind his back the severed head of Douglas Blair. His hand was buried deep in the remains of the neck and into the skull. A butcher knife protruded from the temple of the head. He grabbed the hair with his left hand and pulled the skull off of his right hand with a sickening sucking noise. "I needed to dip the pen into the ink jar." He held out his finger. "You want to play a game? I can chase you around the house with my bloody hand." He lurched toward her, sticking out his bloody finger.

"No, Gilbert!"

Gilbert pulled the knife out. "Too bad. We're going to play anyway." He cackled and started walking toward her. One of the tumors on his

head was bulging larger, and it seemed as though it was about to burst through his skin.

“Satan will give me a new life if I kill you! It’s the final task!”

“No, Gilbert. No. Please stop.” She commanded him.

Natasha backed toward the kitchen counter, hoping to grab a knife or another weapon. She didn’t want to underestimate his power, as she knew he was under demonic control.

She couldn’t find anything and ran out of the kitchen. She threw the Christmas tree down as she passed down the hallway.

“Ahhhh. Satan sees Natashal!” he chanted repeatedly. “Ah, Satan sees Natasha. Ah, Satan sees Natasha. Ah, Satan sees Natasha.

Natasha ran to the master bedroom and tried to lock the door, but the lock was glued shut.

“I hope it’s okay! I’ve made myself at home here the whole time you were gone.”

Natasha looked at her bed—it was messed up, and feces smears spattered the middle. *Like he craps in his sleep. She thought.*

Gilbert kept coming closer. He fought his way through the bedroom door. “You deserve to die, Natasha!” he hissed and swung the knife at her. “Don’t make it harder. Just kneel down on the floor, and I can make it painless.”

“No, Gilbert! No!”

Gilbert lunged at her. Smiling and chanting, he swiped at her again. Natasha tripped backward. Gilbert jumped on top of her and put the knife to her throat. Visions of Jeanette Downey’s final, terrifying struggle against Lucas Philip Renard flashed through Natasha’s mind. Jeanette had called out, but no help had come. Natasha is determined to fight back psychologically. Showing fear would only empower this entity. She had to be brave.

“Okay, Gilbert. Okay. I will give my life for you,” Natasha said as sweetly as she could. “You have had a difficult life, and I would like for you to have the chance for something better. Thank you for the opportunity to do such a good deed.”

Gilbert pulled the blade from her neck and sat up across her pelvis. The tumor over his left eyebrow was pulsating like a sack of about-to-hatch spider larvae.

“Just please. Make it fast and painless like you promised.”

Drool dribbled involuntarily out of his mouth and spilled off his chin.

“Stab me in the heart as hard as you can!” She instructed.

A sinister grin stretched across his lips. “Thank you, Natasha.”

He raised the knife like an axman about to split wood, holding the knife with both hands. He raised it over his head for maximum strength and velocity. A blue vein that went across his brow and into his tumor pulsed in sync with the tumor. As he raised the knife, the tumor erupted into a spitting volcano of pus, splattering Natasha’s face. She contorted in revulsion.

Gilbert swung the knife down at her chest. Natasha had no intention of letting him plant the knife into her heart. “Jesus help me!” She shouted and squirmed sideways. The knife was buried in her clavicle bone and stuck. Natasha puked violently into Gilbert’s face—a huge stream of forceful vomit. Gilbert recoiled, and Natasha pulled the blade from her clavicle. “This is for Katrina Dunlap and Jeanette Downey!” She roared as she swiped across Gilbert’s exposed throat like a tennis backswing. His head dropped down, blood bubbled down his neck, and he fell over sideways. The monster was finally dead.

Ek balleto kakas pneumatias!” Natasha screamed out the words of Jesus as he had cast out Legion. “Get out of here evil spirit!” She cried out in horror, frustration, exhaustion, and victory. She screamed out and cried in spasms. Crumpled on the floor and overwhelmed with trauma and the knowledge that she had helped save the world and avenged the murder of Jeanette Downey and Katrina Dunlap.

Natasha felt thankful and guilty and angry all at the same time, and she argued with God and sobbed until she hyperventilated. She shouted at God and Jesus. “Thank you for the victory, Jesus, but why weren’t Katrina and Jeanette saved too! Why God, why? Why were those innocent girls allowed to suffer even one moment? Why didn’t you save Father Elijah and Jim Worley? Why!”

THE PATERNOSTER IMPOSTER

Eventually, she caught her breath and composed herself. She remembered the sign of the cross as her thoughts turned to the crucifixion of Christ, and it felt as though God, in a way, was answering her cries. Hanging on the cross, Jesus comforted the man being crucified next to him, “Today, I will see you in Paradise.” Jesus had been tortured and murdered also. But then He rose again, giving hope to all mankind of life after death. As Natasha pondered the age-old question, “*Why does God allow suffering?*” She could only find comfort in her faith, that life on Earth is only part of the journey, and death is a portal to a new adventure. *Katrina, Jeanette, Elijah and Jim were surely all now on a new journey, a new mission: perhaps guardian angels of the Kingdom of Heaven.* This thought nourished some inner healing. As Natasha’s faith revived, at last, it seemed a burden had been lifted from her broken body. She crawled to the nightstand for her phone and dialed 911.

CHAPTER 72

Tom arrived home to a scene of ambulances, sheriff's cars, and Secret Service standing on the front porch.

When he walked in, the EMT was finishing the stitches. The wound had been extremely minor. Since the tip of the blade hit the clavicle, nothing more than the very smallest portion of the tip of the blade had actually punctured her skin. It was a miracle.

Natasha bolted to Tom and showered him with kisses. Tom lifted her onto his hips and spun Natasha in circles.

In that moment, Natasha didn't want to tell Tom about what had happened at the Vatican, or about her meeting with Kirov, or her fight with the demons, or how she figured out the PATERNOSTER encryption. She just wanted to hold him tightly and tell him one thing. She wanted to tell him what Elijah had revealed to her while she was in the grocery store, the thing about the sign of the cross. The sign of the cross was the result of her pregnancy test. Tears burst from her eyes, and she smiled widely as she whispered in his ear. "We're going to have a baby!"

Tears leaked from the corners of Tom's eyes as he held Natasha tightly. He smiled widely and kissed her on the lips. "Now, that's what I call a New Year's miracle!" Tom answered.

"If the baby is a girl, could we name her Jeanette?" Natasha asked.

Tom nodded in agreement. "And if it's a boy, we can name him Elijah." He added. Natasha smiled and shed more tears of joy.

CHAPTER 73

William Jaimeson arrived a short time later and asked her about Francis Charles. Natasha left out the parts about Francis being immortal and a possible fulfillment of Antichrist prophecies. Although she feared the dark potential of Jaimeson, she sensed that he was unaware of such potential. For the present, he was a charismatic leader focused on his altruistic agenda. For Jaimeson's part, he seemed genuinely disappointed and astonished at the news. He offered his condolences and, before he left, invited Natasha and Tom to his inauguration ceremony. Natasha and Tom agreed and made hotel and flight reservations for January 24th.

During the inauguration ceremony, a dove landed on Natasha's lap, startling both her and Tom. Natasha looked at its leg and saw what she expected—a message capsule. She opened the capsule and unrolled a short, handwritten note.

The audience was cheering. William Jaimeson was on his way up to the podium. Natasha pushed her glasses up the bridge of her nose and read the letter.

My Dearest Natasha.

I shall remember you forever. Please look in on Nicholas from time to time in my absence. I rescued him from an orphanage in Rimini, and he has always been the son I never had.

As for me, I'll be fine. As you can imagine, I have powers and wealth beyond comprehension.

You may henceforth refer to me as Korah.

Go in peace.

Natasha's heart raced and her mind swirled. She looked up again. William Jaimeson was swearing to protect and defend. Cameras were flashing in all directions.

Many people who attended the inauguration ceremony of William Jaimeson would later agree with Natasha's account; that Jaimeson's eyes glowed red in the moment he took his oath of office.

The End

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Joseph Nicholas is a world traveler, businessman and entrepreneur with real life adventures to draw upon for his storytelling. Over the years from missionary work teaching English and bible classes to guarding the US Embassy in Moscow to diving Caribbean shipwrecks to exploring Mayan ruins to coaching the ranks of one of America's Largest Banks, Joseph tucked away ideas and secret knowledge that eventually inspired the writing of his debut novel "The Paternoster Imposter."



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